

The War on Nostalgia

*What will it take
to end the myth of
the Lost Cause?*

By Clint Smith



The Atlantic

EST. 1857



Plus:

The Neglected
Origin Stories of
Black America

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Features

30

Whose Side Is Kavanaugh On?

Conservatives hope to weaponize his bitterness. Liberals are inviting him over for dinner.

By McKay Coppins

Red Cross workers counsel migrants aboard the Allegra. The cruise ship is one of nine vessels that the Italian government has used to quarantine migrants.

40

PURGATORY AT SEA

Off the coast of Italy, cruise ships are being repurposed as holding pens for migrants rescued from the Mediterranean.

By Ian Urbina

52

COVER STORY

The War on Nostalgia

The myth of the Lost Cause is passed down like an heirloom. What would it take for the truth to break through?

By Clint Smith

62

Estebanico's America

The story of Africans on this continent is longer and more varied than the version I was taught in school.

By Annette Gordon-Reed

Front

8
The Commons
Discussion & Debate

Dispatches

11
OPENING ARGUMENT
How to End Extreme Child Poverty
Buried in the latest stimulus package is a transformative approach to helping families.
 By H. Luke Shaefer and Kathryn J. Edin

16
SKETCH
Stacey Abrams Writes a Thriller
How she became a novelist—and what writing and politics have in common
 By Ayana Mathis

20
MATERIAL WORLD
Burn All the Leggings
What do you wear to the reopening of society?
 By Amanda Mull

24
POSTCARD
Elvis Reenters the Building
In rural Ohio, a performer bookends a year of struggle.
 By Tim Alberta

28
VIEWFINDER
Mother's Day
 Photo illustration by Tabitha Soren

Culture & Critics

70
OMNIVORE
Alison Bechdel's Spiritual Sprint
In her new memoir, the cartoonist runs, climbs, skis, and spins toward transcendence.
 By James Parker

72
BOOKS
The Opportunists
In Louis Menand's new study of Cold War culture, success owes less to vision and purpose than to self-promotion.
 By Mark Greif

76
The Arrow Paradox
 A poem by Mark Jarman

78
BOOKS
The Power of Refusal
New novels by Rachel Cusk and Jhumpa Lahiri explore women's struggle to withdraw and create.
 By Claire Dederer

82
BOOKS
What Richard Wright Knew
A previously unpublished novel reveals his bleak prescience about race in America.
 By Imani Perry

Back

86
FICTION
Bump
 By Morgan Thomas

96
Ode to My Flip Phone
 By James Parker

On the Cover

ILLUSTRATION BY
 RICARDO REY



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Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, Clint Smith confronts the myth of the Lost Cause. In his reporting, Smith spoke with people who would keep that myth alive. What would it take for them to finally acknowledge the role that slavery played in

American history—and the role that their Confederate heroes played in defending that institution? For the cover, Ricardo Rey rendered the Confederate flag as a melting symbol, its power slowly diminishing.

— Paul Spella, *Senior Art Director*

THE

Private Schools Are Indefensible

The gulf between how rich kids and poor kids are educated in America is obscene, Caitlin Flanagan argued in April.

paradise. I am certain that my school's first value (before boosting its capital or launching its graduates into the professional stratosphere) was and is learning, joyfully, for its own sake.

That, I think, is something rare enough to be worth preserving, something that would be hard to replicate, something to which more students, not fewer, should have access. It's not independence that is indefensible. It's inequity.

Abigail Sylvor Greenberg
New York, N.Y.

Flanagan's prescription against the ills of private-school excess leaves me scratching my head. Apparently, the solution lies in private schools "not only limiting the amount of money that individual parents can give, but also accepting that schools don't need to be showplaces. In order to become more equitable, they would have to become less opulent." In other words, the answer isn't to make public schools better, but instead to make private schools worse. In truth, the only way to tear down these elite schools would be to build up the competition: public schools.

Jake Alrich
New York, N.Y.

The schools Flanagan cites, with billion-dollar endowments and facilities and offerings rivaling those of many colleges, may reasonably be accused of perpetuating social stratification. However, the picture she paints is incomplete. She tars all independent schools with

Letters

A

As a public-school student in a district where 78 percent of our nearly 50,000 students are low-income, I find the facts in Caitlin Flanagan's article hard to hear

and even harder to ignore. The past school year has furthered the inequity between private and public schools. Again and again, public-school students are getting the short end of the stick. How can we compete with those who have been learning in person for slots at selective colleges that prioritize rich and legacy students? If private-school parents were really worried "that their kids will be emerging into a bleaker landscape than they did," they would enroll their children in public schools where their money and power can make a difference.

Izzie Kim
Sacramento, Calif.

In 2020, I graduated from an independent New York all-girls

school that is mentioned in Caitlin Flanagan's article. Many of the phenomena Flanagan observes were evident at my school. Yes, the parents had too much influence, especially donors. Yes, the capital campaigns were absurd. Yes, the people were fixated on elite-college admissions. And yes, there was structural racism. Change is badly needed there.

But my school was, to me and so many others, more than a "consumer product for the rich" or a means of guaranteeing future money and power. I transferred there in high school, and as a humanities lover coming of age in a STEM-centric, test-score-focused, preprofessional educational climate, I felt I'd stumbled into intellectual



the same brush, failing to mention or even imply the existence of numerous smaller and less influential independent schools serving crucial roles in the educational fabric nationwide.

Ed Carpenter
Portland, Ore.

As an alum of Sidwell Friends and a current public-school English teacher in an affluent suburban district, I found Caitlin Flanagan's article resonant. Like Flanagan, academic rigor dominates my memory of private education in the 1990s. However, memories of the good old days are mostly false—wealthy private schools have always cultivated elite status within their student body. This is nothing new: Schools for the rich create narratives to excuse their own existence and to reshape elite status into a social good (consider the ubiquitous language of leadership in private-school mission statements). What is new is that social-justice language is now a powerful mechanism for signaling elite status. This presents a paradox for well-meaning teachers and earnest students in private schools and affluent public schools. How can equity-minded teachers and students in elite enclaves develop a just model of education that avoids simply teaching students the progressive language that is now a prerequisite for entry

into the ruling class? Unmasking hypocritical parents, self-serving students, and disingenuous educators is easy. Teaching and learning real lessons of justice within fundamentally unjust institutions is very hard.

Brian Herrmann
Hull, Mass.

America Without God

As religious faith has declined, Shadi Hamid wrote in April, ideological intensity has risen.

I agree that “politics” are more divisive in the United States than they were during the 1937–98 period that Hamid harkens back to as the ideal. But that time was characterized by the systematic exclusion of everyone whose views differed more than marginally from the mainstream. Socialists, atheists, homosexuals, and minority races were all excluded from the “politics” that most were allowed to see.

The ending of that systematic exclusion is what we are seeing now. The divisions that exist and seem worse now were already there; the fact that we are seeing them and talking

about them means that we are moving closer to the realization of our “American creed.”

Matt Halterman
Lake Villa, Ill.

Hamid creates a false equivalence between what he calls “wokeism” and right-wing conspiracy mongering. “Woke” means no longer ignoring the inconvenient reality of life in America experienced by other people. Unlike the deluded right, “woke” people are responding to observable facts such as poverty, systemic racism, and oppression. If the reality-based left has given up religion, which often requires accepting claims that contradict or lack evidence, this isn’t “displacement”; it’s just consistent rejection of unsupported beliefs.

Richard Plevin
Novato, Calif.

SHADI HAMID REPLIES:

One might say that any revolution worth its salt takes its proper share of casualties, and that woke excess is the price to be paid for progress. But ending systemic exclusion does not, or at least should not, require this. If anything, the often superficial

politics of representation, the preoccupation with elite manners, and the focus on “canceling” individuals who diverge from orthodoxy all detract from systemic questions. Corporations have been eager to jump on the woke bandwagon precisely because they find such distractions useful.

Those most intent on upholding the new orthodoxy are white liberals who—not incidentally—are considerably less religious than Black or Latino Americans. In the process, they patronize people of color, assuming that all Latino, Black, and Arab people are part of homogeneous collectives, grateful for the effort expended on their behalf. Richard Plevin says that woke people are merely responding to “observable facts.” Yes, poverty, systemic racism, and oppression are facts, but reasonable people disagree on their proximate causes as well as what types of policy interventions help address them.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

Corrections: “How Special Ops Became the Solution to Everything” (April) stated that a special Israeli unit stormed a hijacked airliner on the tarmac in Entebbe, Uganda, in 1976, to rescue hostages. The hostages were in fact rescued from an airport in Entebbe. “Private Schools Are Indefensible” (April) stated that two-thirds of the winners of Princeton’s Sachs Scholarship over the past decade came from private schools. In fact, more than half did.

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HOW TO END EXTREME CHILD POVERTY

*Buried deep in the latest
pandemic stimulus package
is a transformative approach
to helping families.*

BY H. LUKE SHAEFER
AND KATHRYN J. EDIN

On August 14, 1935, President Franklin D. Roosevelt signed into law one of the most successful anti-poverty programs in the nation's history. The Social Security Act's old-age benefit was founded on a moral certainty: It was wrong that elderly Americans might suffer destitution when they were no longer able to work. The act promised that every worker would be able to count on support as they aged, however their fortunes might change. The program was contentious at the time, but

its passage was enabled by the rare circumstance of the Great Depression. The benefit for older Americans has expanded over time to become part of the basic infrastructure of American life. By one estimate, nearly 40 percent of all elderly people today would fall into poverty without it.

Buried deep in President Joe Biden's pandemic stimulus, the American Rescue Plan, is the seed of a similarly transformative government program. This program holds the promise of dramatically cutting child poverty and effectively eradicating its most extreme forms, nationwide. The expanded, fully refundable child tax credit sounds complicated, but the ideas behind it are simple, and its design has been tested in many other countries. It's based on the principles that children deserve the opportunity to thrive, and that money can help.

Biden's plan is to send money each month, in the amount of \$250 a child—\$300 for young children—to help parents cover rent or utility bills; buy underwear, diapers, or toothbrushes; pay for child care; save for college; or whatever else they need most. Biden's plan treats poor and middle-income kids equally: Except for those in families with the highest incomes, every child of a given age gets the same amount. This may be its most important feature. It neither stigmatizes the poor nor leaves them vulnerable to resentments about special benefits. It says, instead, that raising kids is difficult and expensive, and that government has reason to support parents in this work. This measure could prove to be a temporary anomaly during an unusual time. Or, if made permanent,

it could begin a new era in the fight against child poverty in the United States.

WE DESCRIBED THE previous era of poverty and anti-poverty policy in our 2015 book, *\$2.00 a Day: Living on Almost Nothing in America*. The book follows the lives of eight families trying to survive on cash incomes of \$2 per person per day. Most claimed government food assistance, and some had housing aid. Yet we found that much of their lives was consumed by the work of just trying to get by. Family members sold their blood plasma, helping fuel a growing, multibillion-dollar worldwide industry that has come to depend on the desperation of America's deeply poor. The families bounced from couch to couch, shelter to shelter, and sometimes adults traded sex in exchange for food or a place to stay. They needed cash for the rent or utilities, or for one more night in a motel. They illegally traded their food stamps for cash at 50 cents on the dollar. The money was needed to buy uncovered basic necessities such as toilet paper—or interview-worthy clothes that would offer the chance of landing the job that could get them to a better place.

The parents we met were trying to care for their kids on little more than pocket change. But they also saw themselves first and foremost as workers. Our data on families in poverty showed that most parents who slipped into a spell of \$2-a-day poverty had, in fact, been working and lost a job. Travis Compton worked at a fast-food joint until his hours were cut to zero when foot traffic slowed for the winter; when we met, his family was surviving on the little bit

of cash his wife, Jessica, earned from selling her plasma. Jennifer Hernandez was cleaning boarded-up, foreclosed homes on Chicago's South Side until the work made her so sick that she quit. And Rae McCormick had climbed into a truck she

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shared with family members to go to her job at Walmart when she found that the tank was empty. Her uncle had used up all the gas over the weekend. Her manager told her that if she couldn't make it to work that day, she shouldn't bother coming in again.

The number of families with children going for periods of time with virtually no cash income—\$2-a-day families—more than doubled after 1996; as many as 3 million children lived under those conditions in 2011 and 2012, at the height of poverty following the last recession. According to our research, this rise was linked to the welfare-reform law of 1996, which slashed America's cash safety net for families. That law dismantled a program called Aid to Families With Dependent Children (AFDC), itself a part of the same 1935 Social

Security Act that had created a benefit for the elderly. AFDC provided a safety net, but its structure created problems. It cut benefits for every dollar a recipient earned on the job, reducing the positive impact of work. Many recipients who got married saw their benefits reduced or eliminated. The program had become so stigmatized that even many recipients hated it. In 1996, lawmakers replaced it with the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program. TANF created strict work requirements and time limits for recipients, and its provision as a block grant encouraged states to reduce enrollment as much as possible and keep any leftover money to use elsewhere. That incentive led to other restrictive eligibility requirements, regulations, and sanctions that make it difficult if not impossible for families in need to get help.

What most thought was a "work first" welfare program turned out to be a slush fund for state governments. Michigan, for instance, uses far more of its block grant to fund college scholarships (whose recipients include middle-income kids) than to provide cash aid to very poor families. Many states have become completely dependent on TANF dollars to plug holes in their budgets across numerous programs.

After the 1996 reform, the number of beneficiaries receiving cash welfare fell, from 14.2 million in 1993 to 2.9 million in 2019. There are now millions more postage-stamp collectors in America than there are welfare recipients. In multiple states in 2019, the case-loads were virtually zero. Cash welfare through TANF has continued to shrink during the coronavirus pandemic, falling

to 2.7 million recipients as of September 2020. The program's nonresponsiveness to one of the greatest economic crises of modern times is a testament to its practical and moral failure.

But as TANF floundered, something unexpected happened: Policy makers came together to build a cash-based social safety net, the likes of which the country has never seen. They expanded unemployment assistance to low-wage workers and those in nontraditional jobs, such as contractors and gig workers, who don't typically qualify for unemployment insurance.

They sent stimulus payments to low- and moderate-income families. Even families with zero earnings in the previous year were eligible for the stimulus payments, families like those we profiled in *\$2.00 a Day*. In this way, the federal government has sent tens of billions of dollars in cash—more money than the entire annual budget of TANF—to poor families since the crisis started. And while cash welfare was always largely disliked by the American public, stimulus payments have proved wildly popular, perhaps because the middle class has received them too. According to a poll taken at the end of January, nearly eight in 10 Americans were in favor of the \$1,400 payments proposed in the American Rescue Plan. Another poll found that even a majority of Republicans favored them. And the evidence indicates that this approach has worked as well as anything we've ever done: All told, families with children have been far better protected during this downturn than during any that came before.

These payments, of course, are temporary. But Biden's

expanded child tax credit, passed in March and targeted directly at children, seems likely to be just as popular, and could form the basis of a permanent program. The full payment of \$3,600 each for children under 6 and \$3,000 each for

the credit to be paid monthly starting in July, but the IRS could delay that or make payments less frequently. The program has been approved for one year of funding. Unless it is made permanent, it will disappear in 2022.

exact same purposes, but they can also ensure that the rent is paid and the lights stay on, or buy diapers or school supplies.

Despite the program not being targeted only toward low-income kids, our colleagues at Columbia University estimated



all other children is the same for everyone below a certain income—\$75,000 for a single filer and \$150,000 for joint filers. Some administrative details are still being worked out; congressional champions intend for

When they start to receive the benefits, middle-income families will be able to use the money to pay for child care or after-school programs, to save for college or buy books. Poor parents can use it for the

that a child tax credit comparable to Biden's would cut child poverty by 45 percent. It would cut poverty among Black children by 52 percent and among Native American children by more than 60 percent.

THE IDEA BEHIND the child tax credit isn't new; scholars and some Democratic members of Congress have been talking about the promise of just such a policy for a long time. We joined the ranks of advocates for a "child allowance" after we published our book, as we continued to think about the best ways to help parents like Travis and Jessica Compton, Jennifer Hernandez, and Rae McCormick. It seemed obvious to us that the poorest families in America still needed the cash safety net that had been dismantled by welfare reform. Yet we also didn't think the nation should return to the flawed program that existed before welfare reform.

The expanded child tax credit is a different animal from the old cash-welfare system. It has been built to avoid the pitfalls of the era before the 1996 law, and of the decades since. It is pro-work, because families don't lose the aid by working until they reach the highest income levels. It is pro-family, because poor and middle-income kids keep the benefit even if a parent gets married, unless their spouse has a high income. It is pro-child, because it treats poor and middle-class kids exactly the same. Rather than stigmatizing families, it sends a message that our society acknowledges the hard work of parenting and says, *We're here to help.*

Plenty of evidence from other countries shows us that the benefits of an expanded child tax credit can be sustained. The United Kingdom adopted a new child tax credit, among other poverty-reduction programs, in the late 1990s and saw its child-poverty rate fall by 50 percent. Canada

greatly increased its child benefit in recent years and also saw its child-poverty rate fall dramatically. Some legislators worry that families will make bad choices with the cash, but evidence from Canada suggests that families reduced spending on things like alcohol and tobacco when they received child benefits, which supports the theory that substance use is sometimes a response to financial stress. Some legislators also worry about the cost of an expanded child tax credit—more than \$100 billion a year. The amount seems high, but it is quite a bit less than we spend on health insurance for low-income families, the elderly, and individuals with disabilities through Medicaid. It's also hundreds of billions less than the yearly costs of child poverty to our country—arising from health-care costs and lost productivity, among other factors. A large and growing body of evidence concludes that in the long run, the returns on this investment will far exceed the expense.

Child benefits in other countries have not led to a reduction in work; some analyses suggest that such a benefit could increase work among some parents. That's the beauty of its design—unlike in the old welfare system, a poor family doesn't lose benefits as their earnings increase. (There's also not much evidence from other countries that a child allowance induces people to have more children. Having more babies to build the workforce wouldn't hurt in the U.S., given its low fertility rate, but the child allowance probably isn't going to help much on that front.)

One of the most important features of the child tax credit is its periodic payout. The

federal government already helps low-income working families through the tax code, but that help is delivered in a lump sum at tax time, mostly in the form of the earned-income tax credit and a limited child tax credit that leaves the poorest families out. This lump sum can help families make big investments and plan for the future. But many

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poor families experience huge swings in income from week to week and from month to month, because of instability in jobs or family life. This means that a stable source of regular income is important.

The expanded child tax credit could effectively eliminate the kind of \$2-a-day poverty that motivated our book. Rae McCormick could have used cash from the child benefit to put gas in her truck and keep her job. Then she might have avoided a fight with her uncle, which led her and her daughter to move, yet again, further destabilizing their lives. Jessica Compton might have used her child benefit to pay for basic necessities rather than resorting to selling her plasma

twice a week. Or maybe she could have gone down to selling plasma one time a week to save her body from some of the strain. Jennifer Hernandez might have used the money to keep her family afloat while she recovered from illness. Their problems would not have all disappeared because of a few hundred extra dollars a month, but the money would have made a big difference. It would have provided a foundation to build on.

The Biden administration has taken the first step into a new and profoundly different future. The debate about the permanency of this new program has already begun in Washington. The moral case for continuing the program is unassailable. We would do well to ensure that the lessons we've learned during COVID-19—about mutual vulnerability, structural inequity, the value of cooperation, and shared dignity—are not fleeting. We have the ability to wipe away the most extreme forms of child poverty with a simple policy. Perhaps in so doing, we might create the kind of transformative change for families that our grandchildren can take for granted. *A*

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STACEY ABRAMS WRITES A THRILLER

How she became a novelist, what politics and writing have in common, and why, at the end of every good story, someone's got to die

BY AYANA MATHIS

On the afternoon of my first conversation with Stacey Abrams, she had just moved house. She sat in front of a bay window, sunlight pouring in around the sides of drawn blinds. We were talking over Zoom, and the little square of our interaction was spare and tidy—that is, until she turned her camera around to show me a long, rectangular table crowded with things that hadn't yet found a home: an open box, an orphaned white vase, a pile of books. In the stack sat biographies of Booker T. Washington and James Madison and, she said, “a book about butterflies.” Why butterflies? “Well, it’s about how butterflies are part of the ecosystem that we rarely think about. Much like bees, when we had the bee-colony collapse.”

I wouldn't have guessed that Abrams had bee colonies on her mind. It was early March, and Georgia lawmakers had recently proposed a raft of new voting restrictions that Abrams would later describe in a tweet as “Jim Crow in a suit + tie.” Abrams is, of course, best known as the standard-bearer in the battle against disenfranchisement in her home state of Georgia and around the nation, and the founder of two voting-rights advocacy organizations: Fair Fight Action and the New Georgia Project. In 2018, she became the first Black woman to run for governor in any state as a major party's nominee, but she narrowly lost the general election

to then—Secretary of State Brian Kemp, whose office had purged nearly 700,000 voters from the rolls in the preceding two years. After her loss, she doubled down on her long-game strategy of registering and mobilizing hundreds of thousands of Georgia voters—an effort that is now credited with helping flip the state blue, sealing victories there for Joe Biden and Senators Jon Ossoff and Raphael Warnock.

But threats to our democracy weren't the focus of our chat. We'd met to talk about an Abrams many don't know: Stacey Abrams the novelist. In addition to two nonfiction books—*Lead From the Outside* and *Our Time Is Now*—she has published nine works of fiction. Eight are romance novels, written under the pseudonym Selena Montgomery; her new political thriller, *While Justice Sleeps*, is the first novel to be released under her own name.

I am embarrassed to admit that I came to my conversations with Abrams assuming that her novels were a diverting side hustle, the product of whatever corner of her mind is home to whimsy and all things nonpolitical. I was wrong. Sure, the novels are a whole lot of fun, page-turners in which love and the good guys win. But they're far from peripheral.

If Abrams is a skilled agitator and resetter of expectations, it is in large part because she has the capacity to imagine alternate realities, and the ability to bring the rest of us along. What's more, she understands this about herself. She's not self-aggrandizing, but she doesn't patronize with false humility, either. "I'm a good politician in part because I'm a very

effective storyteller," she told me. "In my world, these are of a piece. I just deploy them in different ways."

FROM THE BEGINNING, Abrams's parents immersed their six children in books and ideas. When she was growing up in Gulfport, Mississippi, her father, Robert, was a shipyard worker, and her mother, Carolyn, was a librarian at a college library. "I literally would sleep in the stacks," Abrams said. "We went to a preschool that was on campus. And when it ended, my parents couldn't afford babysitters. So they would just bring us over to the library."

I laughed and told Abrams that when I was a kid in Philadelphia, my mother couldn't afford child care either, so I'd take the bus after school to a branch library, where my mother would pick me up when she finished work in the evening. I'm a fiction writer myself, and a lifelong love of books took hold on those afternoons.

At the library, Abrams was allowed to read whatever she could reach—and she consumed books hungrily, including the encyclopedia and the dictionary. When the Abrams kids asked questions and their mother said, "Look it up," she meant it. (Among Abrams's five siblings are a biologist, an anthropologist, and a judge. The six have a monthly book club.)

Public schools in Gulfport varied widely by neighborhood, so Abrams's parents sought out the least expensive house to be had in one of the better school zones. Their focus on education paid off in the form of teachers who inspired Abrams, including one who

taught her Latin for two years and encouraged her interest in Greek, Norse, and Egyptian mythology. Abrams still says her name, Mrs. Carr, with gratitude and a hint of reverence.

Her experiences in school weren't all positive, however. One teacher gave her a C on a paper for using too many big words. Abrams was the only Black kid in the class, and the other students, this teacher

"I'M A GOOD POLITICIAN IN PART BECAUSE I'M A VERY EFFECTIVE STORYTELLER," ABRAMS SAID.

said, found her language off-putting. "She wanted me to write and speak differently," Abrams recalled. Instead, she stopped speaking in class altogether, and stopped handing in her work, too. It was a painful but formative lesson: If an arbitrary and unreasonable standard was set, she didn't have to accept it.

After her family moved to Georgia, Abrams remained an unconventional student, with a habit of snoozing in class. A nap during high-school physics proved particularly fateful. She dozed through a pop quiz, jeopardizing her academic standing, but her teacher allowed her to make up part of the grade with an extra-credit assignment. He was so impressed with what she

turned in—a paper on Mesopotamian astronomy—that he helped get it published in a scientific journal. "For a minute there I thought I was gonna be a physicist. Turns out I just like *Star Trek*," she deadpanned before growing serious. "I was a published author—a poor girl from Mississippi. It was just transformational."

Abrams carried this new identity with her to Spelman College, where she took a class with the playwright Pearl Cleage. The first of Abrams's novels wouldn't be published for many years, but Cleage's theories about drama appealed to Abrams's intuition that in writing, as in life, if the stakes aren't high enough, the story won't matter. "She said, 'At the end of the book, someone's got to die.' And what she meant was not that you had to kill a person, but an idea, a person, a theory, an emotion," Abrams explained. "If you end a book and there has been no consequence to everything that's happened, you have failed as a writer."

I confessed that my first literary agent had told me I was a disaster at plot. Get yourself a couple of Lee Child's novels, the agent advised me, and see if you can re-create a truly suspenseful first chapter. I couldn't do it. Still can't. Abrams gave a knowing smile. The thing is, she can.

RULES OF ENGAGEMENT, Abrams's first novel, was an espionage thriller. Or she intended it as such, but when she sent it to publishers, the book industry wasn't much interested in spy novels featuring (or written by) Black women. Abrams, then in her third year at Yale Law School, rewrote the novel so

her spies fell in love. The gambit worked, and the book was published in 2001.

Abrams's romances are racy, with titles like *The Art of Desire* and *Hidden Sins*. They contain sex, of course, and lines like this, from *Deception*: "Salty, strong, powerful, he filled her senses and stole her breath." Gorgeous ethnobotanists, celebrity lawyers, criminal psychologists, and fabulously wealthy international poker players mix it up with grifters, organized-crime types, and money-laundering bank executives. "Sometimes," Abrams told me, referring to her more unsavory characters, "you don't want to be responsible and respectable; you just want to have fun." Most of the protagonists are Black women, a rarity in the relatively white-washed realm of mainstream romance writing. Abrams is eager for Black women who read her books to encounter themselves in roles and places where they usually don't.

Abrams wrote most of her latest book while serving as minority leader in the Georgia State House of Representatives. What might happen, she wondered during lunch with a mentor in 2008, if a Supreme Court justice were permanently incapacitated but didn't die? Over the next few years, she spun this conceit into a legal thriller, but an editor who read the book in 2011 turned it down on the grounds that the villain, a megalomaniacal and corrupt U.S. president, was too awful to be believed. The manuscript languished on her hard drive. In 2019, when Abrams showed it to her agent, a bombastic president and an intense focus on the failing

health of a Supreme Court justice were all too real. This time, she had no trouble finding a publisher.

Abrams is a fan of John Grisham and Scott Turow, and in some ways *While Justice Sleeps* reflects the conventions of their genre. An irascible Supreme Court justice, Howard Wynn, is found unconscious and put on a respirator; Avery Keene, his law

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clerk and the novel's heroine, follows the baffling trail of clues Wynn left behind to guide her to his enemies. By the end of the prologue, she has been thrown into the deep end of a sinister conspiracy involving a deadly bioweapon.

Avery is a woman of color, with green eyes, corkscrew hair, light-brown skin, and a prominent nose. Abrams describes these as "complicated features"—that is to say, Avery's is a face that triggers an old, deep American anxiety about who is Black and who isn't. The character also has a complicated past, one that makes Avery especially vulnerable to the powers that amass against her: "The records indicated a dead father, a

drug-addicted mother, and the hint of a gambling habit."

The book is shot through with Abrams's eclectic and sometimes nerdy curiosities. The plot involves the foreign-investment law known as the Exon-Florio Amendment, the Lasker-Bauer chess strategy, gene-editing technology, and nasty fictional diseases that Abrams cooked up with the help of her younger sister Jeanine, the biologist. Secrets are stashed behind Robert Caro biographies.

A WEEK AFTER our first conversation, Abrams and I spoke again. Georgia's voting-restrictions bill had moved further through the state Senate; by the end of the month, it would be law, imperiling a decade of Abrams's work.

I asked how she navigates darkness. It was an imprecise question. What I really wanted to know was how she deals with evil, and whether the obstacles she encounters ever seem insurmountable. "There has to be darkness for light to be known, and there has to be hardship for joy to be real," she said without hesitation. "In my writing and in my real life, you're solving a pain."

In real life, politics is a slog: The big victories, spectacular though they may be, are a long time coming. Abrams's fictional worlds, however, are gratifyingly under her control. Bad people are punished for doing bad things; grave injustice meets satisfying resolution. If a main character wants to punch a rude, corrupt president in the nose, she does. "It's comforting to have a repository for the parts of you that you can't unleash, because you can't do your job if you do," she told me.

The storytelling skills that Abrams uses to write fiction are also essential to her political life; through narrative, she renders difficult, sometimes intimidating, political concepts compelling. "I can get you to listen to me talk about *tax policy*," she said proudly at one point. A tax lawyer by training, she is adamant that voters need to know more about the topic. In politics, "you tax the people you think can't fight back," she said. "You spend the money on those you're afraid of." At one of her regular town-hall meetings back when she was serving in the Georgia House, she recalls overhearing a conversation between a couple of her constituents. "One guy said, 'I hear she talks about *taxes*.' And the older gentleman said, 'Yeah, but she's not nearly as boring as you'd think she'd be.'"

The word *imagination* isn't much used in politics—it sounds too soft, I guess—but like love, it is a discipline. A mind that is rigorous about constructing plots is a mind that can make tax policy interesting. It is a mind capable of envisioning a blue Georgia, and willing it into being. Abrams has an anticipatory sense of reality, of what might be even though it is not yet.

Near the end of our final conversation, I asked Abrams if she was an optimist. "No," she said. "I am an ameliorist, which is something I made up. I believe that the glass is half full. It's just probably poisoned. And so my job is always to be on the hunt for the antidote." *A*

Ayana Mathis is the author of The Twelve Tribes of Hattie.

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BURN ALL THE LEGGINGS

What do you wear to the reopening of society?

BY AMANDA MULL

On a Friday afternoon in early March, I felt an urge I hadn't experienced in more than a year: I wanted to buy new clothes.

Outside clothes. Clothes in which I would be perceived, by others. Clothes to wear to a party. The late-winter sun had started to warm things up a bit, I was a week and a half removed from my first Pfizer shot, and those two facts combined to cause a flare of optimism so intense that I needed to express it in what has historically been my preferred manner of celebration: by buying some stuff on the internet.

The first order of business was remembering where I had bought my outside clothes before everything went to hell—ASOS? Madewell? Nordstrom? As I dug through my brain, past all the recipes and the opinions about lesser Netflix shows that

I had accumulated in the past year, I opened browser tabs. I was ready to be sold on the possibilities of the year ahead, and I wanted them to include sweaty crowds and recreational drugs and other people's hands. I wanted to take as many steps as I possibly could toward the person I might be by July.

For this foolish optimism, I was greeted with leggings. Row upon row of black leggings, and then some sweats, and matching sets of sports bras and (more) leggings, and finally, once I scrolled far enough, some sweaters and jeans that clearly had been hanging around for months. Not for the first time during the pandemic, I stopped to consider whether I was wrong about what month it was, or even what season. Fashion is an industry built on guessing what people will want to buy months in advance and serving it up to

them before they even realize they want it, yet everywhere I looked, there were no guesses at all about spring. Instead, there were hedged bets, of which leggings are the official garment.

The pandemic has been tough on many types of businesses, but particularly on those peddling clothes. In normal times, when people's lives change—when they start a job, end a relationship, move somewhere different—they buy new things to wear. But in the past year, we found ourselves with few occasions requiring new outfits, and even fewer requiring high heels or hard pants.

Sales took a nosedive, and what money was spent rewarded the brands that were pivoting to elastic waistbands. Tie-dye enjoyed a brief resurgence as people searched for activities they could do in the safety of their driveway. The most viral garment of 2020

was the “nap dress,” which is just a nightgown putting on airs. As adorning the body got boring, the fashion industry went from making billions of dollars a year predicting what people would wear in the future to anxiously studying what little clothing people were buying in the never-ending present.

But now Americans' lives are about to start changing again—profoundly, and outwardly. For some people, especially those of us lucky enough to have been able to work from home, parties and dates and social novelty of all types will be suddenly possible. Those who have lost loved ones or had a brush with mortality may have a particular urge to grab life with both hands. (This may be accompanied by an urge to look hotter while doing the grabbing; research finds that after intensely stressful life events, people are more likely to make big changes to their appearance.) All of which suggests that millions of people will soon be searching stores and their own closets for an answer to an unfamiliar question: What do you wear to reenter society?

PESTILENCE HAS a long history of influencing how people dress. The bubonic plague killed as much as half of Europe's population in the 1300s, leaving survivors with hefty inheritances and higher wages. Some historians credit the plague for sparking demand for finely tailored clothing and luxury goods—clothes became tighter, decorative features like buttons and fur trim became more common, people got really into grand headdresses. In this way, the plague gave rise to the Italian fashion industry, which still helps set global trends.

Later Europeans enshrined disease in their wardrobes a little more directly. By the end of the 18th century, Europe's tuberculosis epidemic had been thoroughly romanticized, the emaciation it caused reflected in the age's wasp-waisted corsetry. A century later, people became nervous that ground-dragging skirts kicked up filth and disease, and in the early 1900s, women began hitching up the excess material with handheld grips, which eventually led to shorter skirts and the beginning of the end of Victorian aesthetics.

But for historical clues about how Americans might dress after the pandemic, Valerie Steele, a fashion historian and the director of the Museum at the Fashion Institute of Technology, in New York, says that the most compelling comparison is probably to the Roaring '20s. That period followed an extended flu pandemic and the First World War, both of which had exhausted and disillusioned many Americans. "Young people were like, *This was just handled so badly. It was a debacle. How can you expect us to follow your rules?*" she told me. Sound familiar?

When the flu subsided, the country exploded into rebellion and exuberance. People danced to jazz and drank in speakeasies and smoked opium; the whole thing was unrepentantly lustful, a backlash against the sexlessness and deprivations of the preceding years, as well as against Prohibition, which tried and failed to head this hedonism off at the pass. Young women unlaced their corsets and opted for still-shorter hemlines. They didn't just reject the previous era's rigidity, though; they embraced

libidinous pursuits, adopting makeup techniques previously associated with sex workers and short hairstyles that could be more easily smoothed into place after an active 15 minutes in the back room of a club. People who had spent years of their youth staring into the abyss wanted to have some *fun*.

This pandemic's end might similarly light a fuse on a powder keg of frustrated desire.

Sexiness isn't the reputation-ruining taboo it was in the early 1900s, but it is fraught in new and different ways. As social norms around sexuality, consent, and gender have evolved at a breakneck pace in recent years, fashion has grown cautiously chaste, according to Lauren Sherman, the chief correspondent for *The Business of Fashion*. Trends have lately tended to obscure the

body with volume instead of finding freedom in its shape. "The way our culture has moved—I don't want to say it's become more puritanical, but it's become more politically sensitive," Sherman told me. "People have overcorrected because they don't know what is appropriate sexiness."

Even before 2020, sexual frequency in the U.S. was decreasing, and celibacy was



increasing. Add in a year of self-abnegation for singles and libido-killing co-confinement for couples, and we may well be looking at an unprecedented supply of horniness. Pop culture, in fits and starts, seems to be picking up on our looming lasciviousness. (See, for example, the biggest musical moment of the pandemic: the enthusiastic reception of “WAP,” Cardi B and Megan Thee Stallion’s gleefully raunchy ode to female pleasure.)

But for many people, the quest to act on that pent-up desire and once again feel like a sexual being has at least one big obstacle in its path: a year-long pileup of stress and isolation. Nichole Perkins, a writer and podcaster whose work frequently focuses on sex and relationships, told me she doesn’t know how to dress going forward. “I don’t want to say I’m dreading it,” she told me, sounding very much as though she was dreading it. “I am having a difficult time imagining getting back out there, especially as a single person getting back into dating.” These anxieties go beyond clothes, but clothes may be where they manifest most acutely. Do you remember what you used to wear to feel cute? Have those outfits retained their magic? Do they still fit?

In Perkins’s worries, I saw my own—so frequently in the past year, I have felt like a brain floating in a jar, disconnected from my corporeal self and its needs. I’m not sure when my body will start to feel like mine again, and not some alien thing my consciousness has to drag from room to room. The urge to shop feels, at least in part, like an effort to reconcile my physical alienation and the version of myself I need to be

in a couple of months. If I can figure out what I want to wear, maybe I can be a coherent person again. Or maybe, at the very least, I can get laid.

FOR THE LUCKIEST Americans, the past year has been marked by soul-deadening tedium and loneliness. For those who have lost jobs, homes, or loved ones to the virus, or have been pressed into dangerous working conditions, fear and grief have been more likely to predominate. The joy that might be possible in the near future for some people will, for many others, be disorientingly incongruous with the pain of the recent past.

Still, for people in both groups, the next few months will be a slow-rolling reunion. At last, I’ll get to see friends again, and I’ll also get to see the people I don’t like, which is nearly as thrilling. I feel the same mixture of anticipation and anxiety that I used to feel on the first day of school: The future is beginning! But, oh God, *the future is beginning*.

The comparison to the start of school is obviously imperfect, but our circumstances do have some of the essential characteristics that make back-to-school shopping so lucrative for retailers: Reuniting with your extended social circle after a lengthy disruption is as close to a clean slate as most people ever get. But even if others are as ready as I am to go shopping for cute new dresses, finding them won’t be as easy as an end-of-summer jaunt to the mall.

Four to six months ago, when most retailers were buying the inventory that populates stores right now, planners had little idea how vaccination efforts would unfold or

what frame of mind the nation would be in come spring, let alone summer. After an extraordinarily lean year, many of them were shy about taking on more risk. *The Business of Fashion*’s Sherman told me that over the winter, a number of brands and stores said warm-weather options would start popping

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up for purchase around May 1, months after they would normally fill retail racks. Others are choosing to play it safe by waiting even longer. (Fast- and ultra-fast-fashion brands such as Zara and Boohoo will be able to react more quickly to sudden surges in demand, because their infrastructure is built for short turnarounds—which FIT’s Steele worries will push even more business toward a sector of the industry rife with labor and environmental abuses.)

Further complicating efforts to predict the mood of the country, designers are as isolated as the rest of us. “Everybody in fashion has been in a real funk,” Sherman said. “There isn’t a ton of creativity there.” Top fashion brands, whose designs are often copied by mass-market retailers, have

stuck to playing the hits. And while some designers are clearly betting that the future will be more fun, or at least sexier—Givenchy’s most recent collection, for example, includes bralettes that lack fabric, serving not to cover but to frame the boob for viewers—others seem less sure. The French brand Celine, which is led by Hedi Slimane, a designer previously known for his ultra-sexy, ultra-glamorous aesthetic, is running an ad campaign featuring a model in a cropped logo sweatshirt, jeans, and a baseball cap.

As long as customers remain sequestered from the situations in which clothes matter, designers will be stuck making these sorts of weird, disparate bets on the future. People decide what they want to look like by being out in the world among their friends and colleagues, and seeing how the people around them dress. Maybe that’s why I’ve always liked clothes so much, and why in the past year getting dolled up at home hasn’t felt like a reasonable way to scratch my fashion itch. Clothes are a language we use to tell others about ourselves; fashion is a conversation. If there are no other people to talk to, then what’s the point?

Following our return to sociality, Sherman thinks that it will take a while for this dialogue to unfold—for designers to divine what this new world will require, and for people to decide what it is they actually want. Which is probably as it should be. The Roaring ’20s were a decade, after all, not a few warm months in 1920. *A*

Amanda Mull is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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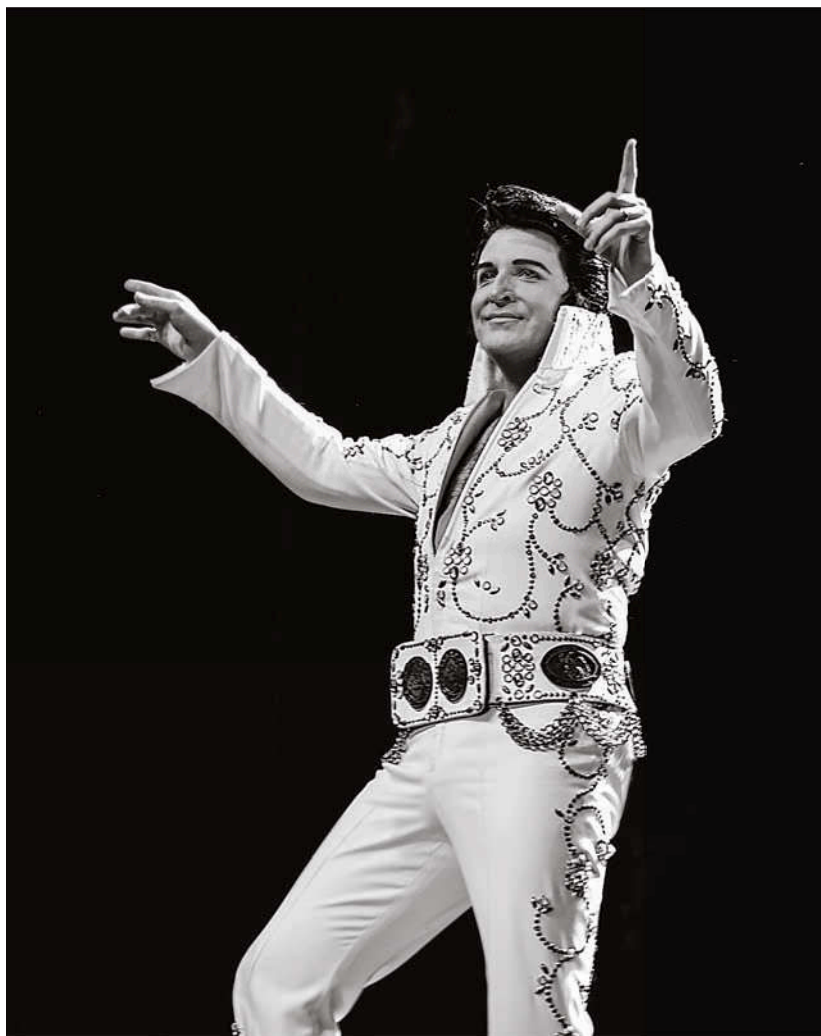
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ELVIS REENTERS THE BUILDING

*In rural Ohio, a performer bookends
a year of struggle and survival.*

BY TIM ALBERTA

S

Strict guidelines had been announced before the show: There could be no kisses on his cheek, no holding of his hand, no accepting of his garish, sweat-drenched scarves. In short: There could be no physical contact with Elvis. But the King was caught up in the moment, playing by his own rules. He had been waiting a year for this. And so had Sue Paszke, although for her it had felt much longer.

The last time Paszke and her fellow “Blue Hawaii Ladies” had caught a live glimpse of Dwight Icenhower—one of the world’s foremost Elvis “tribute artists”—was on March 7, 2020. It had happened here, inside Stuart’s Opera House, an elegant concert hall tucked into the hollows of Appalachia, in Nelsonville, Ohio. For 20 years, the ladies—uniformly clad in sky-blue aloha shirts—had been Icenhower’s groupies, following him to shows all around the country. Paszke, a 78-year-old retired lunch lady from Columbus, had struck up a ritual with Icenhower: Every time she saw him perform, he autographed her favorite scarf. When Icenhower came

Dwight Icenhower at his last show before the pandemic closed Stuart’s Opera House, in Nelsonville, Ohio

SCOTTY HALL

to Stuart's Opera House last March, he signed the scarf for the 99th time. Once more, Paszke joked, and she could die a happy woman.

And then she almost died an unhappy woman. Several months into the coronavirus pandemic, Paszke awoke in the middle of the night unable to breathe. Her husband rushed her to the emergency room. "Good news," the doctors told her. "It's pneumonia." She was flattened for the next two months. Despite orders to avoid human contact—an infection being a likely death sentence—she couldn't seem to stay out of the hospital. Having recently undergone surgery on one knee, she soon had the other knee operated on as well. Later, her heart rate began spiking uncontrollably, the result of a previously undiagnosed cardiac condition. She wept and wallowed and cursed her circumstances: too frail to attend funerals, too compromised to meet her first great-grandchild. "It was hell," Paszke told me. "All I could do was wonder..." She paused. "I didn't think I'd ever get that 100th autograph."

One year and six days later, she stood in an elevated box on the right side of Stuart's stage, a Juliet awaiting her Romeo. This was a special occasion—and not just for Paszke. It was a homecoming for Icenhower. (Yes, Dwight Icenhower is his real name.) Having grown up nearby, he had achieved some level of fame as Elvis reborn—he'd performed around the world and starred in a Super Bowl commercial for Apple that has 1.4 billion YouTube views. But the pandemic left him with considerable time to reflect on his life and career. When he talked with Stuart's about headlining its first show

upon reopening, he asked not to perform as Elvis Presley. He just wanted to be Dwight Icenhower from Pomeroy, Ohio.

He ditched the white jumpsuit and sunglasses for a mustard jacket and black skinny jeans, and performed not only Elvis's greatest hits, but also a medley of Johnny Cash and Ricky Nelson and Elton John songs. When the time was right, he called out to Paszke. Her scarf had been sneaked backstage before the show for Icenhower's signature. Now, telling the crowd their story, Icenhower took Paszke in one hand and raised the faux silk with the other. The moment was one part triumph of the human spirit, one part proof that beauty is in the eye of the beholder.

"I know it might sound weird—all this fuss over an Elvis tribute artist," Betsy Naseman, Paszke's niece and a fellow Blue Hawaii Lady, told me afterward. "But being back here a year later, it feels like we've come full circle. Like we've survived."

Easily the youngest of the group at age 38—she joked that she's their chaperone—Naseman works at a senior-care facility in Cincinnati. The past year, she said, "has been so devastating." More than 20 of her residents died. And the one thing that could always lift her mood was no longer there. "I needed one of Dwight's shows in ways I can't really describe," Naseman said. "We all need something, right? We all need that human connection. I didn't have it. None of us did. And that's not normal. That's why today felt so good. It felt like normal again."

Sitting nearby, Paszke stroked the scarf, tears welling in her eyes. "I wasn't sure

if I should come today. I felt a little guilty. I've only gotten the first vaccine shot, and so many people are still hurting," she said. "But do you know what my doctor said? He told me I needed to come. He said it would be good for my soul. He said I need to get happy to get healthy."

PRESIDING OVER THE historic public square of Nelsonville, a city of some 5,000 people, Stuart's Opera House is three stories of brick and nostalgia—a monument to a

"I NEEDED ONE OF DWIGHT'S SHOWS IN WAYS I CAN'T REALLY DESCRIBE," NASEMAN SAID. "WE ALL NEED SOMETHING, RIGHT?"

time when workers and families flocked to Appalachia, when an opera house could thrive in a small town because the locals were financially secure and starved for culture.

The venue opened in 1879, and what ensued is a story common to scores of opera houses around rural America: a couple of generations of prosperity, followed by sudden collapse.

More than 50 years after Stuart's curtain fell in 1924—when the end of the coal-extraction rush coincided with the advent of mass cinema—a local group decided to revive the theater. But a fire in 1980 nearly destroyed the building. Rebuilding and reopening took

17 years. From 1997 to 2015, Stuart's thrived as a cultural novelty in a region ravaged by the forces of deindustrialization and outsourcing and automation. And then the opera house nearly burned down—*again*.

"The story of this place is survival," Melissa Wales, the theater's executive director, told me as we walked its corridors. Tracing the brickwork backstage, I could see three lines of ceramic demarcation—masonry from the original opera house, from the rebuild after 1980, and from the rebuild after 2015. "This place has survived a lot," Wales said. "And now it's survived COVID."

During my visit to Nelsonville, I heard that word—*survived*—over and over, from Naseman and the other Blue Hawaii Ladies, from Wales and her colleagues, from the bartender at the Mine Tavern next door. ("How's business?" I asked. "We survived the worst," he said.) The mood was less celebratory than quietly relieved, the joys of reopening and reconvening inextricable from the grief and trauma not yet fully behind us.

"My leg is shaking. I'm nervous. This is a huge, huge day for us," Tim Peacock, the longtime artistic director at Stuart's, told the crowd before Icenhower's show. "Thank you all for coming." Backstage, he'd guzzled Pabst Blue Ribbon as a tranquilizer. It all felt surreal. Twenty years at this venue, Peacock told me, couldn't have prepared him for Elvis leaving the building last March. He'd worried that Stuart's was finished.

"We were the first industry to get shut down, and we're the last industry to reopen," he said. "And honestly, this place

couldn't have survived without some very generous donations."

Stuart's booked Icenhower for the grand reopening in part because of his devoted—and elderly—following. (The older the crowd, the more vaccinated patrons.) Because Ohio's governor had capped venue capacity at 15 percent, Stuart's scheduled two shows. The performances could

and working an hour away in Columbus—that Walsh began to realize the thing that might help to revitalize Nelsonville had been there her entire life. She bought a home down the road from where she'd grown up, joined Stuart's board of directors, and in recent years has become its de facto historian. Nelsonville "is a different place with the opera house

of us who work here are from Nelsonville. None of us even live here. Meanwhile, the people down the street are looking at big potholes in the roads. They can't afford new clothes for their kids. And they're wondering how these people who commute into Nelsonville raised \$4 million for a theater."

"We're the poorest county in Ohio—and that's part of our

charming storefront across the square from the opera house, told me. She described the past year as a nightmare for the battered community. Her boutique, which sells locally made pottery and other goods, had grown to employ a staff of 12. "And then COVID destroyed everything. A shop that had been filled seven days a week, a shop that couldn't keep up with its orders, was suddenly empty overnight. Completely lifeless."

Bills stacked up. Federal assistance proved elusive. The prospect of firing workers haunted her, but L'Heureux feared that if she didn't, the store would fold. Soon after letting her entire staff go, she fell and broke her ankle, requiring surgical reconstruction. The store, she announced, would close indefinitely. "People would see me around town and say, 'It must feel good to have all this free time on your hands,'" L'Heureux recalled. "But it wasn't free time. It was time spent wondering if I would make it."

Then she got a request for a specialty order, and then another. Soon, despite her store being closed, she was fielding appointments for people to come in and browse. People started getting vaccinated. State restrictions began to loosen. And Stuart's Opera House announced a show.

A few days after Dwight Icenhower thrilled Sue Paszke with a rendition of "I'll Never Fall in Love Again," L'Heureux told me she'd reached a conclusion: She, too, was going to survive. *A*

Tim Alberta is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Left: Stuart's Opera House. Right: Dwight Icenhower with one of the Blue Hawaii Ladies.

accommodate 60 people in a hall built for 395. But neither one sold out.

"Dwight's been playing packed houses here for 10 years. So the fact we haven't sold 60 tickets to either show—" Wales stopped herself. "It's a bit alarming."

MARY K. WALSH grew up in Nelsonville. "This square used to be very busy," she told me, staring out the third-floor windows of the opera house. "You didn't notice the decline at first. It was gradual, over a long period of time, until you turned around one day and there was nobody here."

As a girl, Walsh had been enchanted by the abandoned opera house. She explored it with her father, who worked for the local electric company, which leased parts of the building. It wasn't until she was grown and gone—living

open," Walsh said. "It really helped bring that sense of community back."

It also delivered a needed economic jolt. When Stuart's books a big act—and especially during its annual summer music festival—the area is transformed. Local shops see record sales. Bars and restaurants overflow. Airbnb rooms sell out. (There are no hotels in town.)

Still, the city's long-term trajectory keeps bending south. Good-paying jobs are scarce. Opioid abuse is rampant. By every metric—rates of poverty, crime, income, education—Nelsonville is in crisis. This can be obscured when the Columbus Symphony Orchestra comes to town. But it cannot be ignored.

"It's always bothered me," Tim Peacock said after Icenhower's second show, leaning against the lobby bar. "None

success," he added. "A lot of people come here because they want to go on a poverty tour. They want to go slumming in southeast Ohio."

By all accounts, Stuart's is a model citizen, hosting blood drives, free dinners, and music-education programs. The opera house even subsidized the hiring of a local school's art teacher. But every year, Peacock said, the suffering around him becomes more glaring. As some of Stuart's employees toasted to the reopening after the encore show, a certain unease filled the air. It's good that the opera house survived. It's good that out-of-towners who can afford concert tickets survived. But what about the folks who live blocks from the theater and have never been inside?

"I've barely been able to look people in the eye," Jennifer L'Heureux, the owner of Nelsonville Emporium, a



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Mother's Day

*Photo Illustration by
Tabitha Soren*

Tabitha Soren documented the months following the birth of her third child, in 2006, with the help of a digital camera mounted in her bedroom and operated by remote. In her new series, Motherload, Soren layers together the resulting images.

I was excited about having a third child, but dreading the first year. A friend of mine who's a filmmaker said, "Why don't you just photograph the whole thing?" I had one mount for the camera over the changing table and another where I nursed. I wasn't sure that anything would ever come out of it. I had not even looked at the photographs until a couple of months ago. They just seemed so quotidian; I couldn't imagine that they would be interesting at all.

Time can turn photographs into metaphor or allow them to become a symbol instead of a documentary picture; at this particular moment, mothers' needs are on the minds of the country. *Motherload* is about what mothers don't show: the emotions and psychological states that we've all been socialized to bury. It's not so much about my personal existence as it is about the blurred existence, all that time spent keeping something alive.

Having a newborn is a very sloppy, ugly, disheveled time of life. I felt out of the picture. I felt very taxed and very needed, but also very invisible. The images get at that ethereal quality of not feeling like a whole person. I'm not really in focus, because my brain isn't in focus either.

I can't tell you how many times I've checked an artist's biography to see, *Oh God, she's so great, but does she have children? Like, are we in the same race?* Because it's like running with weights on. But when I look at the pictures, I feel like a survivor.

— *As told to Sophie Gilbert*





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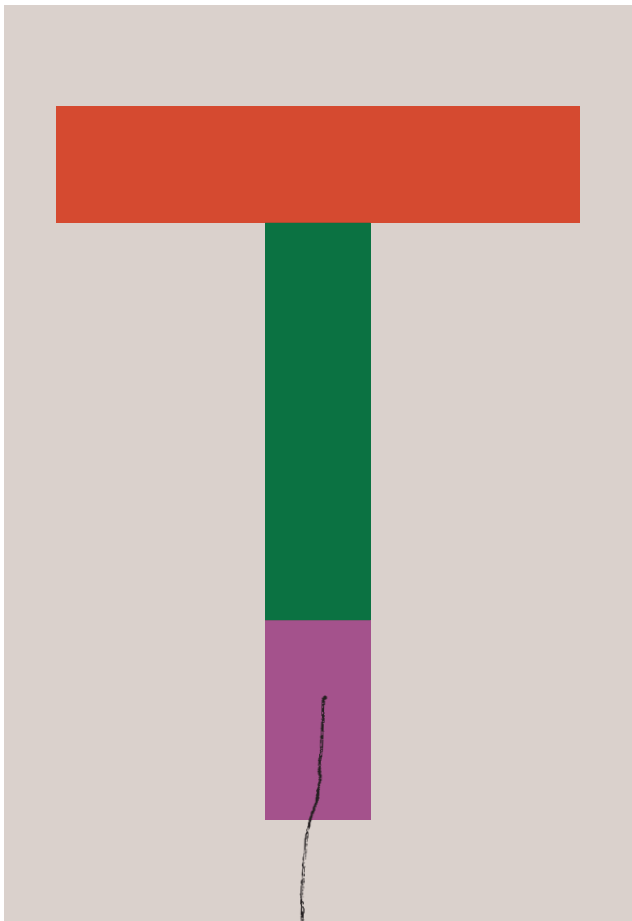


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The suburban gentry of Chevy Chase, Maryland, had some difficulty making sense of Brett Kavanaugh's descent into villainy that fall. He had always seemed so nice and nonthreatening to his neighbors, so *normal*—the khaki-clad carpool dad who coached the girls' basketball team and yammered endlessly about the Nats. It was true that his politics were unusual for the neighborhood, the kind of place where NO JUSTICE / NO PEACE signs stand righteously in front of million-dollar homes. But Brett was not a scary Republican, of the kind who had recently invaded Washington. He was well educated and properly socialized, a friend of the Bushes, a stalwart of the country club. When his nomination to the Supreme Court was first announced, the neighborhood had largely welcomed the news. People gave interviews attesting to his niceness; the owner of the Chevy Chase Lounge said that he would add Brett's photo to the wall of famous patrons.

But then came the first accusation, and the next accusations, and the cable-news pile-on, and the Donald Trump tweets, and the satellite trucks on Thornapple Street, and the regrettable Senate hearings in which their neighbor appeared on national TV, his face twisted into an aggrieved snarl, his voice torqued up to an unnatural shout, ranting through tears about the political enemies who were trying to destroy his life—and, well, suddenly what to think about Brett wasn't so clear anymore.

Stories of his shunning circulated among neighbors, accompanied by a mix of pity and schadenfreude: the woman at La Ferme

who heckled him after dinner; the taunting message on the diner marquee that he passed each morning on his commute. Even at the Shrine of the Most Blessed Sacrament, where people were usually so good about setting aside political differences, the Kavanaugh case proved divisive. Poor Father Foley was swamped with letters and emails, while parishioners parsed the details of Brett's alleged youthful sins—*What was a devil's triangle, anyway?*—and grumbled about watching him receive Communion.

Brett was confirmed in the end, of course, becoming the 114th justice to serve on the Supreme Court, but his photo never made it onto the wall at the Chevy Chase Lounge. And maybe it was just their imagination, but some of his neighbors swore that Brett was different now—harder, further away. He wore a baseball cap when he left the house, and started dining out more at the country club, where security was tight and access was limited. He canceled a planned trip to the annual Harvard–Yale game and turned down invitations to lectures and conferences, hosting small groups of students in his chambers instead.

For months, he seemed to float quietly through the neighborhood like a spectral figure, a ghost of culture wars past, condemned to haunt Chevy Chase. Sightings at the grocery store became moments of morbid fascination disguised as friendly concern: *How did he look? What was his mood? Does he seem okay—you know, after everything?*

Then one day, about six months after he was sworn in, Brett did something strange. It was Easter Sunday, and he had come to Blessed Sacrament for Mass with his family. When the service ended, he made his way outside, positioned himself at Father Foley's elbow, and proceeded to greet parishioners as they filed out of the church—laughing and glad-handing and thanking them for coming, as though Brett were the priest and they were his flock.

This odd little spectacle lent itself to multiple interpretations. Was he reaching out in fellowship to his enemies? Making a show of contrition (or forgiveness)? Or was he perhaps signaling something more ominous? “I read it as a flex,” says one parishioner who huffily steered his family away from the scene. “I read it as *I’m right here, in the middle of everything, and I’m not going away. I won.*”

A STRANGE IRONY of Brett Kavanaugh's ruinous 2018 confirmation battle is that for all the attention it commanded—and all the certainty it instilled in both supporters and opponents—Kavanaugh remained more or less a mystery when it was over. What did he believe? Whose interests was he serving? And what exactly happened in that suburban-Maryland bedroom all those years ago? Christine Blasey Ford's accusation that he'd sexually assaulted her in high school—and the judge's denial—foregrounded debates over predation and privilege, even as Kavanaugh himself seemed to blur into abstraction. Nearly three years later, questions remain, not only about past behavior but about the future. The cold reality is that Kavanaugh is now on the bench. And there is reason to ask whether his bitter path to the Court might influence what he does with a lifetime appointment.

Kavanaugh's confirmation cemented a conservative majority on the Court that got even stronger last year when he was joined by Amy Coney Barrett. Kavanaugh now sits at the Court's

ideological center—illustrating how far to the right the center has shifted. Any judicial victory that liberals hope to achieve in the coming years will likely require winning over the justice whose nomination they fought most ferociously to defeat.

As much as the modern Court clings to its image as an apolitical institution—enlightened, black-robed figures dispensing wisdom from on high, guided by love of country and Constitution—the truth is that its members have always been swayed by politics, ego, and grievance. After Clarence Thomas’s confirmation was nearly quashed in 1991 by accusations of sexual harassment, he retreated into a cocoon of allies and ideologues, rarely speaking in public even as he became one of the most right-wing justices in recent history. Some wonder whether Kavanaugh will follow the same trajectory. It was he, after all, who spoke in that infamous Senate hearing about the country reaping “the whirlwind” and suffering “consequences” in a way that led many to believe he was issuing threats. “As we all know,” he told the senators who were questioning him, “in the United States political system of the early 2000s, what goes around comes around.”

While Kavanaugh’s allies insist that those comments were misinterpreted, they also say that he still privately seethes over the “smear campaign” he believes he endured. “He’s made an effort to say, ‘Look, I’m not bitter about this. I’m moving forward,’” one friend told me. “But I assume, when he’s lying in bed at night, it’s hard not to think about it.” Another friend put it more bluntly: “He was really angry at Democrats for what they did to him and his family.” And yet, those same friends also describe a competing impulse in Kavanaugh—a burning desire to gain readmission into polite society and enjoy all the perks associated with one of the world’s most prestigious jobs.

The Court is poised to tackle a range of consequential issues in the near future—from the regulatory power of federal agencies to voting rights to the fate of *Roe v. Wade*. And for all of America’s illustrious constitutional scaffolding and its ideals about the rule

of law, a generation of jurisprudence could come down to an unnerving question: Is Justice Kavanaugh out for revenge?

BRETT MICHAEL KAVANAUGH learned the virtues of partisanship long before he discovered politics. As a kid, he rooted fanatically for the teams he inherited, the Redskins and the Bullets; as a teen, he developed a close-knit group of friends at Georgetown Prep and performed his allegiance with try-hard zeal. Although Kavanaugh was not a standout athlete, he relished being part of a team—the nicknames and the inside jokes, the camaraderie born of a common cause, no matter how pointless or juvenile. When his friends set a goal of drinking 100 kegs during the year leading up to graduation, few gave more to the effort than Kavanaugh. Acquaintances prone to armchair psychoanalysis would later speculate that his fixation on the fraternal grew out of his status as an only child. “He’s very good in groups of male friends,” a former classmate told me.

If Kavanaugh had grown up somewhere else, he might have joined a cult or a street gang; because he grew up in Bethesda, he pledged a fraternity at Yale. The elite pedigree of Delta Kappa Epsilon—past members include five presidents and a handful of Supreme Court justices—belied its essential frattnishness. To join, Kavanaugh reportedly endured a series of ritual humiliations, including an order to hop around campus in a leather football helmet while grabbing his crotch and chanting, “I’m a geek, I’m a geek, I’m a power tool. / When I sing this song, I look like a fool.”

While Yale was not known for its robust Greek culture, the “Dekes” had a reputation for debauchery. They boisterously waved flags made of women’s underwear, read aloud from *Penthouse* in the quad, and threw legendarily boozy parties. Once, with a frat brother, Kavanaugh got into a bar fight after a UB40 concert, and wound up being questioned by the New Haven police. (According to a police report obtained by *The New York Times*, Kavanaugh was not charged.) Decades later, episodes like these would become fodder during Kavanaugh’s confirmation battle. Democrats discerned a violent, misogynistic streak that supported the allegations against him; Republicans dismissed it all as youthful bravado. But to those who knew Kavanaugh, the stories also revealed the blinkered recklessness of a young man intoxicated by the thrill of belonging.

Kavanaugh showed few signs of ideological fervor as an undergraduate. In fact, his former classmate told me, even at Yale Law School most of his fellow students had no sense of his politics until he started conspicuously cultivating relationships with influential conservative professors. This abrupt political coming-out prompted more than a little cynicism among his peers, who suspected careerism (a mode not exactly foreign to the Yale Law School set): In a field clogged with liberals, the path to coveted clerkships and jobs was much more open if you were coming from the right. “The question is, how conservative was he? I don’t think even Brett knew at the time,” the classmate said.

After Kavanaugh completed an unremarkable clerkship, one of his professors recommended him for a prestigious spot with the libertarian Judge Alex Kozinski, on the Ninth Circuit, which then propelled him to a clerkship with Justice Anthony Kennedy.

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In an arena where Supreme Court clerkships command significant bonuses at big law firms—upwards of \$400,000 today—Kavanaugh’s talent for picking the right mentors paid off.

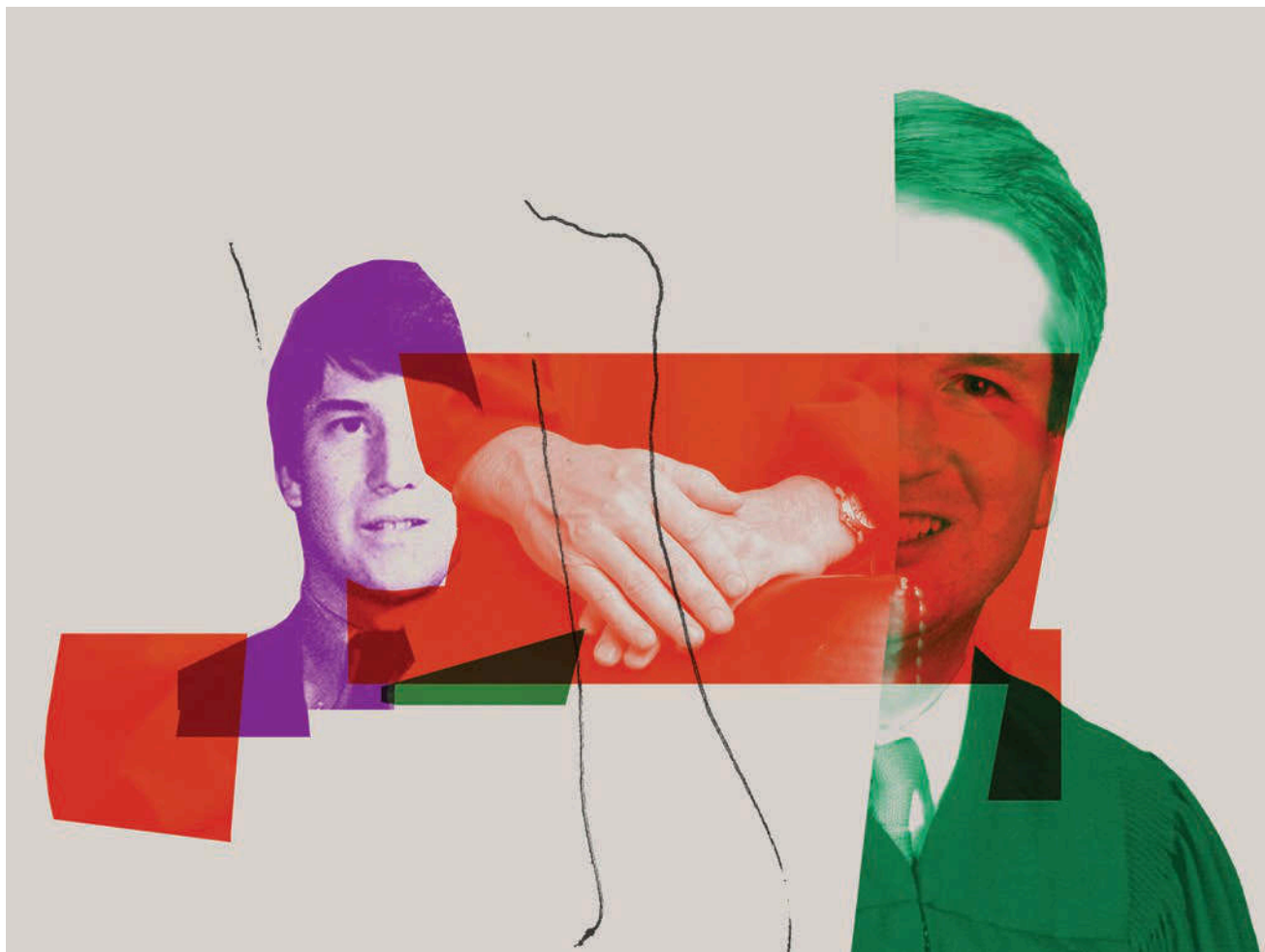
Yet even as he climbed the ladder of Washington’s conservative legal establishment, Kavanaugh remained staunchly nonpartisan in his schmoozing. “He was the kind of conservative you could go out to dinner with,” says Ruth Marcus, a liberal columnist at *The Washington Post* who knew Kavanaugh early in his career and later wrote a book about him called *Supreme Ambition*. So when he joined the newly formed special prosecutor’s office investigating some possibly shady real-estate deals made by Bill and Hillary Clinton, his friends took little notice. The job was supposed to last six months at most, after which he would move on to the lucrative career that awaited him.

The early days of Ken Starr’s investigation were relatively quiet. The office was small, and the scope of the inquiry was narrow. Kimberly Wehle, a member of Starr’s team at that time, recalls Kavanaugh as bright and fair and absurdly hardworking. “I remember thinking to myself, *That is the kind of person who belongs on the Supreme Court*,” she told me. But as the investigation dragged on, growing and mutating and accumulating new targets—from the suicide of Vince Foster to the accusations against President Clinton by Paula Jones to the curious case of a certain White House intern—the environment in the office

changed. Starr himself, once considered a leading prospect for the Supreme Court, came to be seen in Washington as a sanctimonious partisan hell-bent on taking down the Clintons. The lawyers who worked for him were recast as foot soldiers in a “vast right-wing conspiracy”—and some of them started to act like it.

Around this time, Kavanaugh went out on a date with Colleen Covell, a young Democratic prosecutor in D.C. When they got to the bar, Covell recalls, Kavanaugh started draining beers at an impressive pace. The more he drank, the more candid he became in his commentary on the Clintons, until eventually he was shouting things like “I can’t believe you voted for him!” and “They’re total crooks!” The intensity of his animus was startling, Covell told me. “I just remember thinking, *Whoa, he really hates them*.”

By the time Starr’s team turned its attention to Monica Lewinsky, the hothouse environment of the office had taken a toll on Kavanaugh, who had now been there well past six months. Once, amid a debate over whether the president should be asked sexually explicit questions under oath, Kavanaugh fired off a memo to his colleagues advocating for an X-rated line of inquiry. Among his proposed questions: “If Monica Lewinsky says that you inserted a cigar into her vagina while you were in the Oval Office area, would she be lying?” (Robert Bittman, who also worked on Starr’s team, told me that Kavanaugh had written the memo in a fog of sleep deprivation, and that he later expressed regret for its tone.)



The investigation effectively launched Kavanaugh's career. For all the office's blunders, the young lawyer was able to forge relationships and bank favors with powerful Republicans, guaranteeing him a plum spot in the next GOP administration. After a stint on the Bush campaign's legal team during the 2000 Florida recount, Kavanaugh joined the White House counsel's office. George W. Bush took a liking to him, and eventually nominated him to serve on the prestigious D.C. Circuit Court of Appeals.

Over the next 12 years, Kavanaugh worked to reinvent himself as a respectable, and thoroughly unbiased, jurist with friends in both parties. He appeared frequently on legal panels and was hired to teach at Harvard Law School by its then-dean, Elena Kagan. He even publicly repented for his role in the Starr investigation, writing it off as a kind of youthful indiscretion. As a judge, he spent most of his time on wonky regulatory cases, which meant his conservative voting record attracted little attention in the culture wars. And when a politically charged case did fall into his lap, in 2017—involving an undocumented 17-year-old immigrant seeking an abortion in Texas—Kavanaugh tried to find a middle course. Rather than rule decisively on whether the abortion could proceed, he argued that the government should be given more time to find the young woman a “sponsor” who could help her make the decision. The ruling pleased no one, but it suggested an instinct for caution that made his brand of conservatism palatable in Washington.

Kavanaugh's rebranding campaign was so successful that, when he was selected for the Supreme Court, an array of bipartisan validators lined up to sing his praises. Amy Chua, the author and legal scholar, wrote an op-ed hailing his mentorship of female clerks. (In fact, her daughter would go on to clerk for Kavanaugh.) Akhil Reed Amar, a liberal law professor at Yale, said Democrats would be hard-pressed to find a conservative nominee better than Kavanaugh.

But some who had closely followed Kavanaugh's career remained suspicious. “He thinks very much as a partisan,” Garrett Epps, a law professor emeritus at the University of Baltimore, told me. “What has Kavanaugh ever been except the guy clutching onto the greasy pole?”

THE SUPREME COURT is a notoriously opaque institution. Justices rarely give interviews to the press (Kavanaugh declined my request), and clerks are expected to abide by a code of omertà that prevents them from publicly discussing what goes on behind closed doors. This culture of secrecy is encouraged by the Court's members, who are invested in maintaining the perception that their work is done beyond the reach of rank politics.

But people who have seen the inner workings of the Court say it's nothing if not political. Tit-for-tat dealmaking is commonplace. Alliances are formed and rivalries fester. In the 1940s, infighting among President Franklin D. Roosevelt's appointees got so bad that Hugo Black and William O. Douglas are said to have threatened to resign if Robert Jackson was made chief justice. In the 1970s, Potter Stewart leaked damaging stories about his colleagues to the journalist Bob Woodward.

While the judicial sausage-making may be more discreet on today's Court, a range of people close to the justices—including

KAVANAUGH'S ARRIVAL IN THE FALL OF 2018 OCCASIONED A ROUND OF CAREFUL INTERNAL MANEUVERING BY HIS NEW COLLEAGUES.

friends, confidants, and former clerks—told me that Kavanaugh's arrival in the fall of 2018 occasioned a round of careful internal maneuvering by his new colleagues.

Most of the justices already knew Kavanaugh, and some of them even liked him. He was a regular at holiday parties and the swearing-in ceremonies for new Supreme Court lawyers (often lingering until the last guest left, according to one person). They also knew that he had been nominated at an overheated moment in American politics, by a president whose only inclination was to raise the temperature further. Even before the assault allegations, the regular partisan forces seemed especially girded for war: The day Kavanaugh's name was put forward, the organizers of the Women's March accidentally released a fill-in-the-blank statement they had prewritten condemning Trump's “nomination of XX to the Supreme Court.”

In private, Kavanaugh had expressed his own misgivings about the president who nominated him, even as he went through the requisite motions of flattery and fealty. “He was no fan of Donald Trump,” one friend told me. “But he's not going to say no to the nomination. He had to kiss the ring to get there.”

Kavanaugh's future colleagues were primed for sympathy. The justices had long been united in a shared disdain for the confirmation process. The grandstanding senators, the bloodthirsty reporters, the political groups churning out attack ads—to the men and women of the Supreme Court, the whole thing felt like a high-stakes hazing ritual, and they were inclined to give one another the benefit of the doubt. “It's a highly partisan process, and you have to kind of therefore take the slings and arrows with a grain of salt,” a person close to the Court told me. More to the point, some of the justices recognized an opportunity in Kavanaugh's uniquely contentious confirmation.

Kagan, an Obama appointee known inside the Court as a deft strategic operator, was quick to make a move. Sensing that Kavanaugh, in this vulnerable moment, might welcome allies wherever he could find them, she launched a quiet charm offensive. While he was still moving into his chambers, Kagan stopped by and offered to host a dinner party in his honor at her Washington apartment. They were seen together frequently—whispering and laughing during oral arguments or talking baseball over lunch in the justices' private dining hall, where she liked to joke that their conversation was a reprieve from the Shakespearean forays favored by Kavanaugh's predecessor, Anthony Kennedy. "She saw him as up for grabs," said one person with knowledge of the Court's internal dynamics.

The other liberal women on the bench followed Kagan's lead. Sonia Sotomayor gave an interview in which she welcomed Kavanaugh's arrival: "This is our work family, and it's just as important as our personal family." Ruth Bader Ginsburg praised her new colleague at an event in Washington as "very decent and very smart." These comments upset some on the left, but they had a strategic purpose. The liberal justices knew Kavanaugh wouldn't vote with them on a regular basis, but they hoped they could pick off his vote occasionally, when it mattered. Having a relationship would help.

Clarence Thomas, meanwhile, was running his own game. Though he had refused to watch the hearings on principle, he felt he understood better than most what Kavanaugh had gone through. "He had been there," Armstrong Williams, a longtime friend of Thomas's, told me. "It was like déjà vu all over again." Thomas was eager to impart the lessons he'd taken from his own confirmation experience—most important, in his view, that trying to ingratiate yourself with your character assassins was a fool's errand. "It took Justice Thomas a few years to figure that out," Williams said. "But now he lets what he does on the Court speak for him—his rulings, his opinions, his dissenting opinions. He can't do anything about how people talk about him." According to Williams, Thomas hoped to be an example to Kavanaugh and would indeed be "a good mentor."

But the justice to whom Kavanaugh gravitated, according to people close to him, was John Roberts. The two men had moved in similar social circles for years—they belonged to the same country club, played in the same poker game—and Kavanaugh had long considered him a role model. He made little secret of his fanboy status: In his D.C. Circuit chambers, a blown-up photograph of himself and "the chief" had hung on the wall. "Brett idolizes John Roberts," a friend of Kavanaugh's told me. "If you're looking for soul-mate types, that's them."

Court watchers varied on whether the feeling was mutual, but Roberts had his own reasons to cultivate Kavanaugh. The chief justice is an ardent believer in the idea that the Court's credibility rests on its image as an apolitical institution. "It's my job to call balls and strikes," he famously testified during his confirmation hearing, "not to pitch or bat." Roberts's fixation on staving off political backlash had guided much of his tenure. He favored narrow decisions over sweeping ones, resisted establishing broad new precedents, and was said to cut deals with his colleagues behind the scenes to avoid 5–4 rulings in high-profile cases. In 2012, he surprised Court watchers when he cast the deciding vote to

uphold the Affordable Care Act. It was later reported that Roberts had initially planned to strike down a key provision of the law but flipped his vote, avoiding the blowback that would have resulted if conservative justices had overturned President Barack Obama's signature legislation in an election year.

Now Kavanaugh's crash landing threatened to undo the carefully honed image of the Roberts Court—and maybe even the Court itself. Democrats were openly talking about "packing" the bench with liberal justices if they took back the White House and Congress in 2020, while scholars and commentators tossed around proposals to radically reduce the constitutional power of the judiciary.

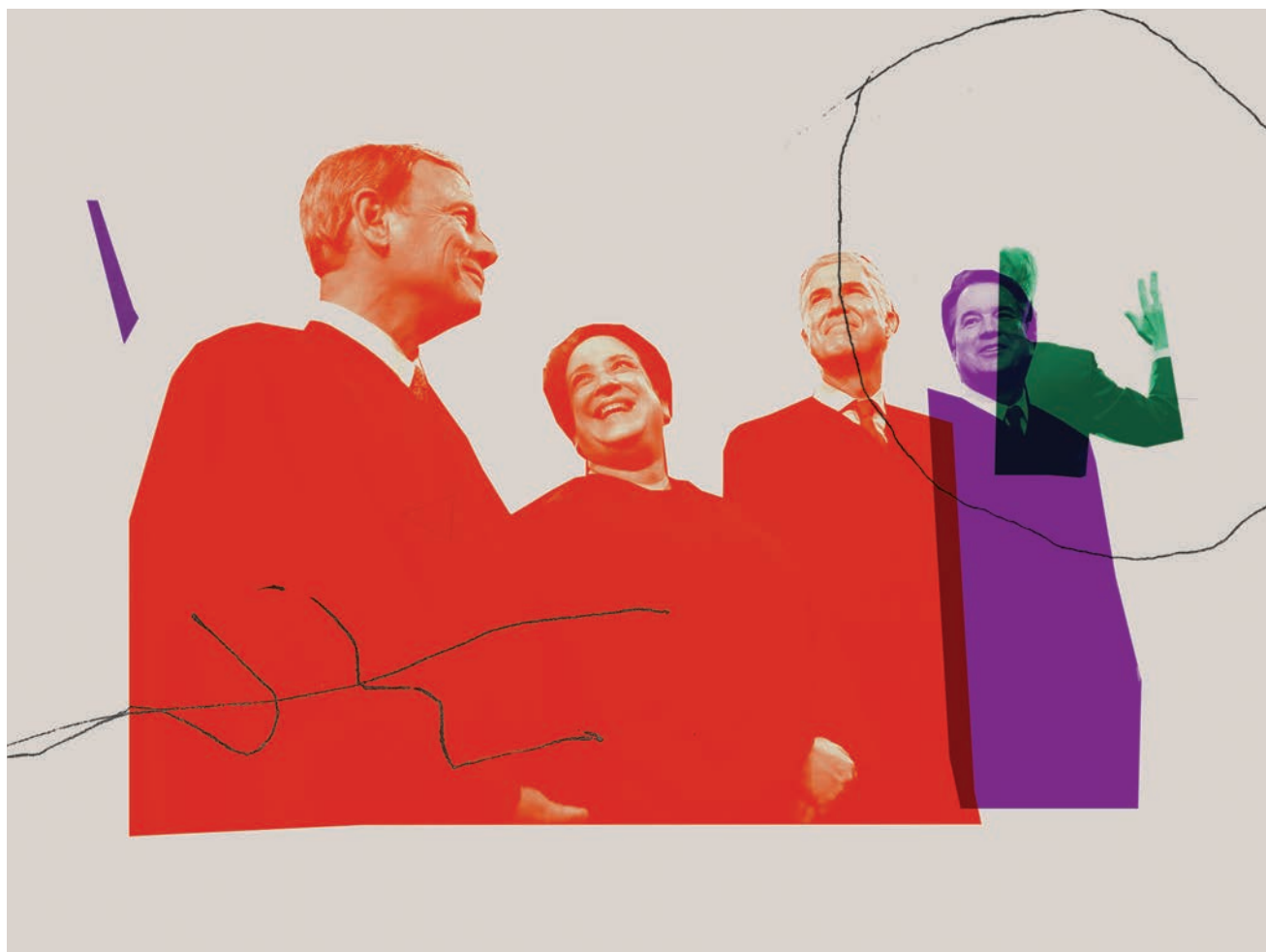
Roberts worked to ensure that Kavanaugh's first term was as uneventful as possible. He maneuvered to clear the docket of abortion cases, and successfully punted a controversial case involving a Christian baker and a same-sex-wedding cake back to the lower courts. In the cases the Court heard, Kavanaugh stuck close to Roberts, voting with him 94 percent of the time.

Observers were quick to note how different Kavanaugh seemed from his fellow Trump appointee, Neil Gorsuch. Though they had known each other since adolescence, when they were two years apart at Georgetown Prep, they were polar opposites. Kavanaugh was the proto-frat bro who organized boozy beach trips for his friends, Gorsuch the know-it-all prig who spent his free time on the debate team. And though they ended up clerking at the same time for Justice Kennedy, they never seemed to warm up to each other. The tense nature of their relationship became a subject of speculation among the Court's insiders. Some chalked it up to clashing personalities: "Gorsuch has somewhat sharp elbows and a lot of self-regard," one person told me. Others pointed to signs of a competitive rivalry: When Gorsuch was nominated first for the Supreme Court, in 2017, a restless Kavanaugh began telling friends that he might retire from the D.C. Circuit and make money practicing law.

Whatever the reason, there was no mistaking their divergent styles on the bench. Gorsuch routinely stirred the pot with his purple opinions and grandiose pronouncements, self-consciously positioning himself as the right-wing heir to Antonin Scalia. Kavanaugh, meanwhile, was restrained during oral arguments, quietly siding with the majority most of the time and periodically aligning himself with the liberals. In his first term, he voted with Kagan as often as he did with Gorsuch. When he did come down on the right in a divisive case, he would write a separate opinion explaining himself in almost apologetic terms.

"He really cares how he's perceived across the ideological spectrum," David Lat, the founding editor of the influential legal-commentary site *Above the Law*, told me. "I would say Justice Kavanaugh is trying to be the conservative that people don't hate."

SO FAR, Kavanaugh has had limited success in that mission. As he nears the end of his third term on the bench, his judicial record has proved peskily difficult to caricature—solidly conservative but not radically so, prone to incrementalism, disinclined toward culture war. And yet, he remains a magnet for criticism and controversy. Whatever your view of Kavanaugh, you can find evidence that he's not on your side.



When he cast the deciding vote in a ruling that allowed states to continue practicing partisan gerrymandering, Twitter exploded with calls from the left for his impeachment. Similar outrage met his vote to allow the Trump administration to include a citizenship question on the census, which many regarded as an intimidation tactic designed to undercount immigrants. A number of liberal Court watchers believe that the worst may be yet to come. As a lower-court judge, Kavanaugh showed open antagonism toward what is known as the *Chevron* doctrine, the legal principle that courts should give great weight to the interpretations adopted by federal agencies as they administer complicated regulations. It may be the one area in which his views are the most hardened. If Kavanaugh leads his conservative colleagues in overturning *Chevron*, Democrats warn, legal challenges will tie regulators' hands and hobble the implementation of progressive policies—affecting everything from health care to the environment to corporate oversight.

For some people, of course, the nuances of Kavanaugh's voting record will always matter less than the fact that he was confirmed after facing a credible accusation of sexual assault. A year after Kavanaugh was sworn in, Christine Blasey Ford was still receiving death threats. The veteran judicial reporter Dahlia Lithwick wrote that she'd been unable to return to the Supreme Court

because she was still so angry. Irin Carmon, a feminist journalist who covered the Kavanaugh hearings closely, told me the episode was especially painful because it took place at a moment when accusations of sexual misconduct seemed at last to be taken seriously. "People had started to think this time would be different, and it wasn't, and that's why it was so crushing."

At the same time, Kavanaugh has disappointed many of the right-wing activists who expected the Hulk-like figure from his confirmation hearings to reemerge on the bench. The grumbling began last year, when he voted to allow the Manhattan district attorney access to Donald Trump's tax records. But frustration really boiled over in February, when his swing vote prevented the Supreme Court from hearing a slate of lawsuits challenging the election results brought by Trump and his allies. Across the Trumpist media, Kavanaugh was derided as a coward and a traitor. John Cardillo, a host at Newsmax, summarized the sentiment on Twitter: "Shame on Kavanaugh for playing ball after they tried to destroy him and his family."

Even within the more staid precincts of the conservative legal establishment, fears have begun to surface that Kavanaugh might be uniquely vulnerable to "judicial drift"—a phenomenon in which Republican-appointed justices, such as Lewis Powell and Harry Blackmun, grow steadily more liberal the longer they're

on the bench. Even before he was nominated, Kavanaugh had raised concerns at the Federalist Society, which vets the conservative bona fides of judicial candidates. He was added to Trump's shortlist only after an intense lobbying campaign by Republican friends, most notably Anthony Kennedy, the justice he had clerked for and eventually replaced. Now some Republicans are privately wondering if the scramble to push through his confirmation was worth it. "Might there be some temptation to appease the left? Yeah, there might be," one Kavanaugh ally told me. "He's a human, and that's a very human temptation. But I would be extremely disappointed in him if he were to go south."

SHORTLY AFTER KAVANAUGH was sworn in, his former clerks gave him a gift: a framed print by the artist Tom Lea accompanied by a quote about living "on the sunrise side of the mountain." The original painting had hung in George W. Bush's Oval Office, and the quote was a Bush favorite. Kavanaugh displayed it prominently in his chambers, a pledge to himself that he would remain optimistic.

Kavanaugh knew the first few months would be bad, friends say. The wounds from the confirmation hearings were still fresh; everybody was still angry. So when he had to withdraw from his teaching position at Harvard Law School amid protests—despite his sterling student evaluations—he was stung, but told everyone he understood the situation. And when Matt Damon turned him into a punch line on *Saturday Night Live*, he gamely insisted that the impression was hilarious. But Kavanaugh was determined not to remain in exile forever. "He thrives on life in the public square," a friend told me. "He loves it."

So far, the public square has not been particularly inviting. At the Federalist Society's 2019 annual dinner, his keynote speech—a rite of passage for new conservative justices—was repeatedly derailed by liberal protesters. At a Georgetown Prep homecoming game, he reportedly had to ask alumni to put down their beers before he would pose for photos with them. Even venturing to Mass or the grocery store meant subjecting himself to a potential confrontation or a nosy neighbor overinterpreting his every move.

The drumbeat of negative media coverage has yet to relent. This spring, when Democratic Senator Sheldon Whitehouse called on the Justice Department to investigate the FBI's 2018 background check of Kavanaugh, suggesting that it was "fake," a round of sensational headlines followed. ("Could Brett Kavanaugh Be Booted From the Supreme Court?" *Vanity Fair* asked.) His conservative colleagues might let stories like that roll off their backs, but Kavanaugh is hyper-attentive to the press. "I don't think Thomas or Alito gives a shit what *The New York Times* says about them," one friend told me. "But I think Brett does."

The pandemic has only heightened the sense of isolation. Last year, for the first time in its history, the Supreme Court began operating remotely, conducting oral arguments and most other business by conference call. Kavanaugh, who unlike most of his colleagues still has school-age children (plus a noisy dog), found working from home untenable, according to one friend, and continued to commute into Washington, where he spent most of his time alone in his spacious chambers.

"I DON'T THINK THOMAS OR ALITO GIVES A SHIT WHAT *THE NEW YORK TIMES* SAYS ABOUT THEM," A FRIEND OF KAVANAUGH'S TOLD ME. "BUT I THINK BRETT DOES."

People close to Kavanaugh say it's only a matter of time before he attempts some kind of rehabilitation tour—an interview in a mainstream news outlet, perhaps, followed by a handful of public lectures. But he's been careful not to move too fast. Time is one thing a 56-year-old Supreme Court justice with a lifetime appointment has plenty of.

For now, observers are left to speculate about what fundamentally drives Kavanaugh. Most of his friends seem to believe that the partisan revenge fantasy feared by the left and craved by the right is unlikely to materialize. He's an affable guy, they all insist—he simply wants everyone to like him again. (Some even wonder if he regrets being tapped. "If he had it to do over again, knowing what would happen, would he accept the nomination?" a person close to Kavanaugh asked. "I honestly don't know.") But squint again at the story of Kavanaugh's rise, and a different picture might come into view: a credential-obsessed meritocrat who's spent his life sweatily striving for power without any grounding in conviction or principle.

Which brings us back to the nature of the Supreme Court itself. There may be no greater indictment of America's democratic system than the fact that Brett Kavanaugh's feelings are so potentially consequential. But at a moment when the Court is routinely called upon to fill the void left by a dysfunctional political system, a single justice has enormous power to set policy and settle national debates. If Kavanaugh is "dangerous," as his critics contend, it's not because he is part of some brazen right-wing conspiracy. It's because he has managed to ascend to the height of American power while remaining, perhaps even to himself, a living Rorschach test. *A*

McKay Coppins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

PANDEMICS EXACERBATE POVERTY

COVID-19 IS STACKING THE ODDS AGAINST THE COMMUNITIES WE SERVE,
WITH GLOBAL POVERTY RISING FOR THE FIRST TIME IN MORE THAN 20 YEARS.

Food and animal feed costs are increasing across the world.

Mexico is seeing **reduced incomes** due to reduced demand, increased animal prices and lack of access to loans.

Women are seeing depleted savings and **reduced incomes by 50%.**

Farm production is **down 20%** across Africa, with increased waste.

WHY PANDEMICS HIT PEOPLE IN POVERTY HARDER:



Close quarters



Poor sanitation



Insufficient nutrition



Lack of access to health care

BUT OUR FARMERS ARE RISING TO THE CHALLENGE.

FARMERS ARE on the front line of the crisis, ensuring consumers continue to have access to safe, healthy, nutritious food.

YOU CAN HELP.

Give farmers the education, resources and opportunities needed to survive both the COVID-19 pandemic and the pandemic that is poverty. Donate today at Heifer.org/Atlantic


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▪ **PURGATORY**

▪ **AT** ▪ **SEA**



■ OFF THE COAST OF ITALY, CRUISE SHIPS ARE BEING REPURPOSED AS HOLDING PENS FOR MIGRANTS RESCUED FROM THE MEDITERRANEAN.

■ PHOTOGRAPHS BY
PAOLO PELLEGRIN

■ BY IAN URBINA

■ LA SUPREMA,

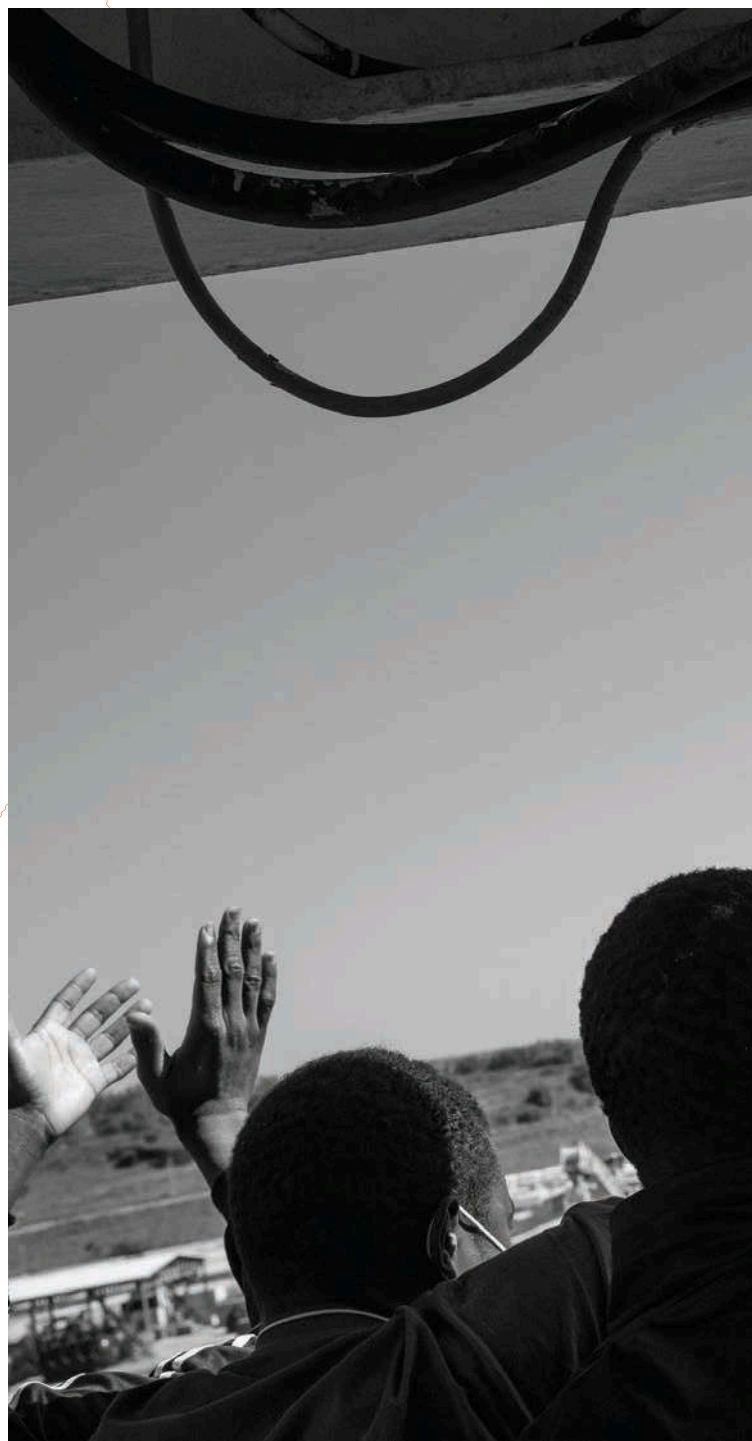
a cruise ship built in 2003 for \$120 million, can carry nearly 3,000 passengers, plus 1,000 cars. Almost 700 feet long, the ship has 567 cabins, three restaurants, six bars, a dozen or so shops, a casino, a movie theater, a nightclub, and a chapel. Its eight stories are connected by motion-sensor-activated escalators and glass-encased elevators, so that vacationers can avoid overexerting themselves on stairs after a few plates at the buffets.

Cruise ships tend to be designed to make passengers feel as though they're not at sea but rather in a five-star Las Vegas hotel. Everything is shiny, sprawling, and inward-facing. On La Suprema, many of the ceilings are paneled with mirrors, to give a sense of greater spaciousness. But natural light is scant; what little sunlight can be found squeezes in through tiny portholes. The narrow hallways, marble lobbies, and chandeliered dining rooms hum with fluorescent light. Thick carpeting muffles the low growl of the engine and the tireless smacking of the waves on the hull.

Last fall, I spent time on La Suprema, but not on a cruise. The lavish vessel, along with eight others, had been chartered by the Italian government and staffed by the Italian Red Cross to quarantine migrants rescued at sea, in order to keep them from bringing COVID-19 ashore. The ships had become giant floating holding pens—reportedly maintained at a monthly cost of more than 1 million euros (\$1.2 million) each—where thousands of migrants, mostly from the Middle East and Africa, were being held. I wanted to see the conditions on the quarantine ships for myself, but the Italian government had forbidden any journalists from boarding. So I applied to the Red Cross to work as a volunteer, and on a balmy, cloudless day in November, I boarded the ship.

ON ANY GIVEN DAY last fall and winter, several hundred migrants and a few dozen Red Cross staff were on board La Suprema. The passengers were confined to designated floors and areas, which were cordoned off with barriers of clear-plastic sheets that had been taped across doorways, to lessen the potential flow of COVID-contaminated air. The ship was kept impeccably clean, and Red Cross workers aggressively enforced mask wearing indoors.

For all its wood paneling and velvet upholstery, the ship felt less like a vacation destination than a nursing home—a place humid with worried waiting, and smelling of boiled broccoli and carrots. The ship's gold-colored railings served as clotheslines, where laundry air-dried. The video-game arcade had become a medical storage closet, with boxes of latex gloves, hand sanitizer, and toilet paper stacked between the Galaga and Pac-Man machines. Single-serve packets of olive oil from the buffet station had been repurposed as a balm for rashes.



Most of the time we were anchored roughly a mile from shore, off the coast of Sicily, and though the sea sometimes swelled, the ship was so massive that it only ever swayed gently. We were circled at all times by two patrol boats from Italy's Guardia di Finanza, which polices immigration and financial crimes.

Several times a day, Red Cross staff led the migrants, single file, out of their cramped hallways to the ship's upper deck, where they were allowed half-hour recesses. The deck, which on a typical cruise would have been dappled with sunbathers, was filled instead with migrants dragging on cigarettes as they paced around a drained, blue-tiled swimming pool strewn with candy wrappers.



I had first learned about the quarantine ships from my friend Francesco Taskayali, a 29-year-old Italian pianist. (A nonprofit I run, the Outlaw Ocean Project, co-published one of his albums.) Last September, Taskayali emailed to say that he was working as a Red Cross volunteer. His concert tours had been canceled, he explained, and with time on his hands, he wanted to see what life was like for migrants on the quarantine ships.

Taskayali was first assigned to another quarantine ship, the *Allegra*. On his second day on the job, he told me, a humanitarian ship operated by Médecins Sans Frontières delivered 353 migrants, pulled from flimsy dinghies in the Mediterranean waters

Previous Spread: Italian law enforcement escorts 68 migrants, rescued off the coast of Sicily, to the Port of Augusta on March 31. Most of the migrants were delivered to the *Rhapsody*, a cruise ship now being operated by the Italian Red Cross, to begin their quarantine. (All photos in this article were shot aboard the *Allegra*, another quarantine ship, from March 29 to April 2.)

Above: Migrants already on board the *Allegra* wave to new arrivals recently rescued at sea.

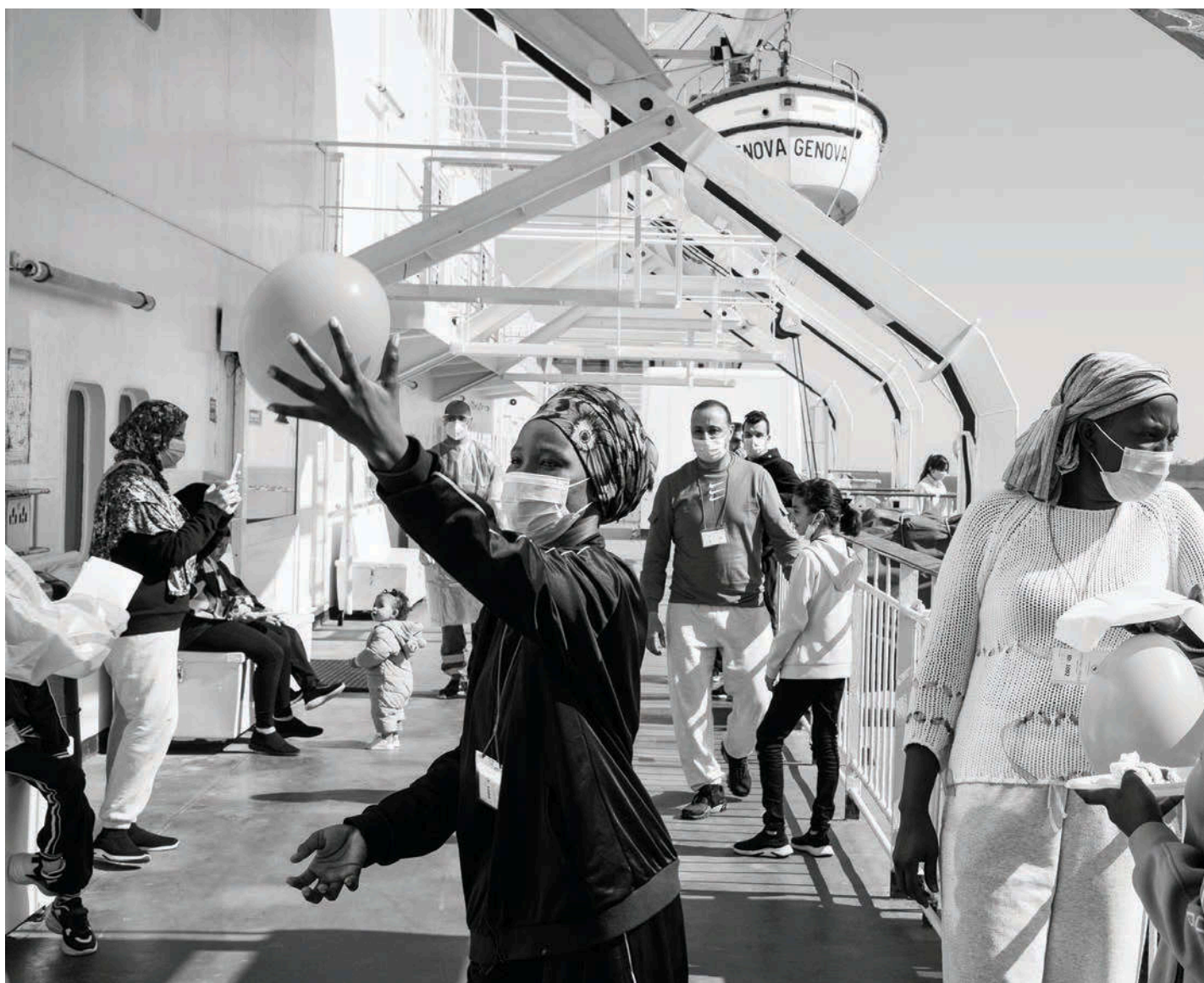
off Libya. A narrow metal ramp with rope railings was laid across the gap between the two ships for the migrants to walk across. First came a woman from Egypt, several months pregnant, with two toddlers in tow. Next came an unaccompanied 8-year-old girl from Morocco, wide-eyed and afraid. Then came others—from Tunisia, Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Libya, Syria, and parts of West Africa. As they arrived on the *Allegra*, a nurse took their temperature and Taskayali brought them to their rooms.

A few weeks later I joined Taskayali on *La Suprema*, where he was performing odd jobs. He brought migrants cellphone chargers, shampoo, and tampons. He fitted them for shoes, which most had arrived without. He handed out ointment for scabies, an intensely itchy and extremely contagious skin infestation that afflicted roughly a third of the migrants. He also plunged toilets, which were often clogged with underwear, flushed by migrants to protest their confinement on the ship. Because the Red Cross knew that my main goal was to shadow Taskayali and report on

what life aboard *La Suprema* was like, my only job was dinner duty, checking names and ID numbers on a clipboard as the migrants were handed a tray.

The migrants spent most of their time sitting on the floor in the hallways outside their cabins, huddled around their cellphones, watching music videos. The cabins typically held two or three people, the majority of them men between 15 and 25 years old, from Tunisia, Egypt, Libya, Somalia, Bangladesh, or Eritrea. On my second day aboard the ship, as I loitered awkwardly in a hallway feeling like a high-school misfit, a 15-year-old boy named Ahmed took pity on me, asking to see what music I had on my phone. Because my 17-year-old son listens mostly to international rap music, I have hundreds of hip-hop songs from Egypt, France, Tunisia, Algeria, and Venezuela on my phone. Ahmed reacted with shock to my collection; he immediately disappeared with my phone into a crowd that erupted in cheers as it played a song by Lacrim, a French Algerian rapper. After

PAOLO PELLEGRIN / MAGNUM



that, the teen boys called me “Music Man” and fist-bumped me when we crossed paths.

Most of the migrants told me they deeply appreciated the Red Cross workers, but they nonetheless felt imprisoned at sea and desperately feared deportation once they reached dry land. If migrants can’t prove that they are fleeing conflict or persecution, rather than poverty, Italy typically rejects their claims for asylum.

Several of the migrants I saw on La Suprema had extensive fuel burns: During their attempted crossings, gasoline had spilled in their dinghies, where it had mixed with seawater and then come in contact with their skin. People sitting or lying in the bottom of the dinghies are at the highest risk of such burns; fuel canisters often leak, get knocked over, or are emptied during frantic efforts to bail out dinghies if they start to sink. Nonetheless, women and children are often instructed to sit on the floor, because many people mistakenly believe it is the safest place on the boat. One doctor told me that some of the migrants she had attended to

on La Suprema had arrived so soaked in gasoline that merely handling their clothes had made her latex gloves melt.

At night, Taskayali’s job was to stand watch outside two glass doors on the eighth-floor deck, to ensure that none of the migrants went outside, where they might try to jump into the water and swim to shore. When the ship was in or near port, migrants would press their faces against the glass for hours, staring at the land.

During my week on La Suprema, the ship pulled into port twice to disembark people whose quarantine period had ended. The first time, as people left the vessel, they were met by dozens of police officers standing at the water’s edge, arms crossed, waiting to usher them onto buses and transport them to one or more of Italy’s many “reception centers.” These centers collectively house more than 75,000 migrants, most of whom are awaiting decisions about their asylum applications. After one group had disembarked, I followed the “sprayer” teams, clad in hazmat suits, who efficiently



Far left: Migrants on the deck of the Allegra celebrate a Libyan girl’s 10th birthday. Migrants are allowed on deck in small groups twice daily; those who test positive for COVID-19 are kept separate. Above: A migrant in his cabin on the Allegra. Left: Migrants converse on deck, in view of the Sicilian coastline.

disinfected the rooms, changed linens, scrubbed bathrooms, and otherwise prepared the ship for the next influx of migrants.

The second time La Suprema came into harbor, at the Port of Augusta, in the east of Sicily, I watched the police onshore grow impatient with a teenager who was scheduled to disembark. They wanted to arrest him, for reasons they did not disclose. Batons drawn, several uniformed officers walked up the ramp and onto the ship and grabbed the boy, who fell to the ground and tried to wriggle free. Other migrants began yelling. Shoving escalated into punches. The captain of La Suprema rushed to the scene. “You have no authority here,” he yelled at the officers. “You will leave my ship immediately!” They left, but soon after, the boy was removed from the ship by the Red Cross and arrested.

On board the ship, several migrants who had witnessed the scene went upstairs to their rooms, where they drank shampoo and other chemicals to induce vomiting, believing that their chances of staying in Italy would be greater if they were to land at a hospital rather than a reception center, because doctors might be more apt to help them than police or bureaucrats. At the end of October, nine Tunisians on one of the other quarantine ships had been evacuated after swallowing razor blades.

“If Libya is hell and Europe is heaven, this is purgatory,” Tas-kayali said to me one night at dinner.

ACCORDING TO THE UNITED NATIONS, more than 2.5 million migrants have made unauthorized crossings of the Mediterranean into Europe since the 1970s. In recent years, migration has spiked as asylum seekers have fled war and political instability in North Africa. In response, European nations have tried to halt the flow, causing this crossing to become what the UN has called “by far the world’s deadliest” for migrants. Since 2000, more than 35,000 of them have drowned or gone missing. This has exacerbated a humanitarian crisis as deep and inexorable as the sea itself.

In 2011, after the toppling of the dictator Muammar Qaddafi, the number of migrants using Libya as a departure point for Europe increased significantly, because people-smuggling networks could now operate there without constraint. Italy’s coalition government initially took a relatively open approach

to migration. In late 2013 and 2014, the Italian government plucked more than 140,000 people from the sea. The government’s hope was that Italy’s European neighbors would follow suit and provide rescue vessels, funding, and, most important, places to resettle the migrants.

That didn’t happen. As the rest of Europe failed to assist, Italian sentiment toward refugees curdled, and the government pulled back from rescues at sea. By 2016, various charities—large global aid agencies such as Save the Children and Médecins Sans Frontières, as well as newer, smaller groups—were trying to fill the gap, patrolling international waters off Libya and making about 25 percent of the rescues in the Mediterranean.

But by then these efforts were themselves coming under pressure. As part of an EU program called Operation Sophia and a subsequent deal between Libya and Italy, the latter agreed to provide ships, training, and millions of euros to Libya’s coast guard, which has been accused of threatening, boarding, and even opening fire on NGO ships. Critics said the now-moribund program constituted *refoulement* (from the French for “turning away”), a violation of international human-rights laws that say no one should be returned to a country where they would face torture or other degrading punishment. Operation Sophia began despite mounting evidence that Libyan smugglers, security forces, and the coast guard itself were committing atrocities against migrants. The migrants picked up by the coast guard tended to face grisly fates. According to a 2017 report by the German embassy in Niger, the detention centers in which Libya was confining migrants featured “concentration camp–like conditions”; the report documented widespread torture, rape, and executions. In September 2018, the UN High Commissioner for Refugees declared that nowhere in Libya should be considered safe for people rescued at sea.

Around the same time, Italy’s populist parties were speaking out against charity rescuers, accusing them of operating “sea taxi” services for migrants. In 2017, the chief of Frontex, the EU’s combined coast guard and border patrol—as well as the interior ministers of Austria and Germany—accused rescue-ship crews of supporting smugglers; within two years, prosecutors in Italy had opened criminal investigations against at least 12 NGO vessels for aiding and abetting illegal immigration. In

**AT THE END OF OCTOBER,
NINE TUNISIANS ON A QUARANTINE
SHIP WERE EVACUATED AFTER
SWALLOWING RAZOR BLADES.**



A migrant in his room in the COVID-positive section of the *Allegra*

2019, to discourage sea rescues, the Italian government began raising the fines that can be imposed on NGOs for entering Italian waters without permission and for carrying undocumented people to port. Those fines are now up to 50,000 euros, or about \$60,000, per violation.

The Italian government justified these actions by claiming that sea rescues encourage migrants to attempt the dangerous Mediterranean crossing. But this doesn't seem to be true. Matteo Villa, a migration researcher at the Italian Institute for International Political Studies, a nonpartisan think tank, has found that people make their decisions about whether to attempt a crossing based primarily on weather and local political conditions; rescue operations at sea do not increase the number of people who cross. These rescue operations do, however, significantly reduce the number of people who die trying: Villa determined that when such operations were disrupted by the Italian government in the first eight months of 2019, the death rate along the sea route from Libya more than tripled, from 2.1 percent to 6.7 percent.

By the end of 2020, virtually all the NGOs had stopped conducting sea rescues, mostly because their ships had been detained by EU authorities. According to Médecins Sans Frontières, the Libyan coast guard intercepted more than 11,700 migrants at sea last year, delivering many of them to the detention facilities that had been deemed unsafe by the UN.

This was the situation during my time on *La Suprema*—except that COVID-19 had made matters worse.

IT'S HARD TO MISS the irony in the use of cruise ships to forestall the spread of the coronavirus. One of the first serious COVID-19 outbreaks outside China was on the *Diamond Princess*, a British cruise ship that had stopped in the port of Yokohama, Japan, in early February, with more than 3,700 passengers and crew members on board. Over the following month, roughly one-fifth of the passengers tested positive; about a dozen people ultimately died. Mass outbreaks followed on the *Zaandam*, the *Rotterdam*, the *Greg Mortimer*, the *Ruby Princess*, and other ships. The ventilation on these ships seems to have been a contributing factor. According to Qingyan Chen, a mechanical-engineering professor at Purdue University who studies how airborne disease is transmitted indoors, many cruise ships' ventilation systems rely on recirculated air sent through low- or medium-strength air filters, causing airborne viruses to spread far faster than on airplanes.

But for Italy, the ships seemed to offer an expedient way to quell domestic concerns. Even though Italian health officials insisted that migrants had played only a "minimal" role in bringing the coronavirus into the country, fears that migrants were the source spread rapidly. In April 2020, Italy announced that, for



the first time ever, its harbors could no longer be considered “safe places” for migrant landings. Shortly thereafter, Malta, another popular landing spot for migrants, did the same. Soon, other EU countries were using fears about the virus to justify tightening their borders and diminishing their relocation efforts.

This was the point at which Italy decided to charter large ships to serve as floating quarantine centers. Health professionals and immigrant advocates criticized the plan, raising questions about the quality of medical care, psychological support, and legal assistance that would be available on board. And even though the ships were intended only to hold new arrivals, reports began to emerge that Italian authorities were transferring COVID-positive migrants who had been onshore for months to the ships.

When Francesco Rocca, the president of the Italian Red Cross, heard those reports, he called the Interior Ministry and warned that if officials were relocating migrants from on-land centers, or if they were holding migrants on ships for even a day more than the medically necessary quarantine period, he would order his staff to release people from the ships en masse. “I made it very clear to them,” Rocca told me. “We will participate so long as our job is not to run floating prisons.” The government quickly agreed.

ONE EVENING AROUND MIDNIGHT, not long before I arrived on *La Suprema*, a commotion erupted in the COVID-positive section of the ship, which held roughly 100

to 150 people. Earlier that day, about 40 people from that section of the ship had been informed that despite having already quarantined at sea for 10 days, they would be required to spend another 10 days in quarantine, because several of them were still testing positive. That night, 20 Syrian men from the section found an unlocked, unguarded door and slipped up a back stairwell to the uppermost deck. Guards quickly found them, and when they approached the men, tensions escalated. After some screaming and shoving, the Syrians sat down in a circle on the deck and began singing.

Worried that if the men dispersed, they would infect others on the ship, doctors at the scene telephoned Andi Nganso, the medical director of the quarantine ships, and asked what they should do. Nganso recommended bringing the men some food and water and letting them remain where they were. So the men stayed on deck all night long—talking, singing, lying on their back and staring up at the stars—while the guards and Red Cross workers kept watch at a distance. The next morning the men filed quietly back to their rooms as a group. “Key is to de-escalate,” Nganso said to me later about the incident.

A couple of weeks after that, Taskayali was on his way to his cabin when he passed a Libyan migrant in the stairwell. The man seemed distraught. Concerned, Taskayali made a U-turn and began following the man, who noticed and started to sprint. Taskayali gave chase, following him up to the eighth floor and



*Opposite page: In the COVID-positive section of the Allegra, a Red Cross medical staffer performs a nasal swab.
This page: Migrants celebrate receiving negative COVID-19 tests.*

onto the deck. After running the long way around a barrier to get to the port side of the ship, the man began climbing a railing. Taskayali tackled him before he could jump.

The man spoke with a trained mediator, who helped him calm down, and then he returned to his quarters. After the episode was over, Taskayali walked back to the spot where he had tackled the man. During the chase, he had assumed that the man was trying to escape the ship by leaping overboard into the ocean—looking over the railing, however, he saw not ocean but a concrete dock, eight stories down.

Nganso told me that no COVID-positive migrants on the quarantine ships had died or even needed to be intubated. “The real challenge,” he said, “is mental health.”

BORN IN ROME, Taskayali began studying piano when he was 6 and composing when he was 11. His talent earned him a deal with Warner Music when he was 24. On the *Allegra*, when Taskayali overheard another volunteer say that there was a piano, he decided to look for it. He found it in a cordoned-off section of the ship, in the back of a dark, empty restaurant

on the seventh floor: an upright Yamaha covered in dust. He sat down and played Chopin’s “Nocturne No. 20,” among the saddest songs he knew, and one of his favorites.

Word had spread among the Red Cross workers that a renowned pianist was in their midst, and several of them asked him to play a concert for them. He agreed, but asked if he could do a concert for the migrants too. The logistics were tough, but eventually he persuaded the ship’s captain to allow him to play for migrants on the upper deck during some of their outdoor smoke breaks. The concerts were inspiring. One day I watched Taskayali play “Eski Dostlar,” a traditional Turkish song, while a group of women from Sudan and Nigeria danced and ululated with joy. Another day, as Taskayali played a song he’d composed, called “Black Sea,” a group of teen boys from Egypt and Libya formed a circle and then took turns gyrating and break-dancing in the center as the others cheered. Another time, he played a famous 19th-century Italian protest song, “Bella Ciao,” which had been remixed in Tunisia into a popular song titled “Habiba Ciao.” When the migrants heard the tune, they exploded into clapping and cheering, grabbing me by the

arm and pulling me into their circle as they chanted “*Italia!*” and “Thank you, Red Cross!”

A couple of days later, I found Taskayali leaning over a railing, smiling coyly. He told me that he planned to play a concert in the COVID-19 ward, a section of the ship we were normally forbidden to visit. We met there that afternoon, and two Red Cross workers helped us into hazmat suits. Taskayali played for half an hour, during which the place vibrated with an invisible current. The migrants in this section, who rarely got visitors, seemed shocked that we had entered their area. After the concert, I noticed a man in his mid-30s standing silently in front of the keyboard, weeping. I asked him if he was okay. “This man, so kind,” the migrant kept saying. When Taskayali shyly tried to beat a hasty retreat, he was slowed by a gantlet of migrants wanting to take selfies with him. As we peeled off our hazmat suits, Taskayali turned to me and said, “I’ve never experienced anything as beautiful.”

Disembarking the *Allegra*: After the migrants’ quarantine period is over and they receive a final negative COVID-19 test result, they are released to Italian police and immigration authorities waiting onshore.

THESE MOMENTS OF BEAUTY stood out amid abiding pain. One afternoon, Taskayali was told to go check on a recently arrived 8-year-old Tunisian boy who had migrated alone. After some initial small talk, made possible by another migrant who spoke both Arabic and English, Taskayali asked the boy whether he had any relatives waiting for him in Italy. He responded that he had a friend in France. “I will find him,” the boy said.

“But where are your parents?” Taskayali replied, somewhat insistently. The boy looked down. Communicating with his hands, he indicated that his father had been hanged, and that his mother’s throat had been slit. Taskayali later told me he very much regretted the manner in which he had asked his question.

While helping serve meals to the migrants on *La Suprema*, I worked alongside a Red Cross officer named John Ogah. In 2013, because of growing violence in Nigeria from terrorist groups like Boko Haram, Ogah fled to Tripoli, where he shared an apartment with 15 other Nigerians and found work as a welder. One night, a group of armed Libyan men broke into the apartment to rob it, and in the process shot and killed one of Ogah’s apartment mates. This sort of thing was not out of the ordinary for migrants in Libya, Ogah told me. “Rapes and killings all the time,” he said.

Ogah decided to flee again, this time to Europe. He found a trafficker, covertly arranged passage across the Mediterranean on a boat carrying 300 other migrants, and, in May 2014, came ashore in Italy. He made his way to Rome, where he spent months living on the streets. To earn money, he begged and



PAOLO PELLEGRIN / MAGNUM

WHEN THE MIGRANTS HEARD THE TUNE, THEY EXPLODED INTO CLAPPING AND CHEERING, PULLING ME INTO THEIR CIRCLE AS THEY CHANTED “ITALIA!”

carried people's bags outside a supermarket in Rome's Centocelle neighborhood. One day, a man wearing a motorcycle helmet and carrying a large meat cleaver pushed past him into the grocery store. The man walked to the counter and demanded money from the register. Security footage from the store shows Ogah watching the incident. When the thief attempted to leave on his scooter, Ogah grabbed him, wrested the cleaver from him, and held him down until police arrived.

Because he didn't have immigration papers, Ogah quietly left the scene. But the police tracked him down, and the government awarded him with a one-year residency permit, which has since been extended. The police encouraged Ogah—who was raised Catholic but never baptized—to share his story with the Vatican. During a 2018 Easter Mass, Pope Francis baptized Ogah in a televised ceremony. The Red Cross hired him as a logistics officer.

By the time I met Ogah, many of the migrants on board La Suprema knew his story. When I asked one of the migrants what he hoped to become if he was allowed to stay in Europe, he said, “Like him,” and pointed at Ogah.

But Ogah's story is no fairy tale. One night not long ago, he called me to talk about the loneliness of life as an immigrant in Italy. “I don't have a girl. I don't have friends,” he said, adding that his pay was barely enough to get by on; after rent he could not buy all the groceries he needed. “I'm the luckiest immigrant I know,” he said, “but I didn't realize life would be like this here.”

ONE NIGHT ON THE ALLEGRA, Taskayali met a 15-year-old from Ivory Coast named Abou Diakite. The boy had arrived only two days earlier, after being rescued with nearly 200 other migrants off the coast of Libya by a Spanish nonprofit called Proactiva Open Arms. He had high cheekbones, wide eyes, and short, braided hair, and he sometimes wore a stud in one ear or a hoop in the other.

At the time of his rescue, Diakite was severely dehydrated and malnourished. He had scars on his limbs, which some thought may have come from his having been tortured in Libya. A week after boarding the rescue ship, he started suffering intense lower-back pain. He tested negative for COVID-19, and medical staff—suspecting a possible urinary-tract infection—put him

on antibiotics. When he was transferred to the Allegra the next day, his fever had gone down and he seemed to be improving.

But his condition soon worsened, and Red Cross officials requested that the Health Ministry allow an emergency evacuation, so that they could take Diakite to a hospital in Palermo. The day before the evacuation, Taskayali stayed up all night writing Diakite a farewell song, in three parts, the first corresponding to Diakite's departure from Ivory Coast, the second to his time on the ship, and the third to his arrival in Europe. The song was meant to convey a sense of hope—what Taskayali imagined Diakite would feel when he finally arrived on land in Italy.

The next morning, Diakite's friends helped him into an ill-fitting green hazmat suit and a new N95 mask. Diakite resisted, feebly; he had worked as a tailor in Ivory Coast, his friends said, and he cared about his clothes. Taskayali helped move Diakite onto a stretcher and down to the lowest deck. Onshore, an ambulance and a gaggle of police officers were waiting for him. As he was taken away, Taskayali pressed his shoulder and said, “My friend—the land, finally.” Barely conscious, Diakite did not reply.

He fell into a coma and was transferred to a second hospital in Palermo, due to lack of space in the first. He died shortly after arriving at the second hospital.

COUNTRIES MUST POLICE their borders. Managing immigration flow is never easy; COVID-19 has only made it harder. At least in the short term, quarantine ships represent an alluring fix to a politically thorny problem: Because of its remoteness, the sea is an attractive place for governments to detain migrants.

But the cost of this solution is that it renders an already voiceless demographic even more invisible. “When I was growing up, I always thought that the world was unfair,” Taskayali wrote to me when he learned of Diakite's death. “I lacked the proof until I found it at sea.” *A*

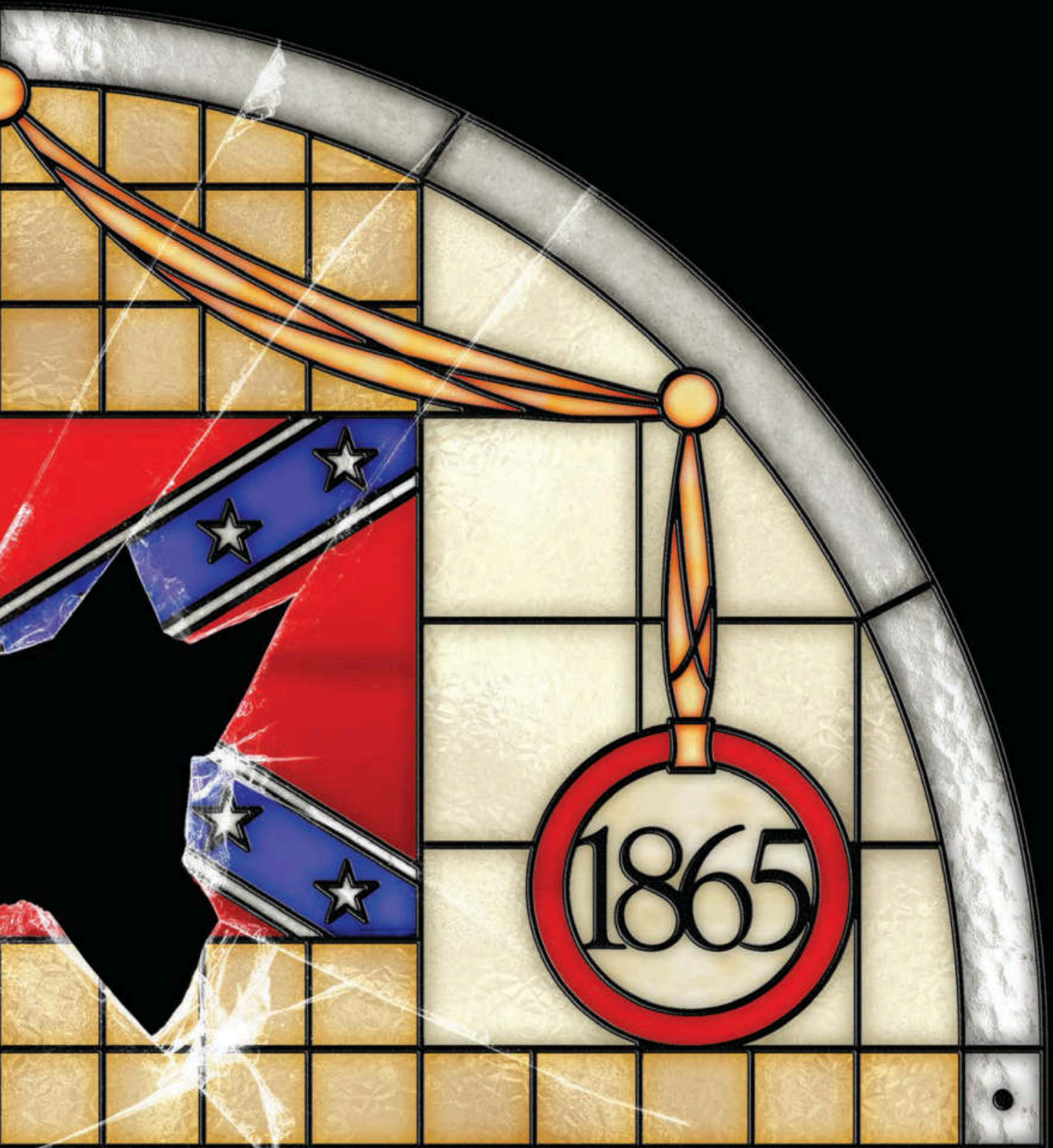
Ian Urbina is a contributing writer at The Atlantic, a Pulitzer Prize winner, and the director of the Outlaw Ocean Project, a nonprofit journalism organization that produces stories about crimes at sea. This story was supported by the Pulitzer Center.

THE WAR ON NOSTALGIA



*The myth of the Lost Cause is passed down like an heirloom.
What would it take for the truth to break through?*

BY CLINT SMITH





Most of the people who come to Blandford Cemetery, in Petersburg, Virginia, come for the windows—masterpieces of Tiffany glass in the cemetery’s deconsecrated church. One morning before the pandemic, I took a tour of the church along with two other visitors and our tour guide, Ken. When my eyes adjusted to the hazy darkness inside, I could see that in each window stood a saint, surrounded by dazzling bursts of blues and greens and violets. Below these explosions of color were words that I couldn’t quite make out. I stepped closer to one of the windows, and the language became clearer. Beneath the saint was an inscription honoring the men “who died for the Confederacy.”

Outside, lawn mowers buzzed as Black men steered them between tombstones draped in Confederate flags. The oldest marked grave at Blandford dates back to 1702; new funerals are held there every week. Within the cemetery’s 150 acres are the bodies of roughly 30,000 Confederate soldiers, one of the largest mass graves of Confederate servicemen in the country.

From 1866 into the 1880s, Ken told us, a group of local women organized the tracking-down and exhuming of those bodies from nearby battlegrounds. “They felt that the southern soldier had

not been treated with the same dignity and honor that the northern soldiers had,” and they wanted to do something about it. Most of the bodies were not identifiable; sometimes all that was left was a leg or an arm. Nonetheless, the remains were dug up and brought here, and the ladies refurbished the old church as a memorial to their fallen husbands, sons, and brothers.

Tiffany Studios cut them a deal on the stained glass: \$350 a piece instead of the usual price of about \$1,700 (\$51,000 today). Thirteen southern states donated funds. Ken outlined the aesthetic history of each window in meticulous detail, giving each color and engraving his thorough and intimate attention. But he said almost nothing about why the windows were there—that the soldiers memorialized in stained glass had fought a war to keep my ancestors in chains.

Almost all of the people who come to Blandford Cemetery are white. “It’s not that a Black population doesn’t appreciate the windows,” Ken, who is white, told me. “But sometimes in the context of what it represents, they’re not as comfortable.” He went on: “In most cases we try and fall back on the beauty of the windows, the Tiffany-glass kind of thing.”

But I couldn’t revel in the windows’ beauty without reckoning with what those windows represented. I looked around the church again. How many of the visitors to the cemetery today, I asked Ken, are Confederate sympathizers?

“I think there’s a Confederate *empathy*,” he replied. “People will tell you, ‘My great-great-grandmother, my great-great-grandfather are buried out here.’ So they’ve got long southern roots.”

We left the church, and a breeze slid across my face. Many people go to places like Blandford to see a piece of history, but history is not what is reflected in that glass. A few years ago, I decided to travel around America visiting sites that are grappling—or refusing to grapple—with America’s history of slavery. I went to plantations, prisons, cemeteries, museums, memorials, houses, and historical landmarks. As I traveled, I was moved by the people who have committed their

lives to telling the story of slavery in all its fullness and humanity. And I was struck by the many people I met who believe a version of history that rests on well-documented falsehoods.

For so many of them, history isn’t the story of what actually happened; it is just the story they want to believe. It is not a public story we all share, but an intimate one, passed down like an heirloom, that shapes their sense of who they are. Confederate history is family history, history as eulogy, in which loyalty takes precedence over truth. This is especially true at Blandford, where the ancestors aren’t just hovering in the background—they are literally buried underfoot.



WE WENT OVER to the visitors’ center, where Ken introduced me to his boss, Martha, a kind-looking woman with tortoiseshell glasses.

She said her interest in women’s history had drawn her to Blandford. “This is how they helped to get through their grief,” she told me. “And this is what their result was, this beautiful chapel.” She added, “I think you could take the Civil War aspect totally out of it and enjoy the beauty.”

I asked her whether Blandford was concerned that, by presenting itself in such a positive light, it might be distorting its connection to a racist and treasonous cause.

She told me that a lot of people ask why the war was fought. “I say, ‘Well, you get five different historians who have written five different books; I’m going to have five different answers.’

It's a lot of stuff. But I think from the perspective of my ancestors, it was not slavery. My ancestors were not slaveholders. But my great-great-grandfather fought. He had federal troops coming into Norfolk. He said, 'Nuh-uh, I've got to join the army and defend my home state.'"

As we spoke, I looked down at the counter and reached for one of the flyers stacked there. Martha's gaze followed my hand. Her face turned red and she thrust her hand down to flip the paper over, attempting to cover the rest of the leaflets. "Don't even look at this. I'm sorry," she said. "I will tell you, from a personal standpoint, I'm kind of bothered."

I looked at the flyer again, trying to read between her fingers. It was a handout for a Memorial Day event at Blandford hosted by the Sons of Confederate Veterans. Paul C. Gramling Jr., then the commander in chief of the group, would be speaking. It was May 2019, and the event was just a few weeks away.

"I don't mind that they come on Memorial Day and put Confederate flags on Confederate graves. That's okay," she said. "But as far as I'm concerned, you don't need a Confederate flag on—" She stumbled over a series of sentences

I couldn't follow. Then she collected herself and took a deep breath. "If you're just talking about history, it's great, but these folks are like, 'The South shall rise again.' It's very bothersome."

She told me that she'd attended a Sons of Confederate Veterans event once but wouldn't again. "These folks can't let things go. I mean, it's not like they want people enslaved again, but they can't get over the fact that history is history."

More people were coming into the visitors' center, and I didn't want to keep Ken and Martha from their work. We shook hands, and I made my way out the door. Before getting back in my car, I walked across the street, to another burial ground, this one much smaller. The People's Memorial Cemetery was founded in 1840 by 28 members of Petersburg's free Black community. Buried on this land are people who were enslaved; a prominent antislavery writer; Black veterans of the Civil War, World War I, and World War II; and hundreds of other Black residents.

There are far fewer tombstones than at Blandford. There are no flags on the graves. And there are no hourly tours for people to remember the dead. There is history, but also silence.

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AFTER MY VISIT to Blandford, I kept thinking about the way Martha had flipped over the Memorial Day flyer, the way her face had turned red. If she hadn't responded like that, I don't know that I would have felt so curious about what she was trying to hide. But my interest had been piqued. I wanted to find out what Martha was so ashamed of.

Founded in 1896, the Sons of Confederate Veterans describes itself as an organization of about 30,000 that aims to preserve "the history and legacy of these heroes, so future generations can understand the motives that animated the Southern Cause." It is the oldest hereditary organization for men who are descendants of Confederate soldiers. I was wary of going to the celebration alone, so I asked my friend William, who is white, to come with me.

The entrance to the cemetery was marked by a large stone archway with the words OUR CONFEDERATE HEROES on it. Maybe a couple hundred people were sitting in folding chairs around a large white gazebo. Children played tag among the trees; people hugged and slapped one another on the back. I felt like I was walking in on someone else's family reunion. Dixie flags bloomed from the soil like milkweeds. There were baseball caps emblazoned with the Confederate battle flag, biker vests ornamented with the seals of seceding states, and lawn chairs bearing the letters UDC, for the United Daughters of the Confederacy. In front of the gazebo were two flags, one Confederate, one American, standing side by side, as if 700,000 people hadn't been killed in the epic conflagration between them.

William and I stood in the back and watched. The event began with an honor guard—a dozen men dressed in Confederate regalia, carrying rifles with long bayonets. Their uniforms were the color of smoke; their caps looked as if they had been bathed in ash. Everyone in the crowd stood up as they marched by. The crowd recited the Pledge of Allegiance, then sang “The Star-Spangled Banner.” After a pause came “Dixie,” the unofficial Confederate anthem. The crowd sang along with a boisterous passion: “Oh, I wish I was in the land of cotton / Old times there

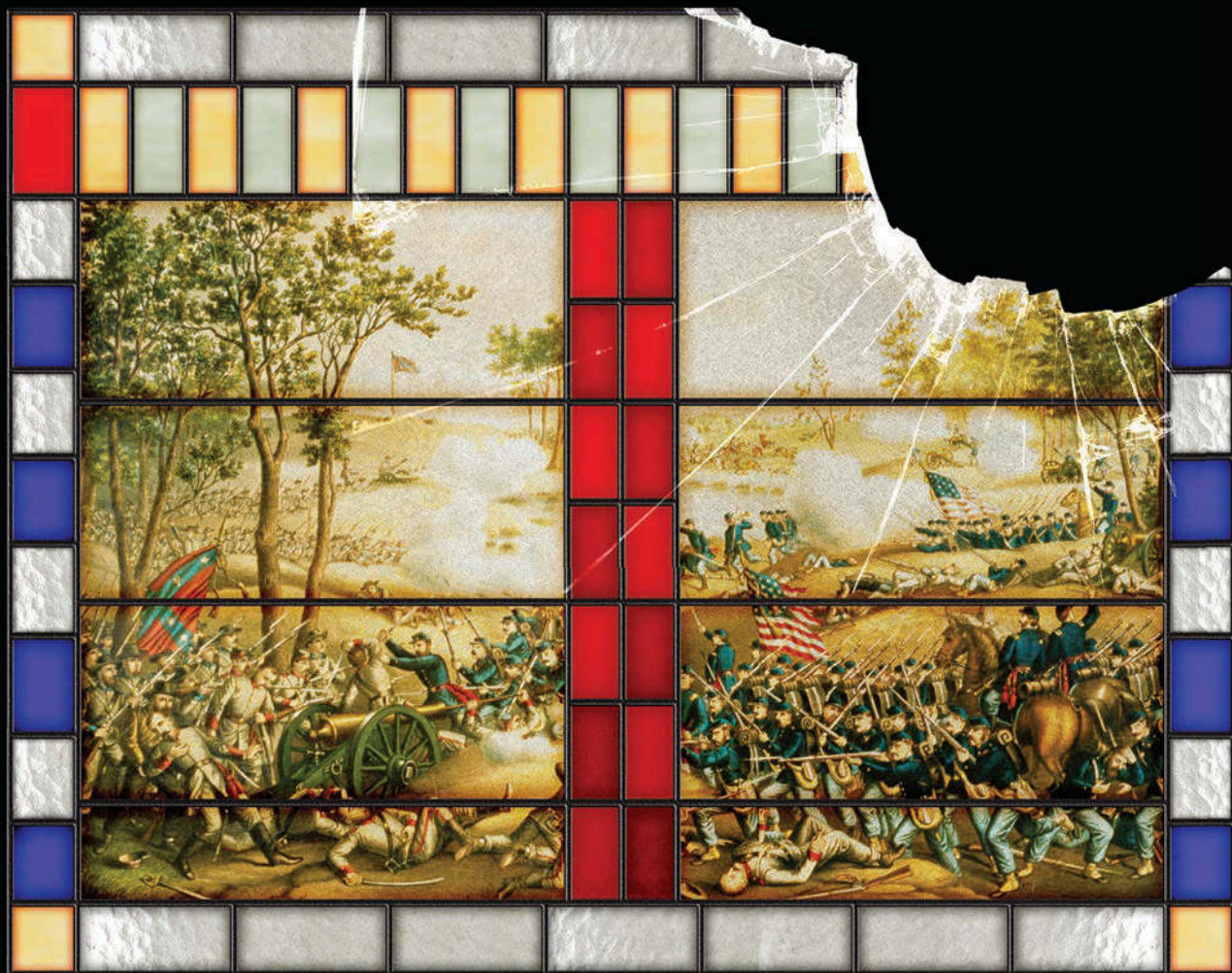
are not forgotten / Look away! Look away! Look away! Dixie Land.”

I glanced around as everyone sang in tribute to a fallen ancestral home. A home never meant for me. Speakers came to the podium, each praising the soldiers buried under our feet. “While those who hate seek to remove the memory of these heroes,” one said, “these men paid the ultimate price for freedom, and they deserve to be remembered.”

More than a few people turned around in their seat and looked with puzzlement, and likely suspicion, at the Black man they had never seen before

standing in the back of a Sons of Confederate Veterans crowd. A man to my right took out his phone and began recording me. The stares began to crawl over my skin. I had been taking notes; now I slowly closed my notebook and stuck it under my arm, doing my best to act unfazed. Without moving my head, I scanned the crowd again. The man in front of me had a gun in a holster.

A man in a tan suit and a straw boater approached the podium. His dark-blond hair fell to his shoulders, and a thick mustache and goatee covered his lips. I recognized him as Paul C. Gramling Jr. from



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the Confederacy and to “take back the narrative.” When his speech ended, two men in front of William and me started swinging large Confederate flags with unsettling fervor. Another speech was given. Another song was sung. Wreaths were laid. The honor guard then lifted its rifles and fired into the sky three times. The first shot took me by surprise, and my knees buckled. I shut my eyes for the second shot, and again for the third. I felt a tightening of muscles inside my mouth, muscles I hadn’t known were there.

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the flyer. He began by sharing a story about the origins of Memorial Day. “I don’t know if it’s true or not, but I like it,” he said, before reading aloud the account of a ceremony that took place on April 25, 1866, in Columbus, Mississippi, when a group of women “decorated the graves of both Union and Confederate soldiers.” Those soldiers, he continued, had “earned their rightful place to be included as American veterans. We should embrace our heritage as Americans, North and South, Black and white, rich and poor. Our American heritage is the one thing we have in common.”

Gramling’s speech was strikingly similar to those at Memorial Day celebrations after the end of Reconstruction, when orators stressed reconciliation, paying tribute to the sacrifices on both sides of the Civil War without accounting for what the war had actually been fought over.

Gramling then turned his attention to the present-day controversy about Confederate monuments—to the people who are “trying to take away our symbols.” In 2019, according to a report from the Southern Poverty Law

Center, there were nearly 2,000 Confederate monuments, place names, and other symbols in public spaces across the country. A follow-up report after last summer’s racial-justice protests found that more than 160 of those symbols had been removed or renamed in 2020.

Gramling said that this was the work of “the American ISIS.” He looked delighted as the crowd murmured its affirmation. “They are nothing better than ISIS in the Middle East. They are trying to destroy history they don’t like.”

I thought about friends of mine who have spent years fighting to have Confederate monuments removed. Many of them are teachers committed to showing their students that we don’t have to accept the status quo. Others are parents who don’t want their kids to grow up in a world where enslavers loom on pedestals. And many are veterans of the civil-rights movement who laid their bodies on the line, fighting against what these statues represented. None of them, I thought as I looked at the smile on Gramling’s face, is a terrorist.

Gramling urged all who were present to understand the true meaning of

“I DON’T KNOW if it’s true or not, but I like it”—I kept coming back to Gramling’s words. That comment was revealing. Many places in the South claim to be the originator of Memorial Day, and the story is at least as much a matter of interpretation as of fact. According to the historian David Blight, the first Memorial Day ceremony was held in Charleston, South Carolina, in May 1865, when Black workmen, most of them formerly enslaved, buried and commemorated fallen Union soldiers.

Confederates had converted Charleston’s Washington Race Course and Jockey Club into an outdoor prison for captured Union soldiers. The conditions were so terrible that nearly 260 men died and were buried in a mass grave behind the grandstand. After the Confederates retreated, Black men reburied the dead in proper graves and erected an archway bearing the words MARTYRS OF THE RACE COURSE. An enormous parade was held on the track, with 3,000 Black children

singing “John Brown’s Body,” the Union marching song. The first Memorial Day, as Blight describes it, received significant press coverage. But it faded from public consciousness after the defeat of Reconstruction.

It was then, in the late 1800s, that the myth of the Lost Cause began to take hold. The myth was an attempt to recast the Confederacy as something predicated on family and heritage rather than what it was: a traitorous effort to extend the bondage of millions of Black people. The myth asserts that the Civil War was fought by honorable men protecting their communities, and not about slavery at all.

We know this is a lie, because the people who fought in the Civil War told us so. “Our position is thoroughly identified with the institution of slavery—the greatest material interest of the world,” Mississippi lawmakers declared during their 1861 secession convention. Slavery was “the immediate cause of the late rupture and present revolution,” the Confederate vice president, Alexander Stephens, said, adding that the Confederacy was founded on “the great truth that the negro is not equal to the white man.”

The Lost Cause asks us to ignore this evidence. Besides, it argues, slavery wasn’t even that bad.

The early 1900s saw a boom in Confederate-monument building. The monuments were meant to reinforce white supremacy in an era when Black communities were being terrorized and Black social and political mobility were impeded. They were also intended to teach new generations of white southerners that the cause their ancestors had fought for was just.

That myth tried to rewrite U.S. history, and my visit to Blandford showed how, in so many ways, it had succeeded.

After the speeches, I began talking with a man named Jeff, who had a long salt-and-pepper ponytail and wore a denim vest adorned with Confederate badges. He told me that several of his ancestors had fought for the Confederacy. I asked what he thought of the event. “Well,” he said, “I think if anyone never knew the truth, they heard it today.”

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coming back to those words.*

He spoke about the importance of the Confederate flag and monuments, contending that they were essential pieces of history. “They need to be there for generations in the future, because they need to know the truth. They can’t learn the truth if you do away with history. You’ll never learn. And once you do away with that type of thing, you become a slave.”

I was startled by his choice of words but couldn’t tell whether it was intentionally provocative or rhetorical coincidence.

“I think everybody should learn the truth,” Jeff said, wiping the sweat from his forehead.

“What is that truth?” I asked.

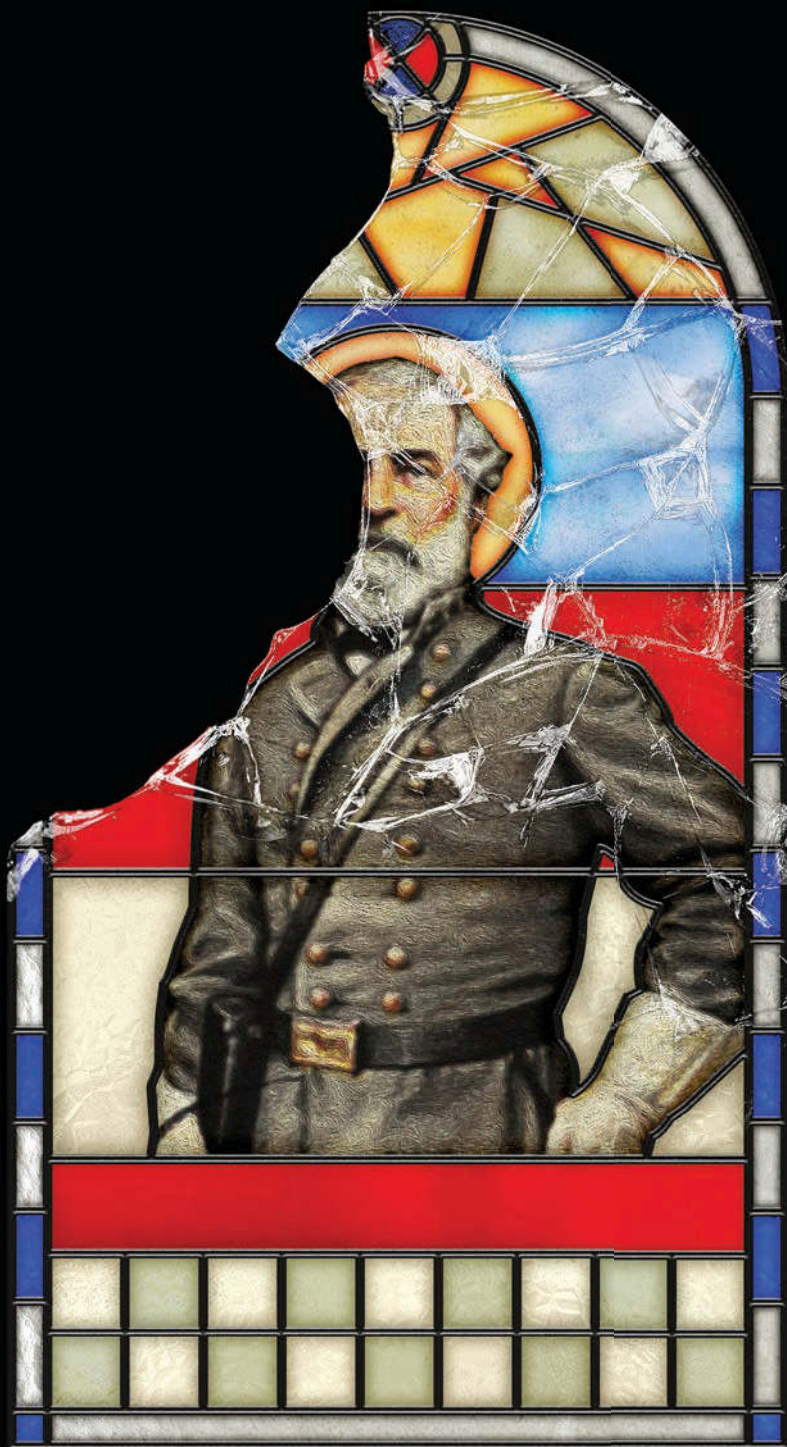
“Everybody always hears the same things: ‘It’s all about slavery.’ And it wasn’t,” he said. “It was about the fact that each state had the right to govern itself.”

He pointed to a tombstone about 20 yards away, telling me it belonged to a “Black gentleman” named Richard Poplar. Jeff said Poplar was a Confederate officer who was captured by the Union and told he would be freed if he admitted that he’d been forced to fight for the South. But he refused.

Poplar, I would learn, is central to the story many people in Petersburg tell about the war. The commemoration of Poplar seems to have begun in 2003, when the local chapter of the Sons of Confederate Veterans pushed for an annual “Richard Poplar Day.” In 2004, the mayor signed a proclamation establishing the holiday; she called Poplar a “veteran” of the Confederate Army. The tombstone with his name on it was erected at Blandford.

But the reality is that Black men couldn’t serve in the Confederate Army. And an 1886 obituary suggests that Poplar was a cook for the soldiers, not someone engaged in combat.

Some people say that up to 100,000 Black soldiers fought for the Confederate Army, in racially integrated regiments. No evidence supports these claims, as the historian Kevin M. Levin has pointed out, but appropriating the stories of men like Poplar is a way to protect the Confederacy’s legacy. If Black soldiers fought for the South, how could the war have been about slavery? How could it be considered racist now to fly the Dixie flag?



One Confederate general, Patrick Cleburne, actually did float the idea of using enslaved people as soldiers, but he was scoffed at. A senator from Virginia is reported to have asked, “What did we go to war for, if not to protect our property?” General Howell Cobb was even more explicit: “If slaves will make good soldiers, our whole theory of slavery is wrong.” In a desperate move just weeks before General Robert E. Lee’s surrender, the Confederacy approved legislation that would allow Black people to be used in battle. But by then it was too late.

I asked Jeff whether he thought slavery had played a role in the start of the Civil War. “Oh, just a very small part. I mean, we can’t deny it was there. We know slave blocks existed.” But only a small number of plantations even had slaves, he said.

It was a remarkable contortion of history, reflecting a century of Lost Cause propaganda.

Two children ran behind me, chasing a ball. Jeff smiled. He told me that he doesn’t call it the “Civil War,” because that distorts the truth. “We call it the ‘War Between the States’ or ‘of Northern Aggression’ against us,” he said. “Southern people don’t call it the Civil War, because they know it was an invasion ... If you stayed up north, ain’t nothing would’ve happened.”

When Jeff said “nothing would’ve happened,” I wondered if he had forgotten the millions of Black people who would have remained enslaved, those for whom the status quo would have meant ongoing bondage. Or did he remember but not care?

A mosquito buzzed by Jeff’s ear, and he swatted it away. He told me that 78 of his family members were buried in the cemetery, dating back to 1802, and that he had been coming here since he was 4 years old.

“Some nights I just sit there and just watch the deer come out,” he said, pointing to the gazebo, his voice becoming soft. “I just enjoy the feeling. I reminisce ... I want to preserve history and save what I can for my granddaughters.

“This is a place of peace,” he said. “The dead don’t bother me. It’s the living that bother me.”

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A LITTLE LATER, I was speaking with a mother and son about how often they came to events like these when a man in a Confederate uniform, carrying a saber in his left hand, approached us and stood a few feet away. I watched him from the corner of my eye, unsure whether he was trying to intimidate me or join the conversation.

I turned toward him, introducing myself and getting his name: Jason. He had a thick black beard and a mop of hair underneath his gray cap. He told me that “Civil War reenactor” had sounded like a cool job. “I didn’t realize it’s all volunteer,” he said with a laugh.

I asked him what he believed the cause of the Civil War had been. “How do I put this gently?” he said. “People are not as educated as they should be.” They’re taught that “these men were fighting to keep slavery legal, and if that’s what you grow up believing, you’re looking at people like me wearing this uniform: ‘Oh, he’s a racist.’” He said he’d done a lot of research and decided the war was much more complicated.

“We used to be able to stand on the monuments on Monument Avenue [in Richmond, Virginia]—those Lee and Jackson monuments. We can’t do it anymore, ’cause it ain’t safe. Someone’s gonna drive by and shoot me. You know, that’s what I’m afraid of.”

I thought that scenario was unlikely; cities have spent millions of dollars on police protection for white nationalists and neo-Nazis, people far more extreme than the Sons of Confederate Veterans. I found it a little ironic that these monuments had been erected in part to instill

fear in Black communities, and now Jason was the one who felt scared.

The typical Confederate soldier hadn’t been fighting for slavery, he argued. “The average age was 17 to 22 for a Civil War soldier. Many of them had never even seen a Black man. The rich were the ones who had slaves. They didn’t have to fight. They were draft-exempt. So these men are going to be out here and they’re going to be laying down their lives and fighting and going through the hell of camp life—the lice, the rats, and everything else—just so this rich dude in Richmond, Virginia, or Atlanta, Georgia, or Memphis, Tennessee, can have some slaves? That doesn’t make sense . . . No man would do that.”

But the historian Joseph T. Glatthaar has challenged that argument. He analyzed the makeup of the unit that would become Lee’s Army of Northern Virginia and pointed out that “the vast majority of the volunteers of 1861 had a direct connection to slavery.” Almost half either owned enslaved people or lived with a head of household who did, and many more worked for slaveholders, rented land from them, or had business relationships with them.

Many white southerners who did not own enslaved people were deeply committed to preserving the institution. The historian James Oliver Horton wrote about how the press inundated white southerners with warnings that, without slavery, they would be forced to live, work, and inevitably procreate with their free Black neighbors.

The *Louisville Daily Courier*, for example, warned nonslaveholding white southerners about the slippery slope of abolition: “Do they wish to send their children to schools in which the negro children of the vicinity are taught? Do they wish to give the negro the right to appear in the witness box to testify against them?” The paper threatened that Black men would sleep with white women and “amalgamate together the two races in violation of God’s will.”

These messages worked, Horton’s research found. One southern prisoner of war told a Union soldier standing watch, “You Yanks want us to marry

our daughters to niggers”; a Confederate artilleryman from Louisiana said that his army had to fight against even the most difficult odds, because he would “never want to see the day when a negro is put on an equality with a white person.”

The proposition of equality with Black people was one that millions of southern white people were unwilling to accept. The existence of slavery meant that, no matter your socioeconomic status, there were always millions of people beneath you. As the historian Charles Dew put it, “You don’t have to be actively involved in the system to derive at least the psychological benefits of the system.”

Jason and I were finishing our conversation when another man, with a thick gray beard and a balding head, walked up to us. We shook hands as he and Jason greeted each other warmly. “He’s a treasure trove of information,” Jason said. I mentioned that I had seen him talking with my friend William. “I been in his ear good,” the man said, telling me that he’d even given him his phone number. I said that was very generous. He looked at me, his eyes searching. His face shifted. “I told him, if you write about my ancestors”—the air trembled between us—“I want it to be correct. I’m concerned about the truth, not mythology.”

L

LIKE BLANDFORD CEMETERY, the Whitney Plantation in Louisiana has a church. It is large and white and flaked with a thin coat of dirt. The door whistles as it opens, and the wooden floor

moans under your feet as you step inside. There are no stained-glass windows here.

Instead, scattered throughout the church's interior—standing next to the pews, sitting on the floor, hiding in the corners—are statues. There are more than two dozen of them, life-size sculptures of children with eyes like small, empty planets. The boys wear shorts or overalls; the girls, simple dresses. When I saw them I was startled because, at first glance, I thought they were real. Each one was so alive despite its inanimateness, intricately detailed from the contours of the lips to the bridge of the nose. They look like they're listening, or waiting. They are *The Children of Whitney*, designed for the plantation by the artist Woodrow Nash.

Once one of the most successful sugarcane enterprises in all of Louisiana, the Whitney is surrounded by a constellation of former plantations that host lavish events—bridal parties dancing the night away on land where people were tortured, taking selfies in front of the homes where enslavers lived. Visitors bask in nostalgia, enjoying the antiques and the scenery. But the Whitney is different. It is the only plantation museum in Louisiana with an exclusive focus on enslaved people. The old plantation house still stands—alluring in its decadence—but it's not there to be admired. The house is a reminder of what slavery built, and the grounds are a reminder of what slavery really meant for the men, women, and children held in its grip.

On a plot of earth tucked into a corner of the property, between a white wooden fence and a redbrick path, are the dark heads of 55 Black men, impaled on silver stakes. Their eyes are shut, their faces peaceful or anguished. They're ceramic, but so lifelike that the gleam of the sun could as easily be the sheen of blood and sweat. These heads represent the rebels in the largest slave revolt in American history, which took place not far from here in 1811. Within 48 hours, local militia and federal troops had suppressed the uprising. Many rebels were slaughtered, their heads cut off and posted on stakes lining the Mississippi River.

Like Blandford, the Whitney also has a cemetery, of a kind. A small courtyard called the Field of Angels memorializes the 2,200 enslaved children who died in St. John the Baptist Parish from 1823 to 1863. Their names are carved into granite slabs that encircle the space. My tour guide, Yvonne, the site's director of operations, explained that most had died of malnutrition or disease. Yvonne, who is Black, added that there were stories of some enslaved mothers killing their own babies, rather than sentencing them to a life of slavery.

At the center of the courtyard is a statue of an angel down on one knee. Her chest is bare and a pair of wings juts from her back. Her hair is pulled into thick rows of braids and her head is bent, eyes cast downward at the limp body of the small child in her hands.

My own son was almost 2 at the time, and his baby sister was a couple of weeks from making her way into the world. This child, cradled in the angel's hands, evoked in me a surge of grief I had not expected. I felt the blood leave my fingers. I had to push out of my head the image of my own child in those hands. I had to remind myself to breathe.

"There's so many misconceptions about slavery," Yvonne said. "People don't really consider the *children* who were brought over, and the children who were born into this system, and the way to get people to let their guard down when they come here is being confronted with the reality of slavery—and the reality of slavery is child enslavement."

Before the coronavirus pandemic, the Whitney was getting more than 100,000 visitors a year. I asked Yvonne if they were different from the people who might typically visit a plantation. She looked down at the names of the dead inscribed in stone. "No one is coming to the Whitney thinking they're only coming to admire the architecture," she said.

Did the white visitors, I asked her, experience the space differently from the Black visitors? She told me that the most common question she gets from white visitors is "I know slavery was bad ... I don't mean it this way, but ... Were there any good slave owners?"

She took a deep breath, her frustration visible. She had the look of someone professionally committed to patience but personally exhausted by the toll it takes.

"I really give a short but nuanced answer to that," she said. "Regardless of how these individuals fed the people that they owned, regardless of how they clothed them, regardless of if they never laid a hand on them, they were still sanctioning the system ... You can't say, 'Hey, this person kidnapped your child, but they fed them well. They were a good person.' How absurd does that sound?"

But so many Americans simply don't want to hear this, and if they do hear it, they refuse to accept it. After the 2015 massacre of Black churchgoers in Charleston led to renewed questions about the memory and iconography of the Confederacy, Greg Stewart, another member of the Sons of Confederate Veterans, told *The New York Times*, "You're asking me to agree that my great-grandparent and great-great-grandparents were monsters."

So much of the story we tell about history is really the story we tell about ourselves. It is the story of our mothers and fathers and their mothers and fathers, as far back as our lineages will take us. They are the stories Jeff tells as he sits watching the deer scamper among the Blandford tombstones at dusk. The stories he wants to tell his granddaughters when he holds their hands as they walk over the land. But just because someone tells you a story doesn't make that story true.

Would Jeff's story change, I wonder, if he went to the Whitney? Would his sense of what slavery was, and what his ancestors fought for, survive his coming face-to-face with the Whitney's murdered rebels and lost children? Would he still be proud? *A*

Clint Smith is a staff writer at The Atlantic. This article has been adapted from his new book, How the Word Is Passed: A Reckoning With the History of Slavery Across America.

Estebanico's America

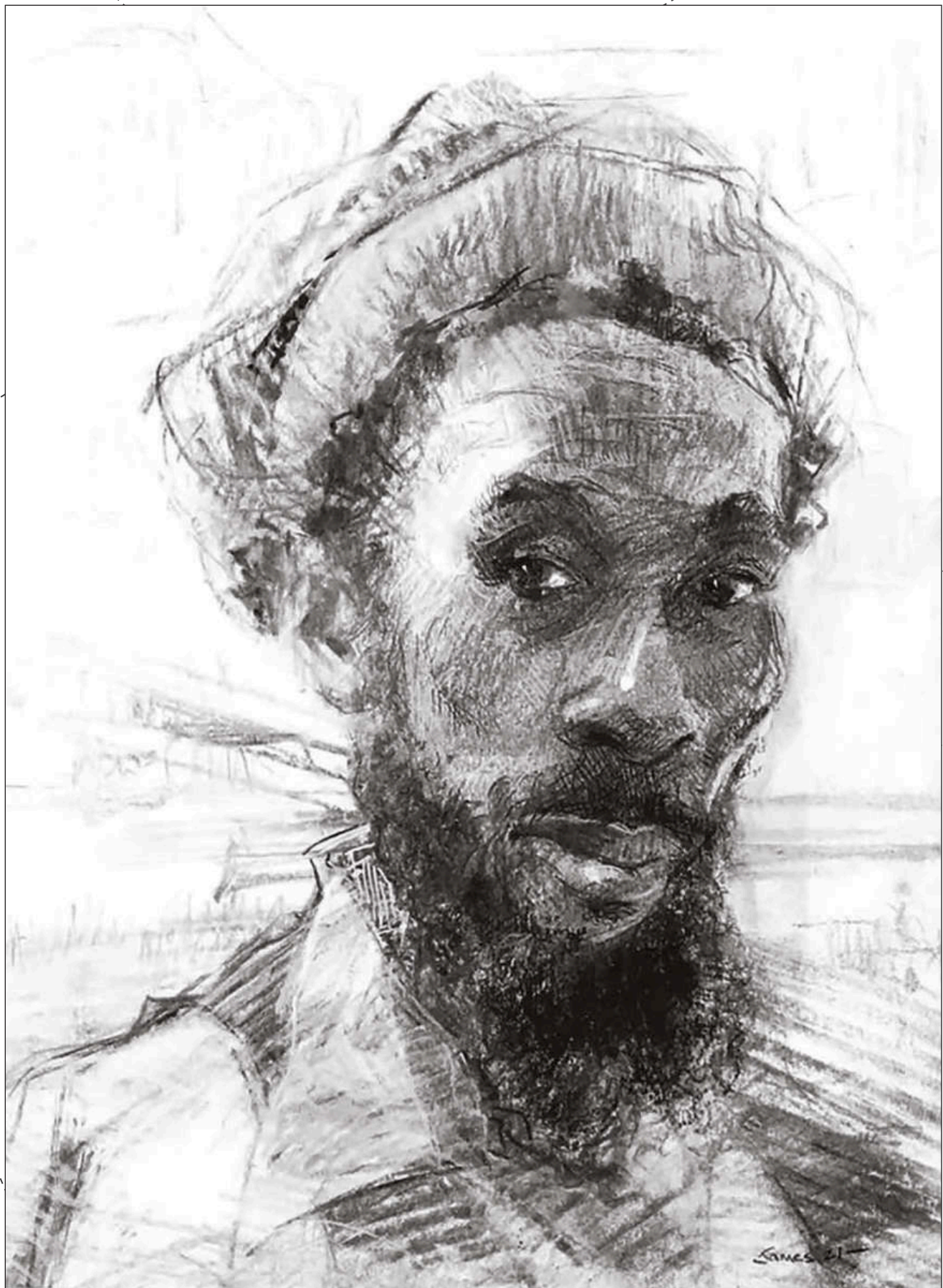
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*The story of Africans on
this continent is longer and
more varied than the version
I was taught in school.*

✱

BY

Annette Gordon-Reed



W

When I was growing up in Conroe, Texas, about 40 miles north of Houston, my classmates and I took Texas history twice, in the fourth and seventh grades. We learned about Texas's history in the United States, its previous existence as a republic, and its time as a province of Mexico. Among other things, we were exhorted to "remember the Alamo" and "remember Goliad," famous events in Texas's fight for independence from Mexico. Some other aspects of the state's history were less covered. I didn't need school lessons to tell me that Black people had been enslaved in Texas, but in the early days of my education, the subject was not often mentioned.

Some of our lessons did, however, involve the "period of Spanish exploration." And I remember hearing in those lessons stray references to a man of African descent—a "Negro" named Estebanico—who traveled throughout what would become Texas. Estebanico was described, according to Andrés Reséndez's book *A Land So Strange: The Epic Journey of Cabeza de Vaca*, as a "black Arab from Azamor," on the coast of Morocco. A Muslim, he had been forced to convert to Christianity and sold away from his home to Spain; he eventually found his way to Texas in the company of the famous explorer Álvaro Núñez Cabeza de Vaca. He arrived in the area of the future Galveston, where Union General Gordon Granger would proclaim the end of the Civil War and the end of slavery in Texas more than 300 years later, on the day now known as Juneteenth. Estebanico's journey across Texas as an interpreter for Cabeza de Vaca made him one of the first people of African descent to enter the historical record in the Americas. He was part of a cohort of African people who predated plantation slavery in the Americas, and had stories and legacies outside that institution. And the time in which he entered the story of the continent—in the 1520s—is roughly a century earlier than when the most popular stories about Black people in America begin.

The arrival in Virginia in the early 1600s of "20. and odd negroes," as John Rolfe announced, is often taken as the beginning of what we might call Black America—from that 20 to nearly

47 million souls today. Historians study those earliest years to, among other things, pinpoint the beginning of American slavery. They also look to this time to see if they can discover how deeply ideas about race were embedded in the culture of the people who established the English colony in Virginia. From these histories, people create and curate origin stories, of both themselves and the ideas they hold. And what these stories leave out—including Estebanico, the period of Spanish exploration, and years of Black and Indigenous history on the continent—is as important as what they include.

Origin stories matter, for individuals, groups of people, and nations. They inform our sense of self, telling us what kind of people we believe we are, what kind of nation we believe we live in. They usually carry, at least, a hope that where we started might hold the key to where we are in the present. We can say, then, that much of the concern over origin stories is about our current needs and desires, not actual history. Origin stories seek to find the familiar, or the superficially familiar—memory, sometimes shading into mythology. Both memory and mythology have their uses, even if they must be separated from the facts of the past. But in the case of Black people, the limitations of the history and possibility of our origin stories have helped create and maintain an extremely narrow construction of Blackness.

THE TWO ORIGIN STORIES that American children are most often taught are those of Jamestown, Virginia, an English colony founded in 1607 as a moneymaking venture, and Plymouth, Massachusetts, where people escaped religious persecution in 1620. The latter narrative is more inspirational and more in keeping with America's sense of moral exceptionalism than the former, which is perhaps why it has tended to loom larger in the American mind. Both origin stories emphasize the triumph of amity over enmity between Indigenous people and English settlers, something very different from what actually happened. But Black people are absent in the story of Plymouth, and the role of Jamestown as a hub of chattel slavery is often minimized. For Black Americans, neither origin story is sufficient.

Another origin story might be more suitable. St. Augustine, Florida, was not at all a part of my early education, but it's where race-based slavery, as an organized system, began on American soil, established by the Spanish as early as 1565. Enslaved and free African laborers helped build the settlement and its fortifications. In 1693, the king of Spain offered freedom in Florida to enslaved people who escaped from the British colonies if they converted to Catholicism and swore their allegiance, and in 1738, the Spanish governor established a settlement for them in St. Augustine. The story of Africans in St. Augustine is rich, as documented in surviving parish records. The settlement of free Blacks existed in some form until the British acquired Florida in the Treaty of Paris in 1763.

I had heard of St. Augustine by the time I got to college. But even then, it was presented as a historical footnote. The English had "won" the contest against the Spanish in North America—in Texas and in Florida. What was the point of incorporating this story of Africans and Spanish people into the general narrative

of American history or, more specifically, the history of African Americans? The same could be said of the French, in their beaver-trapping colonies near the Great Lakes. They were “also rans” in the race for the territory that became the United States. The French influence in Louisiana—its civil-law approach to marriage, its stratification of people of African descent into several social spheres based on white ancestry, the French Quarter in New Orleans, the arrival of Cajuns (descendants of the people exiled in the 18th century from the French colony Acadia by the victorious British)—has been treated as mere seasoning for a culture almost universally recognized as Anglo-American. Similarly, the brief period of Dutch slave ownership in New York is almost totally out of the picture.

THE STORY OF ESTEBANICO is part of this historical marginalia. Estebanico came to the Americas with the man who enslaved him, Andrés Dorantes, and Cabeza de Vaca, two of the leaders of a 300-person expedition to Florida and lands west. A series of disasters—food shortages, illness, and skirmishes with Indigenous people—spurred them to cross the Gulf. The men built rafts and split up, 50 men to a raft.

Dorantes, Estebanico, and most of the men on their raft made it to Texas, as did Cabeza de Vaca and most of the men on his. The other parties landed south of them and died as a consequence of either attacks by Native Americans or starvation. Dorantes’s party made contact with Cabeza de Vaca and his party. Many died during a cold and hard winter. Estebanico ended up in a small group with Dorantes, Cabeza de Vaca, and another man. Their ordeal moved into another phase when they were enslaved by Indigenous groups living along the Texas Gulf Coast. The men endured almost six years of slavery but eventually managed to escape. They then embarked upon an epic journey, walking for about 10 months across Texas and Mexico to the Pacific Coast.

Cabeza de Vaca, who wrote a widely read memoir about the extraordinary adventure, noted that Estebanico had played a key role as the chief translator between the Spaniards and the Indigenous people they encountered along the way, because of his great talent for learning and speaking languages. Estebanico appears to have achieved a measure of respect among his fellow explorers, but that respect disappeared once he and his fellow wanderers came upon a group of Spaniards in what is now Sinaloa State, in northwestern Mexico. Once they were

safe and back among a strong complement of other Spaniards, Estebanico’s Spanish companions were again in their element, and Estebanico was, again, their slave.

Like Estebanico’s journey, the experiences of so many other Black people and communities have been pushed to the sidelines, held in thrall to the prerogatives of white storytellers and the needs of white origin stories: The United States’ own nationalist-oriented history focuses intensely on what happened within the boundaries of the British colonies, and on the perspective of English-speaking people. The world enclosed in that way leaves out so much about the true nature of life in early America, about all the varied influences that shaped the people and circumstances during those times. That focus prevents vital understanding about contingency—how things could have taken a different turn.

ACCORDING TO THE conventional narrative with which most Americans, it is safe to say, are familiar, Black people came to North America under the power of the English from places that were never clearly identified, because where they came from

didn’t matter much. They went from speaking the languages of their homelands to speaking English. They worked on plantations, in the fields or in the house. This highly edited origin story winds the Black experience tight. To be sure, the institution of slavery itself circumscribed the actions of enslaved Black people, but it never destroyed their personhood. They did not become a separate species because of the experience of being enslaved. All of the feelings, talents, failings, strengths, and weaknesses—all of the states and qualities that exist in human beings—remained in them. There has been too great a tendency within some presentations of enslaved people to lose sight of that fact, in ways obvious and not.

We can see this tendency in the historical treatment of that most basic of human traits: the ability of enslaved people to acquire language and speak. Estebanico’s tal-

ent for languages might seem to mark him as exceptional, but actually helps us understand the multilingual nature of slavery and enslaved people. For example, Dutch was the first language of the noted abolitionist Sojourner Truth, born Isabella Baumfree in Swartekill, New York, near the end of the 1790s. She almost certainly spoke English with a Dutch-inflected accent. Yet reproductions of her speech were written in the stereotypical dialect universally chosen to portray the speech of enslaved Black

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people, no matter where in the country they lived. Under this formulation, the experiences of growing up hearing and speaking Dutch had no effect on Truth. It was as if the legal status of being enslaved and the biological reality of having been born of African descent fixed her pattern of speech, almost as a matter of brain function.

When I was working on my first book, writing about the way historians had handled the story of Thomas Jefferson and Sally Hemings, I noticed that one line of attack on the veracity of Madison Hemings's statements to the journalist Samuel Wetmore, in which he said that he was the son of Jefferson and Hemings, was to suggest that they were unreliable because they had been recorded in standard English. The notion that a formerly enslaved person could speak that way was treated as presumptively incredible. Even a brief thought about the circumstances of Hemings's life, viewing him as a human being, tells a different story. Hemings's recollections make clear that his older siblings—Beverley and Harriet—left Monticello to live as white people. Both married white people who may not have known that their spouses were partly Black and had been born enslaved. The communities where they lived evidently did not know that either.

How did Madison Hemings's siblings live convincingly as white if they spoke in the dialect applied universally to enslaved people? Why would Madison speak differently than his siblings? Taking into account the Hemingses' actual circumstances would have proved absurd the assumption that Madison Hemings could not have spoken in the way portrayed in his conversation with Wetmore.

A similar analysis, or lack of analysis, has often been at play in writings about the Hemings children's mother, Sally. As I have traveled the country talking about the books I have written about the Hemings family, I've been struck by the responses to the fact that Sally Hemings and her brother James learned to speak French during their years in France. On several occasions I have been asked, with seeming wonder, how they could have learned to speak French. How could they have gotten along there? Because slavery in the United States was racially based, it was easy to graft the legally imposed incapacities of slavery onto Black people as a group, making incapacity an inherent feature of the race.

Perhaps there is something about French, for a long time the language of diplomacy and culture. It is considered "fancy" in a way that goes along with the country's cuisine and vaunted high fashion—haute cuisine, haute couture. What of individuals born at the lowest rung of society? Could enslaved people, Black people, ever lay claim to sophistication? More than a century after James and Sally Hemings's time in France, Secretary of State William Jennings Bryan, while contemplating a crisis in Haiti, exclaimed, "Dear me. Think of it. N*****s speaking French."

The fiction that has African Americans naturally speaking in a particular way, or unable to learn a language, slyly promotes the notion that Black people are somewhat less than human. At the very least, the ideas about Black people and language convey the supposed gulf that exists between the races. Editors and



St. Augustine, Florida, was the site of the oldest free Black community in what is now the United States.

interviewers for the Federal Writers' Project ex-slave narratives of the 1930s, which gathered the recollections of formerly enslaved people, engaged in a concerted effort to render the speech of the interviewees into stereotypical Black dialect. As a result, the accents and speech of all the interviewees—whether from Virginia or Georgia or Texas—appear exactly the same. The exaggerated



dialect was supposed to signal “authenticity”—an authenticity defined by incapacity.

I don’t recall whether Estebanico’s language skills featured in the fleeting mention that was made of him in my early education. I do wonder what difference it might have made to my and my classmates’ understanding about the enslaved to have had a more fully realized example of someone who displayed such perseverance and talent. Estebanico was a flawed man—there were complaints about his treatment of some of the women he encountered, and

he ultimately died in a hail of arrows, killed by Native Americans after he insisted on taking gifts of “turquoise and women” from them—but even these negative notes would have helped us see him as a human being with strengths and weaknesses. We would have encountered a known person, to substitute for the nameless people in cotton fields who, at least in my education, never broke out or appeared as anything other than fungible agricultural workers. Of course, I know now that the lives of enslaved field-workers were more complicated than portrayed during my childhood, and

worshipping heroism, as typically defined, works against the idea that the lives of common people count and hold lessons for us as well. But learning that the Spanish explorers and the Indigenous people they encountered and lived with at times relied on Estebanico to help them speak with each other brings another dimension to our understandings about slavery and the people enslaved.

Even more, knowing that some of the Black people who came to the Americas with the Spanish went off on their own to lead expeditions in Mexico, Central America, and South America would have altered the framework for viewing people of African descent in the New World. Africans were all over the globe, having all kinds of experiences. Some founded free settlements, decades before the English arrived. Some, like Estebanico, were instruments of conquests. Some became bound to the institution of chattel slavery. But in all that, one thing is certain: Blackness does not equal inherent incapacity or limitation.

OVER THE PAST several decades, academic historians have emphasized that enslaved people in North America did more than work in the fields. The insights from this scholarship have filtered down to public-history sites where enslaved people lived and labored, changing the presentations at those places. If one goes to Colonial Williamsburg, in Virginia, one sees actors portraying enslaved people who were skilled artisans of one sort or another. At Monticello, guides point out the work of John Hemmings, the carpenter and joiner who made furniture for Jefferson and worked on the physical structures of both Monticello and Poplar Forest, Jefferson's home away from home in Bedford County, 90 miles from his mountaintop mansion.

As has been said many times, Black history is American history. People of African descent, however, occupy a special place in the narrative of the rise and fall of European nations in North America. For all its problems, nationalist-oriented history presented a cogent telling of the origins of the United States, though a superficial one. It made some degree of sense to sunset the influence of the other European nations with which the English settlers contended for control of the continent. American culture continued under the influence of what had been, at the time of the separation, a British society.

But a closer look at the story of the 20 or so Africans who landed at Jamestown contains a hint of the broader nature of the origin story: The Africans, from the region of Angola, had been taken after a battle with a Portuguese galleon. The Spanish, and their Portuguese neighbors, had been enslaving Africans, working with elites within African societies, for centuries by this time. The English were relative newcomers to the practice. The

field of Atlantic history, which studies the era of contact among the peoples of Africa, Europe, and the Americas in the 16th through 18th centuries, began to take hold in the 1980s, when I was in college and law school. It has expanded further, as a challenge to inward-looking nationalist history. Thinking of these interactions as part of a global system makes even more clear that the origin story of Africans in North America is much richer and more complicated than many people like to believe.

Would it make sense for African Americans enslaved under English rule to think they had absolutely no connection to enslaved people who spoke Spanish or French? What enslaved Africans had in common, what really ordered their lives, was the experience of enslavement in a world where the notion of white supremacy was ascendant. National borders cannot contain the experiences shared by families enslaved across the Caribbean and the entire breadth of two continents. There is no reason for the people taken from Africa to define themselves strictly by the countries, languages, or societal roles their captors created. Even

though the Spanish "lost" Texas and Florida, Estebanico and the Spanish-speaking Blacks of St. Augustine should be seen as a part of the origin story of African Americans. The echoes of that world reverberated from the 1500s through to my classrooms in the 1960s and '70s, and continue to reverberate today. *A*

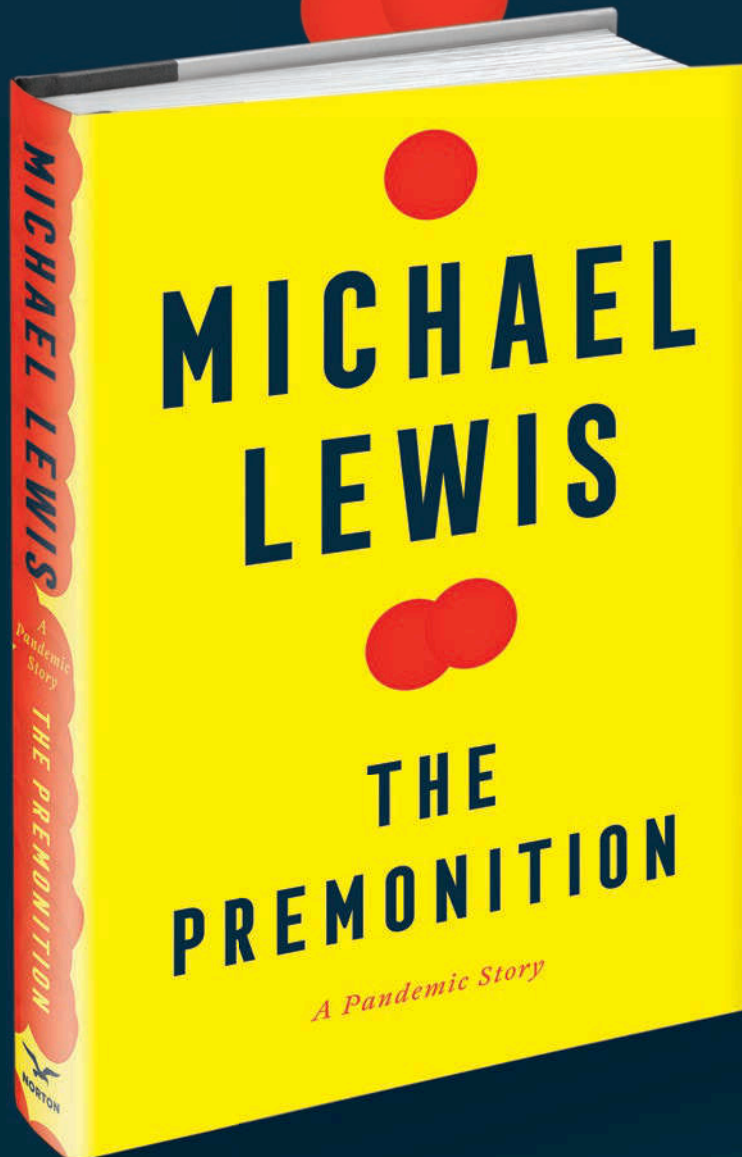
Annette Gordon-Reed is the Carl M. Loeb University Professor at Harvard. She is the author of The Hemingses of Monticello: An American Family, which won the 2009 Pulitzer Prize for History. This article has been adapted from her new book, On Juneteenth.

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Culture & Critics



OMNIVORE

Alison Bechdel's Spiritual Sprint

In her new memoir, the cartoonist runs, climbs, bikes, skis, spins, and Soloflexes her way toward transcendence.

By James Parker

Death comes, and the soul, dragged blinking from its nest of nerves, perceives its dimensions for the first time. It swoops; it stretches; it delights; it trails its wing tips in a dazzling, boundless sea. And all the dichotomies, all the infernal dualities—mind/body, I/you, subject/object, wanting/getting—are finally, finally resolved.

But what if there were something we could do about them *while we're alive*? What if through, say, very determined bicycling, or running up mountains, or doing push-ups on our knuckles, we could override ourselves? Forget ourselves, and so transcend these binaries that bedevil us?

This is the theme, or one of them, of Alison Bechdel's rather astonishing new graphic memoir. *The Secret to Superhuman Strength* is an account of Bechdel's lifelong pursuit of nondual bliss through vigorous-to-the-point-of-violent physical activity: the dharma of working out, you might call it.

The big questions have always preoccupied Bechdel, the memoirist of *Fun Home* fame. In one of my favorite sequences in the book, she is in the bathroom, age 9 or so, sitting on the lid-down toilet, clipping her toenails and staring at her cat. She is wondering whether her cat has a soul. "He was definitely conscious," runs the text. "But perhaps not conscious of himself as a *self*; as I was." The cat stares back at her with his small, humorless cat face. Bechdel stands up and looks at herself in the bathroom mirror. "I deduced that the soul must therefore consist in this self-consciousness. How I envied the cat. God knew, no one was more self-conscious than I was." The cat leaves.

How to escape this self-consciousness, how to get out of your own head? As a child, Bechdel works herself into a trance state throwing and catching an old tennis ball: "In time I learned that the secret to

mastering the woolly orb was not to try. Not to think about it. Not to think at all.” With her skis on, confronting the big slopes, trying and falling and trying again, she learns another route to cessation of mind: exhaustion.

At the same time, Bechdel wants to be *strong*. The Charles Atlas bodybuilding ads in her comic books are magnetic to her. (“It didn’t really occur to me—despite the endlessly repeated word ‘man’—that these were *male* bodies.”) As a teenager, peering into her mother’s copy of *The Joy of Feeling Fit*, she is introduced to the concept of *otrada*—a birthright condition of “enchanting well-being,” as the book’s Russian author has it, lost in the grind of growing up but recoverable via well-tutored exercise. She runs, she stretches, she jumps around. *Otrada* is hers. But for how long?

Bechdel’s on a physical journey, and a mystical one, and a political one too. Obligated to look past the “gender psychosis” of the various training programs she encounters in girlhood (TV’s Jack LaLanne talking about firming up the bustline and shedding those ugly pounds), she achieves an autonomous, nonconformist approach to fitness. College radicalizes her, and she comes out as a lesbian. At the Michigan Womyn’s Music Festival, an epiphany: “Not a man in sight ... In that startling void, I underwent a vertiginous perceptual shift! I could see what it meant to be a subject and not an object.” (Cue a Richard Scarry–like full-page drawing of a field of women, all cheerfully and variously busy.) She reads Adrienne Rich: “Two women, eye to eye / measuring each other’s spirit, each other’s / limitless desire, / a whole new poetry beginning here.” And running parallel to all this evolution, sprinting along next to it, the life-in-exercise. Bechdel bikes ferociously, she hikes ferociously; she does yoga and karate, Nordic skiing, Soloflex, spinning, Insanity training. Barely a fitness fad goes by that she doesn’t leap on, a craze that she isn’t crazed by.

There are some juicy tensions here, of which Bechdel the memoirist is far from unaware. Self-forgetting might be one end of working out; self-improvement, leading to self-glorification, is another. “Part of me is still enamored of the ideal of the rugged individual, the enclosed impregnable ego! But *why*? This fantasy of physical fitness is for fascists! I’m a feminist, for *@#&c’s sake!” The flow state, the letting-go-ness, the concentration of no concentration—can it be reconciled with a heroic, neurotic, teeth-gritted striving for strength and beauty? And how much of self-forgetting is just escapism, anyway? A way of blowing everybody off? “I turned forty without attaining enlightenment,” deadpans the text, as Bechdel in the frame pours herself a shot of Loch Lomond and her cat paws at a withered-but-still-floating balloon.

Bechdel has her spirit-allies on the journey. Adrienne Rich, as mentioned, but also those proto-backpackers the Lake Poets: Coleridge and Wordsworth, stomping about in a landscape that was also, for a moment, their shared

inner panorama. There’s Coleridge in one frame, vaulting a gate on his way to visit Wordsworth (and his sister) for the first time: “Coleridge’s literal leap into their lives impressed them both indelibly.” The Transcendentalist Margaret Fuller, always battling to live in fullness as a woman, shuttles in and out of the text. And Bechdel wrangles lovingly with the shade of Jack Kerouac. *On the Road* gets thrown across the room: “Macho bullshit.” *The Dharma Bums*, his Buddhism-inflected account of hiking the High Sierras with Gary Snyder, is carefully studied. “Self-absorbed misogynist prick!” thought-bubbles Bechdel, reading Kerouac by flashlight in her sleeping bag. But his fleeting flow states—“He watches the weather, the sun, the moon, the animals. His self blissfully recedes”—are much to be envied.

Self-forgetting, self-improvement—and self-regulation. Bechdel’s story, as she tells it in *The Secret to Superhuman Strength*, also contains a lot of what in my own life I call “buzz management.” Which is to say, the husbandry and distribution of one’s personal energies: knowing when to stimulate, when to tranquilize, when to run up a mountain and boil your shitty mood in endorphins, and so on. And the thing about buzz management is that you’re always getting it wrong. You overexcite yourself; you frazzle yourself; you’re bored, and then you’re anxious, and then you’re tired. There’s some surfeit or deficit of electricity, some kink in the wiring, that you’re always trying to straighten out. In Bechdel I recognize the symptoms of a fellow buzz manager: a tricky relationship to alcohol, a tricky relationship to work, a tricky relationship to relationships. I’m 53, and my exercise regimen—push-ups, pull-ups, jumping rope—is basically a means of helping me digest the consequences of my personality.

And the life-in-exercise, of course, is also a steady mortality readout. You watch in fascination as your body thickens, softens, slows. Can’t run: creaky knee. Fifty push-ups? Not anymore. To be gracious and accepting of these changes feels inhuman, impossible. But what are you going to do? *The Secret to Superhuman Strength* loses me in the final pages, because it ends in serenity and existential forgiveness. Bechdel and her partner make it through 2020—the virus, the Trumpgasm—by working hard on what she is still calling “the fitness book,” and at the top of the trail, guess what, there is hard-won wisdom. “We are a part of everything,” she writes. “Also: this is it. The only thing to transcend is the idea that there’s something to transcend.” Selfishly, I’d prefer this utterly absorbing book to end in a welter of confusion and failed chin-ups. No answers—or only those most fugitive ones, nontransferable, grasped or glimpsed for a second as you’re grimacing past your limit. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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THE SECRET TO
SUPERHUMAN
STRENGTH

Alison Bechdel

HOUGHTON MIFFLIN
HARCOURT

BOOKS

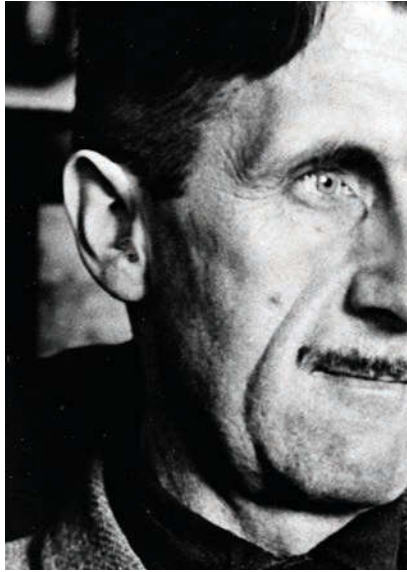
The Opportunists

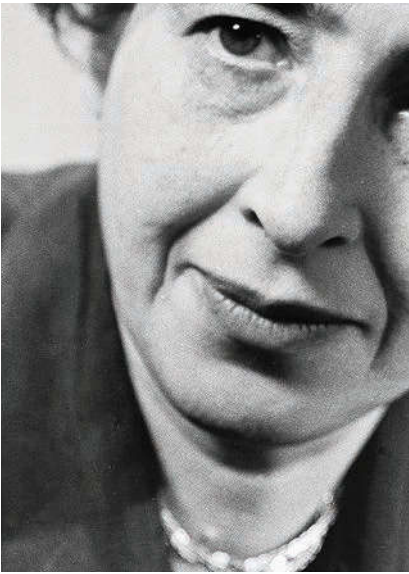
In Louis Menand's monumental new study of Cold War culture, success owes more to self-promotion than vision and purpose.

By Mark Greif

Louis Menand's big new book on art, literature, music, and thought from 1945 to 1965 instills the conviction that the 20th century is well and truly over. It seems like the right gift for the graduating college senior this year. Born in 2000, the proud degree-holder may not recognize the Jackson Pollock reproduced on the accompanying CONGRATULATIONS! card, or know the Allen Ginsberg lines misquoted in the commencement speech, but can look them up in *The Free World: Art and Thought in the Cold War* and confirm that this past is truly past. For those of us who lived through any portion of this period and its immediate aftermath, the book is a rather amazing compendium of the scholarly research, revision, and demythologizing that have been accomplished in recent decades. Interweaving post-1945 art history, literary history, and intellectual history, Menand provides a familiar outline; the picture he presents is one of cultural triumph backed by American wealth and aggressive foreign policy.

Menand's inclination is not really to debunk, nor to make or undo reputations. Yet guided by a fascination with the wayward paths to fame, he half-unwittingly sows doubt about the justice of the American rise to artistic leadership in the postwar era. In his erudite account, artistic success owes little to vision and purpose, more to self-promotion, but most to unanticipated adoption by bigger systems with other aims, principally oriented toward money,





political advantage, or commercial churn. For the greatness and inevitability of artistic consecration, Menand substitutes the arbitrary confluences of forces at any given moment.

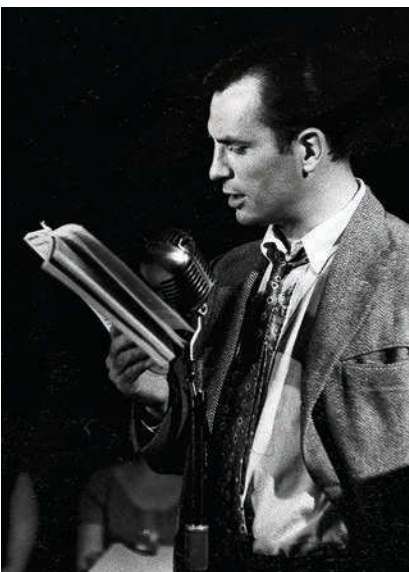
The book is constructed as a “great books” program of personalities, glued together by middlemen, all contributing to “an exceptionally rapid and exciting period of cultural change.” The curriculum runs chapter by chapter through George Kennan, George Orwell, Jean-Paul Sartre, Hannah Arendt, Jackson Pollock, Lionel Trilling, Allen Ginsberg, Claude Lévi-Strauss, Robert Rauschenberg and John Cage, Elvis and the Beatles, Isaiah Berlin, James Baldwin, Jack Kerouac, Andy Warhol, Susan Sontag, and Pauline Kael. Each biography opens a door to a school or trend of work. At first, the persona is squeezed for color and human interest. Here, pared down slightly, is the period’s best-known philosopher:



Sartre was five feet two inches tall ... He was conscious of his ugliness—he often talked about it—but it was the kind of aggressive male ugliness that can be charismatic, and he wisely refrained from disguising it ... He was also smart, generous, mildmannered, extremely funny, and a great talker ... Sartre liked other people to like him—which, in social situations, can be almost as good as liking other people. He was a gifted mimic, he looked surprisingly good in drag, and he did a great Donald Duck impression. He enjoyed drinking and talking all night, and so did [Simone de] Beauvoir.

The disorienting trick of this approach is that these central figures are then popped inside out, and they, too, become intermediaries for, or transfer points to, many other personages, artists, thinkers, salespeople, propagandists. Menand’s is not a “great man” view of history, because no one seems particularly great. One gets a feeling for Sartre as a person, a limited knowledge of how Sartre made *Being and Nothingness*, and a vivid sense of how the book made Sartre a celebrity. Then one learns how a troupe of others came along and rode his success like a sled.

Menand zooms in and out between individual ego-maniacs and the milieus that facilitated their ascent and profited from their publicity. The results—group biographies, in miniature, of the existentialists, the Beats, the action painters, the Black Mountain School,



Top, left to right: George Orwell, Jean-Paul Sartre, Hannah Arendt, Jackson Pollock. Middle: Simone de Beauvoir, John Lennon, Elvis Presley, Allen Ginsberg. Bottom: Andy Warhol, Susan Sontag, Jack Kerouac, James Baldwin.

the British Invasion, the pop artists, and many coteries more—are enchanting singly but demoralizing as they pile up. All of these enterprises look like hives of social insects, not selfless quests for truth or beauty. Menand is a world-class entomologist: He can name every indistinguishable drone, knows who had an oversize mandible, who lost a leg, who carried the best crumbs. The caution is that you must not seek lasting value in their collective works. From this vantage, the monuments really are just anthills.

MENAND IS truly one of the great explainers. He quotes approvingly a lesson taken by Lionel Trilling from his editor Elliot Cohen: “No idea was so difficult and complex but that it could be expressed in a way that would make it understood by anyone to whom it might conceivably be of interest.” Menand puts his own practice to the test. He is accurate, he is insightful, and he is not a dumber-downer. It is notoriously hard to summarize Martin Heidegger’s *Being and Time*, structural linguistics, serial composition in music, or the formation of Great Power rivalries in the period of decolonization. Menand’s account of each is an abbreviated tour de force. His explanations work at all levels: interpretation for scholars, review for general readers, introductions for neophytes. Where another writer would take 20 pages to tell us why someone or something mattered historically, Menand does it in two.

The Free World is a treasury of details. Some complicate myths without displacing them. Jack Kerouac did not actually improvise *On the Road* in three weeks on a scroll of teletype paper, high on speed. He did type *On the Road* in three weeks on a scroll, as a revision of many previous drafts, while drinking coffee. Jackson Pollock was not an uninhibited wild man, did not cut the ends off the landmark painting *Mural* to fit it on Peggy Guggenheim’s wall, and probably did not piss in her fireplace at the party where it premiered. He was an alcoholic, however, and exhibited sudden inebriated shifts in mood. He was mortified and depressed by the mythmaking photographs and film that Hans Namuth shot of him throwing paint at the canvas, leading to a significant breakdown.

Menand endows some minor incidents with greater dignity. Criticized for his feckless interventions into politics, James Baldwin may actually have helped galvanize the Kennedy administration’s support for civil rights, when he and an entourage of entertainment friends browbeat Robert F. Kennedy at a much-derided celebrity summit. Other discoveries are bummers. De Gaulle deliberately reentered Paris at the liberation with only white soldiers from his Free French Forces, though the majority of his troops had been recruited from French colonies in Africa. Behind

Robert Rauschenberg’s win at the Venice Biennale in 1964, a landmark for postwar American art, may have been a successful plot by his gallerist and publicist to influence the jurors.

Most of the memorable details are just funny. The titanic French intellectual Claude Lévi-Strauss taught as “Claude L. Strauss” in America to avoid confusion with the blue-jeans manufacturer. American tourists may have begun to complain about French rudeness only when France ceased to be their bargain-basement destination, after the hugely favorable postwar exchange rate of dollars to francs was moderated in a 1958 currency stabilization.

THE UNDERLYING THEORY of the book rests on a picture of what makes for “cultural winners,” works and ideas that Menand defines as

goods or styles that maintain market share through “generational” taste shifts—that is, through all the “the king is dead; long live the king” moments that mark the phases of cultural history for people living through it.

Fame comes through misreadings, fantasies, unintended resonances, charisma, and publicity.

This definition might seem to make a “cultural winner” synonymous with a “classic,” a work whose influence persists and evolves because of inherent artistic value. Menand’s recountings are less concerned with the changing meanings of individual works than with their successive adoptions and co-optations, in defiance of depth and meaning. It is a process of “winning” often based on cults of personality, indifference to complex origins, and the fortune or misfortune of timing. One sentiment repeated with variations throughout the book is “The timing was good” (for the appearance of Hannah Arendt’s *The Origins of Totalitarianism* in 1951, when Stalin seemed to have taken the place of Hitler). “The timing was lucky” (for cheaper pop art to appeal, in 1962, to impecunious collectors during an economic downturn). “Everything was set for a new culture hero to walk [onstage]. As if on cue, one did.” (This was Sartre in 1945, when the Nazi occupation ended and he delivered a philosophy of freedom that “turned France’s wartime experience into a metaphor.”)

The thrust of many of Menand’s retellings is that “in the business of cultural exchange, misprision is often the key to transmission.” Fame comes through misreadings, fantasies, unintended resonances, charisma, and publicity. Often Menand’s point seems to be that the culture’s reigning talkers and salespeople and debaters need to conjure figures to venerate and attack (in ceaseless alternation) for short-range purposes of attention and competition. Any given work—1984, say, or *Bonnie and Clyde*—isn’t much of

In particular, the inability to tell the difference between a joke and a real expressive creation keeps cropping up in Menand's vision of cultural progress by means of misreadings. Elvis Presley felt little commitment to "That's All Right, Mama," but undertook it while "kidding around," he said. He juiced the performance by "acting the fool," according to a fellow musician. Sam Phillips of Sun Records pulled it out from an early recording session, pushed radio airplay, and made it a rock-and-roll breakthrough. (The song's African American originator, Arthur "Big Boy" Crudup, never got a royalty from Elvis's sales. Crudup himself had likely lifted much of the song uncredited from Big Joe Turner.) Menand says much the same was true of Presley's epochal "bump-and-grind" version of "Hound Dog," delivered first on *The Milton Berle Show* in 1956, then repeated on *The Ed Sullivan Show*. Though Elvis was certainly a gyrating, passionate singer, this famous routine—rerun a thousand times, as the cultural desublimation of the white male American pelvis—started as self-conscious burlesque, "tongue-in-cheek, a joke."

Menand does too, I think—though it is hard to be sure. The paradoxical feature of the book is that its stylish, comprehensive retellings of some of the most famous stories of the most famous individuals, weaving connections between them, made me doubtful and weary of them, and much more interested in minor figures whom we barely glimpse. (Funny that in this book Josef Albers, Ralph Ellison, and Aimé Césaire become such “minor figures”—because the more peripatetic fame seekers like Rauschenberg and Baldwin are pushing their way in front of the camera instead.) As for the construction of art history in “schools” or “groups,” the effect of *The Free World's*

Menand's famous artist-protagonists seem haunted by a dialectic of shame and shamelessness, perhaps as a side effect of the rising tide of money and publicity swamping their actual accomplishments. His most searching and illuminating portraits are of figures at the extremes. People who found themselves cringing at celebrity—Pollock, Trilling, and Kerouac—come in for compassionate treatment as they struggle unhappily with their success, annihilating themselves in alcohol or psychotherapy. But the extroverts, who were willing to go on any TV show, travel anywhere,

Louis Menand

The Atlantic

meet anyone, and who liked to provoke as much as they liked to create, gain even more from Menand's studiously neutral dissection of a process in which the connections between people, rather than quality of work, are what make for centrality.

He's particularly sympathetic to the most wisened-up among them. The pages on Andy Warhol are unexpectedly sensitive and moving, precisely because of the total depthlessness of Warhol's stance and his dedication to relentless productivity, his touching desire to participate in the art world. Menand is fondly impressed, too, by the shared self-promotion of Rauschenberg, who pulled disparate objects like stuffed goats and trash and corks into his visual-art "combines," and his collaborator Cage, the composer best remembered for his noteless, silent piece, *4'33"*. They alternately charmed tastemakers and trolled them—and they knew to play the long game. "Rauschenberg would later recall with amusement the days when he was regarded as a jester," Menand writes. "Cage wanted recognition ... Like Rauschenberg, he didn't care very much if other people considered him a clown." Menand does not seem to think they were clowns in the end, but he does surprisingly little to reassure the reader.

Menand's book bequeaths the sense that the last laugh may truly have been on the self-seriousness of a whole historical period, one that treated its most publicized and successful arts figures far too generously, giving them too much credit for depth and vision, while missing the cynical forces by which they'd been buoyed up and marketed. It is an unillusioned book appropriate to our disillusioned times. I can imagine *The Free World* leaving my hypothetical college senior, denizen of the bleak attention economy of the 21st century, feeling liberated to discover that culture was no better—no more committed to a quest for what is true, noble, lasting, and beautiful—in the world of the Baby Boomers and beaming grandparents. I, too, finished *The Free World* relieved to know that this book will henceforth be on my shelf to consult when I forget why innumerable great names were once remembered, and to preserve me from the call of future books titled *Why X [or Y] Still Matters*, by confirming that X and Y probably don't. The book is so masterful, and exhibits such brilliant writing and exhaustive research, that I wonder whether Menand could truly have intended where his history of the postwar era landed me. I learned so much, and ended up caring so much less. *A*

Mark Greif teaches English at Stanford and is the author of The Age of the Crisis of Man: Thought and Fiction in America, 1933–1973.

The Arrow Paradox

By Mark Jarman

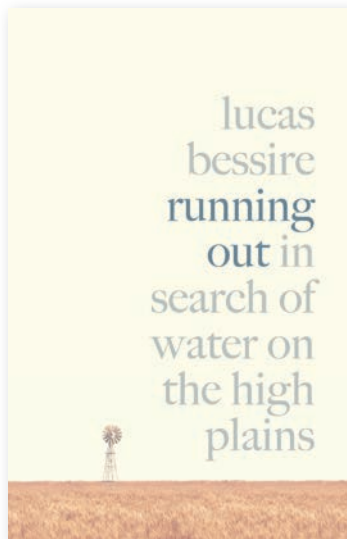
Zeno sent
his arrow flying
endlessly from point
to point along its arc
to make a point
about eternity:
getting there is tricky.

That's what I think
anyway, as snowflakes
stall in the morning's
freezing air
like seed fluff
reluctant to drop
anchor in the ice.

I'm watching that
tentative descent
though I'm in motion
and counter-motion
even as I follow
my pen's blue notes
and think I'm not—

not doing anything,
not going anywhere
much farther
than my own flight
across the blank
momentum
of the turning page.

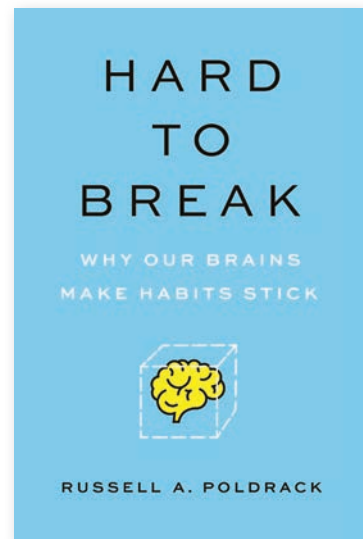
Mark Jarman's most recent books are the poetry collection The Heronry (2017) and the essay collection Dailiness (2020).



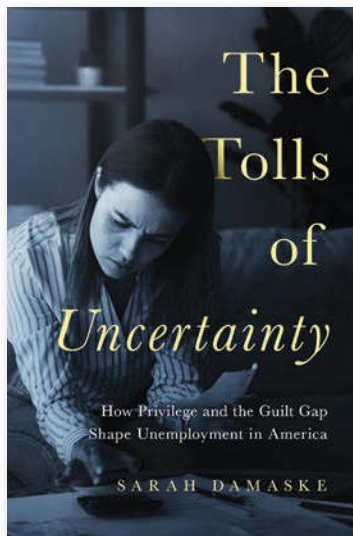
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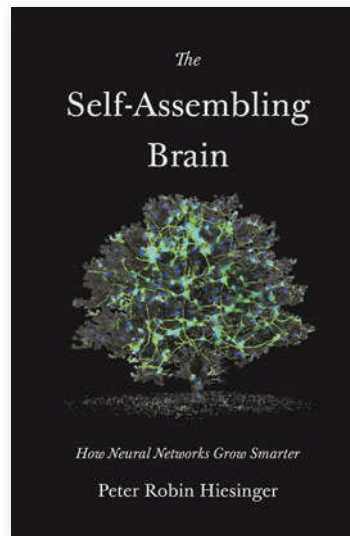
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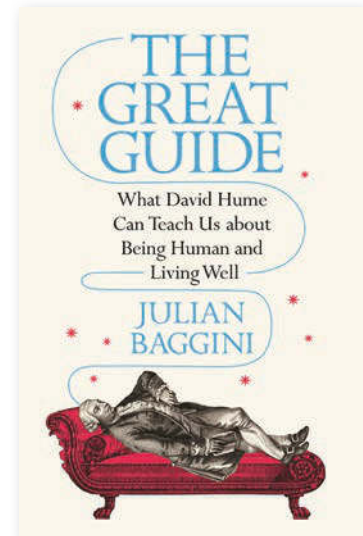
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—*Publishers Weekly*



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—Leslie McCall, author of *The Undeserving Rich*



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—David Edmonds, author of *The Murder of Professor Schlick*



BOOKS

The Power of Refusal

New novels by Rachel Cusk and Jhumpa Lahiri explore women's struggle to withdraw and create.

By Claire Dederer

My father died this spring. Right up until he went into the hospital, at age 88, he lived alone in a small houseboat at the end of a long pier, bare of conventional creature comforts but filled with his books and maps and hiking gear. My brother and I had worried: "Dad, you could have a heart attack and fall in the lake." Better that than give up his freedom, he'd said. To other people, his ascetic life might not have looked like freedom. It might've looked like emptiness. His life seemed to be made up of things he didn't have. But to him, the not-having was the same thing as his freedom.

I sat by my father's hospital bed for two months. As he slept, he gripped my left hand and I held a book in my right. Toward the end of my vigil, I read new novels by Rachel Cusk and Jhumpa Lahiri. The protagonists of both books have built lives that are full of refusals, as my father

did. But there is one important difference—these first-person narrators are women, and they wear their refusals awkwardly; my dad wore his with a sovereign dignity. Refusal, like so much else, turns out to be the prerogative of men. The narrator of Cusk's *Second Place*, identified only as M, says it plainly, addressing a male painter who is identified as L: "You've always pleased yourself," I said, somewhat bitterly, because it did seem to me that that was what he had done, and what most men did." M, by contrast, struggles to please herself, apart from others.

Second Place is a strange novel. The publisher calls it a fable, and perhaps it is, in the sense that many of Cusk's books can be read as fables of female dissatisfaction. Drawing on the observational sparseness of her celebrated *Outline* trilogy and the eccentric vigor of her earlier work, she powerfully blends evocations of personal turmoil with ruminations on art, truth, freedom, the will, men and women, and more.

Cusk signals a turn away from *Outline*'s realism at the start, as M recounts a cryptic meeting with the devil on a train trip years earlier, heading "back to a home I thought of with secret dread" after an unsettling visit to Paris. A young mother, she has just been transported by the paintings she sees at a major retrospective of L's work. The hideous devil is gabbling nonsense and fondling a doll-like girl. He seems to be taunting M to try to stop his antics, and leaves her feeling that she's failed her "moral duty as a self," not that she knows what that duty is.

After a long period of emotional devastation—devastation spurred by her encounter with the devil yet only hinted at—M has finally landed in a rural idyll on the shores of a marsh in an unspecified country. There she shares a home with Tony, a taciturn fellow who seems content with his lot in life—decidedly unlike M. From their remote outpost, she writes a letter to L, whom she has never ceased to think of and admire deeply. She invites him to take up residence in a kind of guesthouse on their marsh property, amid what appears to be our current pandemic.

L's arrival at the "second place," as M and Tony call it, brings about a series of reversals and revelations, each of which exposes to M a further unpleasant truth about herself and "how lonely and washed up" she feels, plagued by "a tormenting scent of freedom," yet unable to do much of anything. Can L, she needs to know, "release me into creative action"? The tension between M and L, between female and male, between domesticity and art, between restraint and abandon fuels the book. M clings to the few things she has found that make her feel safe and in control—Tony, her now-grown daughter, the marsh—even as she hears an "inchoate call out of some mystery or void," which she associates with L.

Though Cusk's and Lahiri's narrators seem to have freed themselves of the familiar forms of wanting, they are not passive or pain-averse, or fragile.

L, meanwhile, is suffering his own setback—his work is going out of fashion. When L complains about his reduced circumstances, M explains, "Not to have been born in a woman's body was a piece of luck in the first place: he couldn't see his own freedom because he couldn't conceive of how elementally it might have been denied him." M's escapes from her disapproving first husband and from the "fleshliness" of the parent-child bond have plainly been ordeals. And her struggles to absorb some of L's power, evoked with great subtlety by Cusk, ultimately come to naught. "That's all I've managed as far as freedom is concerned, to get rid of the people and the things I don't like" is her rueful verdict. "After that, there isn't all that much left!"

In a short note at the end of the book, Cusk reveals that the novel "owes a debt" to *Lorenzo in Taos*, a memoir by the patron of the arts Mabel Dodge Luhan (M) about a long and difficult visit from D. H. Lawrence (L) in the 1920s. "Intended as a tribute to her spirit," Cusk's transmutation of Luhan's book nods to a long lineage: The predicament of the frustrated female artist orbiting the male was haunting 100 years ago and still is today. In order to create, the woman who sets out to make art knows that she must refuse something, some aspect of her femaleness. *Second Place* lets us listen as one such woman tries to describe what happens to her—in her mind and her body, alone and in the company of others—as she finds herself stymied.

THE UNNAMED NARRATOR of Jhumpa Lahiri's *Whereabouts*—the first novel that Lahiri has composed in Italian and then translated into English—practices a starker form of refusal, rendered in short, journal-like fragments so strongly and rightly voiced that other books sound wrong when you turn to them. She lacks M's fierce yearning for creativity, yet very much like M, she keeps her social circle and activities limited. "I dislike waking up and feeling pushed inevitably forward. But today, Saturday, I don't have to leave the house. I can wake up and not have to get up. There's nothing better." She and Cusk's M make a small sisterhood of women staring into space. It's as though only in inactive solitude can they listen to their minds, register the ineffable, and, perhaps, prod at the feeling that freedom eludes them. (Perhaps the sisterhood is not so small.)

Yet she, like M, can't decide just how willed her retreat really is, and does her own quieter form of soul-wrestling. Living alone in a spare apartment, she takes walks by herself. At times she finds moments of quiet transcendence in her solitude: "As I eat it," she reflects, sitting outside with a sandwich, "as my body bakes in the sun that pours down on my neighborhood, each bite, feeling sacred, reminds me that I'm

not forsaken.” Other times, her solitude makes her fussy. A friend’s child leaves a pen mark on her sofa:

The line is like a long strand of hair, innocuous, intolerable. A line that drifts and drifts. I can’t rub it away with my finger. Nothing I do to try to lift it works. I buy cushions, a blanket to hide it. But they’re not a solution, the cushions move around and the blanket slips down. I read on the armchair now.

In this emptiness, subdued images loom with outsize power.

The way she inhabits her isolation recalls Barbara Pym’s *Excellent Women*, another luminous portrait of a chosen withdrawal. (In places, Lahiri’s book also calls to mind the sourer loneliness evoked in the poetry of Pym’s friend Philip Larkin.) Pym’s narrator is offered various escapes from her solitude, but opts to mete out her time in her own way. The glory of the book lies in her dominion over her own hours. Lahiri’s narrator, too, says solitude “demands a precise assessment of time, I’ve always understood this. It’s like the money in your wallet: you have to know how much time you need to kill, how much to spend before dinner, what’s left over before going to bed.” There’s a sadness here—but money is, after all, valuable. Lahiri’s narrator is spending her hours in the way she and only she sees fit.

The effect is of someone making her way carefully through the world, always aware of the void below, well practiced in navigating with a command that both is and isn’t what it seems. Lahiri highlights this theme of precariousness as her narrator thinks back on a girlhood game, popular among her peers, of hopping from tree stump to tree stump:

It now occurs to me that I was as tenacious as I was timid. I never protested, I did what they did, that is, I clambered up, I hesitated, and then I strode across, afraid each time that the empty space between the stumps would swallow me up, terrified each time that I would fall, even though I never did.

She envies the “brazen strides” of the other girls, yet also prizes her outsider status.

BOTH OF THESE BOOKS might sound bloodless, and yes, Cusk’s and Lahiri’s narrators seem to have freed themselves of the familiar forms of wanting. That hasn’t drained them of will, though. They are anything but passive or pain-averse, or fragile. They are desperate, and their refusals feel like a groping yet determined effort at survival—survival on terms they need to discover, define, understand. They don’t know what to do, but they feel they know what not to do: be a woman like other women.

SECOND PLACE

Rachel Cusk

FARRAR, STRAUS
AND GIROUX

WHEREABOUTS

Jhumpa Lahiri

KNOPF

For her whole life, Lahiri’s narrator has watched her mother give way to her father’s wishes. Cusk’s *M* has come to resist the demands of upkeep, of caretaking: “the feeling that my life has entailed too many practical tasks, so that if I add even one more to the total, the balance will be tipped and I will have to admit I have failed to live as I have always wished to.” Cusk and Lahiri know that motherhood and domesticity will eat you alive. They don’t know how to fix that, but their narrators know that a woman who wishes to be free has to *not* do a lot of things.

In a memorable scene in Cusk’s *Transit*, the second in her *Outline* trilogy, she captures the enchantment and the entrapment of domesticity. Her narrator, Faye, attends a dinner party at her cousin’s house in the country, complete with candles, music, pretty children, bejeweled women, all sheltered in a “long low farmhouse.” What could be lovelier? Yet before the evening is through, mayhem has set in and everyone is behaving very badly. Faye can’t get away fast enough the next morning. As she escapes the house, she says, “I felt change far beneath me, moving deep beneath the surface of things, like the plates of the earth blindly moving in the black traces.” Earth-shaking: That’s the daunting scale of transformation entailed—or at least desired. (Faye is well aware that her own children await her at home.)

I—and these novels confirm I’m not alone—also want some other life that can be lived by some alternative version of myself: unscripted, maybe lonely and uncomfortable. And that life starts with refusal. This in-between state is where the narrators of *Second Place* and *Whereabouts* exist. They are saying the essential *no*. For this reader at least, that’s a thrilling spectacle—and a *yes*, Cusk suggests, is perhaps hidden in there. “Might it be true,” *M* wonders late in the novel, as she considers her daughter’s future, “that half of freedom is the willingness to take it when it’s offered?”

My father’s freedom never seemed like it could be mine. I was raised to be like my mother, to please other people. After my father died, I walked onto his houseboat and looked around at the light streaming through the windows; the walls of books; the few, chosen objects. I saw, too, the tight quarters, the galley kitchen, space enough to fulfill the needs of only one person. I had struggled my whole life to become my mother, but suddenly, my children almost grown, I wondered whether I could become my father instead. Could I live here? Could I be free and sovereign? Could I simply ... refuse? *A*

Claire Dederer is the author, most recently, of Love and Trouble: A Midlife Reckoning.

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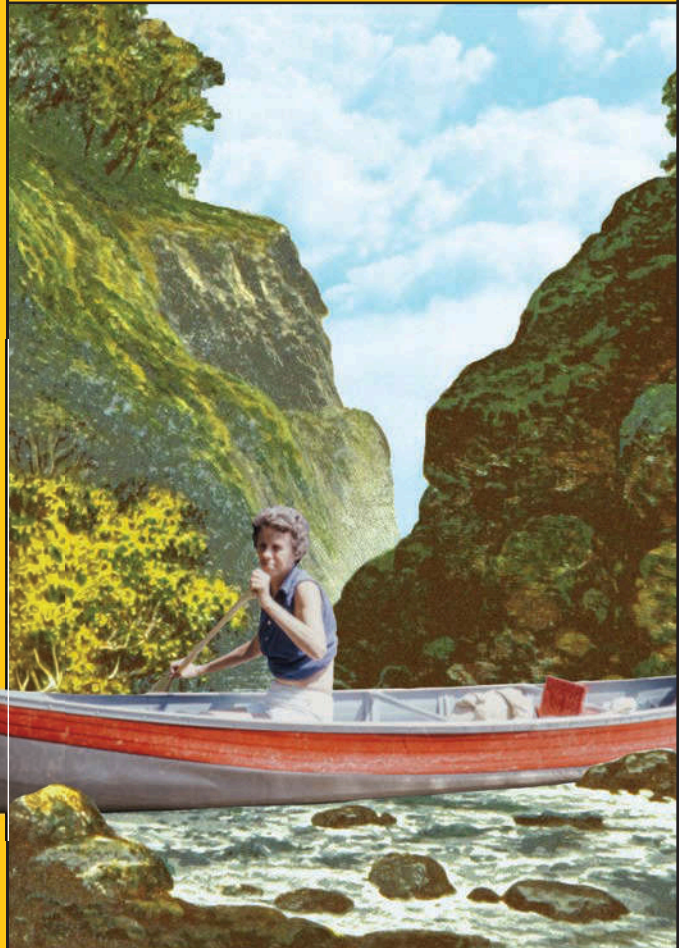
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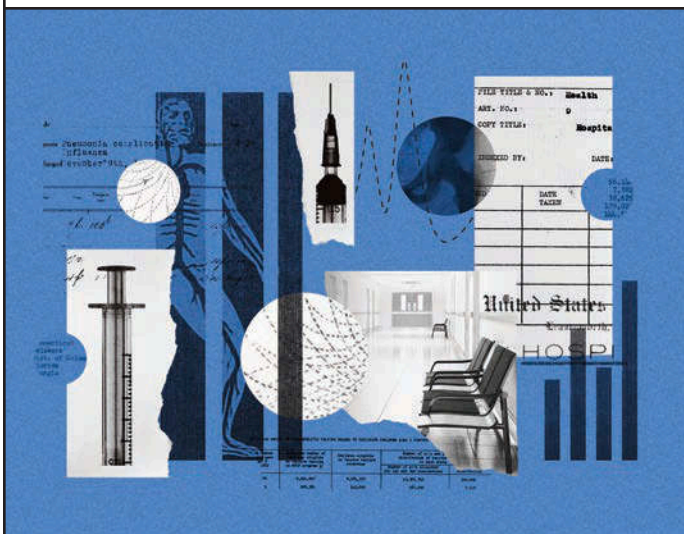


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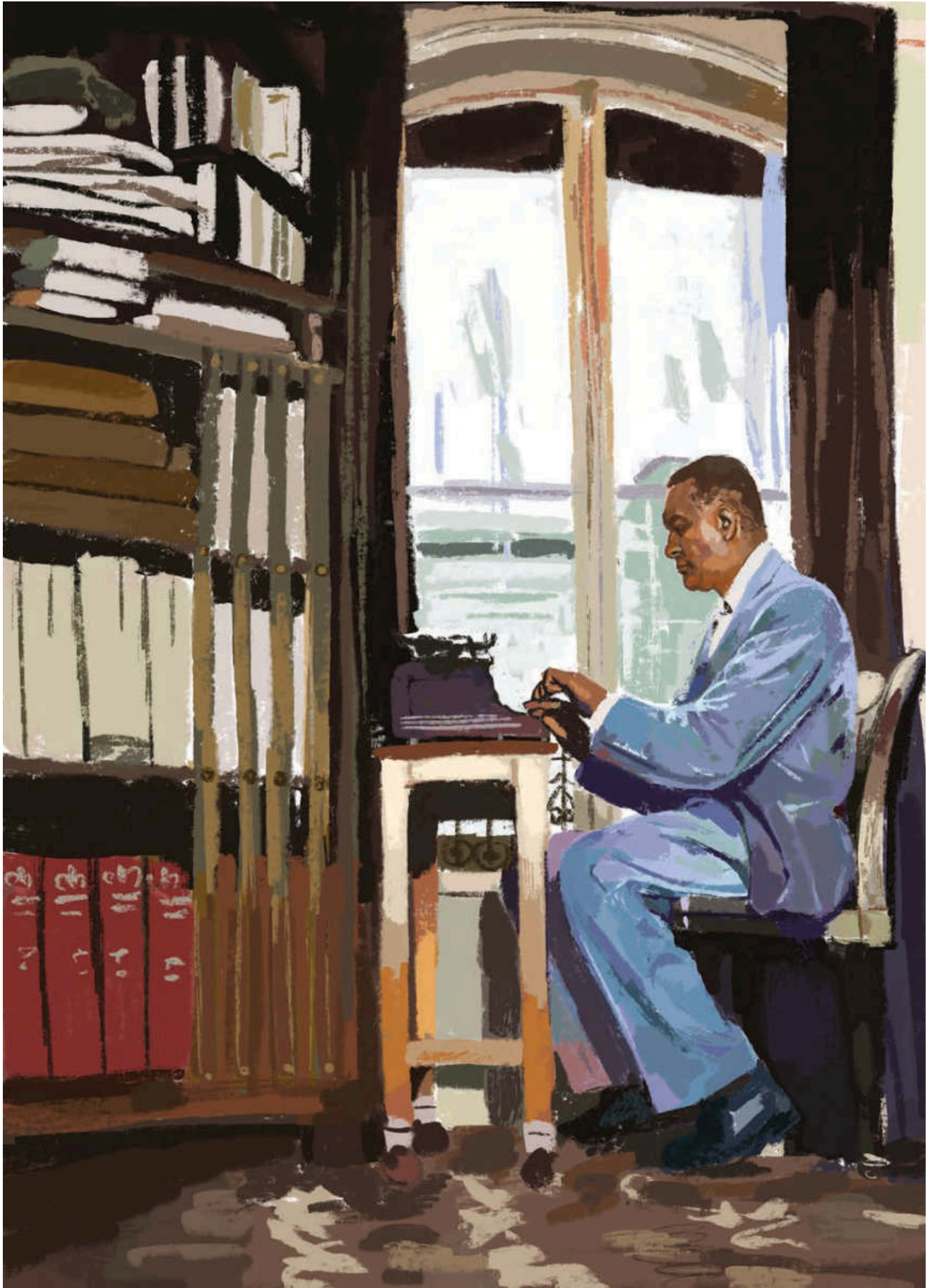


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What Richard Wright Knew

A previously unpublished novel reveals his bleak prescience about race in America.

By Imani Perry

Richard Wright, the father figure of African American literature, both nurtured and was rejected by his two most conspicuous heirs, Ralph Ellison and James Baldwin. Wright, who took Ellison under his wing in New York in the late 1930s, told his acolyte to stop copying him, that he was mimicking, not cultivating his own style. Ellison responded that he was trying to learn to write well by imitating his mentor. That was when they were close. Baldwin, too, started out as a pupil and an admirer who saw Wright poised to be the greatest Black writer in the United States.

Though it happened slowly, by 1941, Ellison betrayed signs of feeling that Wright, affiliated off and on with the Communist Party, wrote fiction that was too ideological and not sensitive enough to nuance: Wright wanted to testify to the monstrosities of white supremacy, rather than the power of Black resilience. Ellison grew committed to the poetry of American democracy, despite how badly it was sullied; he swore by the virtues of individualism. Calling Wright “Poor Richard,” Baldwin joined Ellison in lamenting their mentor’s failure to see the beauty of Black people. The two of them never ceased to love Wright’s prose, but they came to reject his perspective.

I admit I’ve been inclined to share their verdict, based on Wright’s first novel, *Native Son*, published in 1940, which I read again and again in classes before and during college. I’ve parroted the notes I took in lectures, and I’ve taught a version of those lectures myself: Bigger Thomas was a protagonist stripped of any redeeming qualities, so distorted by the conditions of racism that he became an avatar more than a character, and an unsettling representation of Blackness.

My assessment of Wright has begun to shift over the past couple of years. I’ve read *12 Million Black Voices* (1941)—his reflections on the Great Migration, accompanied by Farm Security Administration photographs taken during the Depression—and been struck by his broad sympathy. And I’ve reread *Black Boy* (1945), a memoir I hadn’t touched

since my final year of high school in the Northeast, in a writing seminar led by a teacher born, like me, in Birmingham, Alabama. Wright reached for the very core of the human condition in his portrait of growing up destitute in the Deep South during the early 20th century, and then making his way north: abundance everywhere and terrible hunger, tragedy mixed with the quotidian in the most disorienting ways. The experience he evoked might not have been every Black life, but it was indeed a part of Black life. In Mississippi, the land could swallow you whole. In Chicago, a rat might bite you, because after all, you were made to live in slums no different from rattraps. Wright was showing us something true, if not absolute—how, with the plantation breathing at your back and deferred dreams before you, tragedy happened.

Now that I’ve read *The Man Who Lived Underground*—a previously unpublished novel held in the Wright archives, also written in the early 1940s—I’m even more convinced that Wright deserves to be looked at with fresh eyes. At first, I texted a friend, “This novel is clearly a direct model for Ralph Ellison’s *Invisible Man*.” My friend wrote back, “That’s why he told Ellison to stop copying him!” Wright’s protagonist is a Black man who is falsely accused of a double homicide and brutalized by the police before escaping into a sewer. Ellison’s protagonist is also a Black man who eventually retreats into a sewer, on an identity quest that has been thwarted aboveground. Yet I quickly discovered that Wright was mapping an unexpected journey.

Though *Native Son* had been a best seller, Harper rejected *The Man Who Lived Underground*, its immediate successor. Readers’ comments in the archives suggest that the editors might have been deterred by the “unbearable” police violence and an imbalance between allegory and graphic detail. The book opens with a harrowing encounter between decent, respectable Fred Daniels, the protagonist, and three police officers. Fred is subjected to torture so extreme that he’s left barely conscious. He loses track of everything in the horror of the moment. His identity disappears, time is drained of meaning, he forgets his pregnant wife and grows unsure about his innocence. The *unheimlich*, Freud’s idea of the unfamiliar familiar, is a constant presence for Wright: Nothing makes sense, and yet he and we know that this is the way the world is. And then, almost as if in a dream, Fred realizes that the officer guarding him has briefly walked away, and “a vague gathering of all the forces of his body urged him to escape.” Like a disoriented, curious child, he gravitates toward a “gaping manhole.”

The sewer provides a nightmarishly sensual experience. What sounds like a holler might be a skidding car. The slosh of water turns to sludge; a baby passes by him, dead and flushed away. Ellison’s invisible man escapes into an Emersonian isolationism—a reckoning with himself underground. Wright scripts a surreal reencounter with the world as seen through discovered cracks and doors that reveal hidden interiors: In his subterranean wandering, Fred comes upon the basement of a Black church, drawn to it by singing that he

finds at once “sonorous and magnificent in its expression of melancholy renunciation” and infuriating in its guilty “whimpering.” He happens on the safe room of a real-estate office, and ends up complicit in a theft that results in another man’s punishment. He finds himself in a coal bin, saved from being scooped up by a worker only because the exhausted old man works in the dark, never turning on the lights.

Viewed from below, the social world, the economy—all manner of ordered things—are clearly absurd. Reason eludes Fred, and empathy flows in at the vision of humanity as “children, sleeping in their living.” After all, what really matters? This isn’t the doctrinal Wright, warning us of the disasters that capitalism creates. This is an unmooring Wright, pushing us past the edge of social analysis and into madness. Perhaps this turn, from leftist literary naturalism to a morbid unraveling of the self, is what most disturbed the Harper editors.

IT’S IMPOSSIBLE to read Wright’s novel without thinking of this 21st-century moment, when we urgently assert, “Black lives matter.” We live with cycles of repeated violence; the terror of Black innocents being killed is all around us and in our consciousness. Starting in the 1940s, Ellison and Baldwin criticized Wright for his insistence on dramatizing this ineluctable subjugation; they saw Wright himself as submitting, in the process, to Black oppression in America. They believed, each in his own fashion, that Black literature ought to capture hope, possibility, beauty, and endurance. Transcendence and, more important, transformation were possible until they weren’t. Now the tragic absurdity of Fred’s life seems all too familiar. We see it on our screens regularly: the snuff films of white supremacy. Perhaps we have too readily judged Wright’s bearing of witness to be reductively stark and fatalistic. What he observed is still happening, despite all those generations of unyielding hope.

Critics will no doubt liken *The Man Who Lived Underground* to Kafka, Dostoyevsky, and Sartre. And the analogies are there in Fred’s drive to “assert himself,” to act in the face of “death-like” existence. But the novel is also a Protestant work, as much about God as it is about Black people, as Wright himself explains in an accompanying essay about the novel’s origins titled “Memories of My Grandmother.” In a world beyond understanding and reason, his Seventh-day Adventist grandmother had a religion that imposed meaning on the incomprehensibility of existence. She believed, in accordance with Church doctrine, that right and wrong were starkly distinguished. Strangeness was not to be explored, but simply judged. Guilt preceded assessment: Humans were guilty, and only holiness could save them. In its own way, this fierce Black Protestantism gave psychic refuge to believers but also recommended

surrender to the cruelty of the world. In Fred’s odyssey, which leads him back aboveground to confess to the crime he didn’t commit, Wright has him careen from rage at the pervasive burden of guilt to an embrace of it.

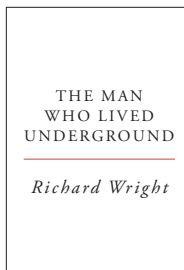
As I read, I was reminded of Lorraine Hansberry’s thoughts about Wright’s contested literary status. Like her fellow writers, she valued debate over how best to use literature as a tool of social criticism, but she felt that Baldwin’s attack on Wright was too harsh—as if Wright had to plummet in order for his own star to rise. She disliked the pleasure that white critics took in this literary patricide. In her view, very few American writers could match Wright’s skill and style.

Wright deserves sensitive reconsideration, especially now that so many of us have been proved naive in our belief that an honest rendering of Black people might lead to recognition of our existence in the universality of humanity. When Wright became an expatriate, in the late ’40s, he did not turn his back on America. He found a vantage point that allowed him to understand better what actually went on in a country where Black people “are accused and branded and treated as though they are guilty of something,” as he wrote in his essay. Baldwin, who also moved to France, eventually came to a similar conclusion that with distance from the U.S. came newly clear-eyed intimacy.

I write, again and again, that things have changed for Black Americans, as unjust as the world remains. I say that Black people have displayed remarkable endurance and transformed so much. And yet, I wonder. When the novelist and poet Margaret Walker looked at Richard Wright, a man she loved completely, she worried that he capitulated too easily to the violence. But he, a child of the Black Belt, was up close to it in a way that Walker, a Birmingham-born preacher’s daughter, simply wasn’t. Nor am I. I have visited a squatter’s residence, a crack house, a federal prison, but I haven’t lived in any of them. I have been falsely accused and unfairly judged, but never beaten senseless in the process.

Wright tells an old story that still lives. His Fred carries the name of our most famous Black fugitive, the abolitionist writer Frederick Douglass, and he travels underground in ways more reminiscent of the Underground Railroad than of Dostoyevsky. He finds himself encountering the world, unfiltered by established terms of order, and acquires a tenderness for all people. In the end, his Black existence presents a particular window and a universal predicament—and a reminder: Surrounded by ghastly forces every day, we destroy life with our many idolatries and illusions. *A*

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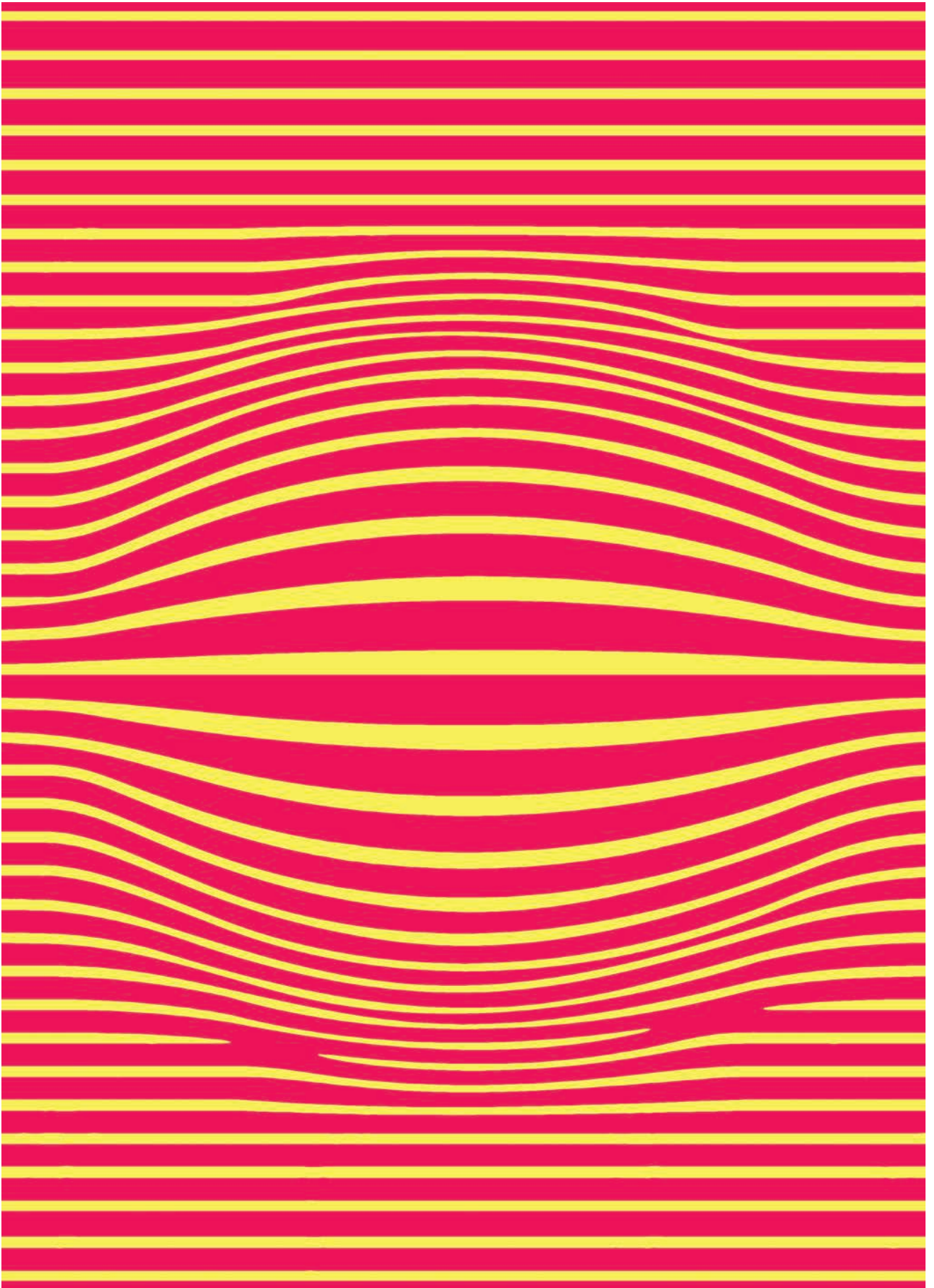
FICTION



Bump

*By
Morgan
Thomas*

To those who accuse me
of immoderate desire,
I say look at the oil
executives. Look at the
Gold Rush. Look at all
the women who want a
ring and romance and
lifelong commitment,
and then look again
at me. Me, I just want
a person to dance the
two-step with on Friday
nights, a person who
won't mind if I wear
a shirt with maroon
sequins or, occasionally,
a strap-on pregnancy



bump. In return, I offer a woman who can get by on little. I keep myself spotless. My car and my nails and my résumé, I polish. I polish myself until I shine.

The first thing that drew me to Len was that he had worked to be where he was and would work to stay there. Born on a cattle ranch an hour outside Gainesville, he'd made partner at an Atlanta law firm, the firm that had once represented Coca-Cola against the state. He wore a suit and tie to work even on casual Fridays. He had no southern accent. On our first date, I asked him about the accent. He said, "I did away with it." Like it was nothing, doing away with a whole part of yourself. When I talk about polish, this is what I mean. Representing Coca-Cola is reprehensible, and I've told him that, but still, I admire his dedication.

When I told him, on our third date, that I was trans, he said, "That makes no difference." Another reason I love him. Not like my Nana, who had a conniption, said I was risking my job and her livelihood in the bargain, since she counted on me to take care of her. And I did lose that first job. I made mistakes. I worked a miserable job for six years just for the health insurance. But a year ago I got a part-time job, a better job, and here I am.

Len didn't care that I was trans. Now I think I should have asked for more than ambivalence, but for three years, I was happy with Len. Friday evenings, we danced the two-step at Dig Down, and he maneuvered me expertly through the crowd. Weekends, when he was feeling ambitious, he cooked crepes. He was devoted to me. His crepes were terrible.

His wife, Melinda, sometimes invited me to the nail salon or for sushi. I was grateful to her for the invitations, though I always declined. We were cordial, Melinda and I. We understood how to fit together, help each other. We both believed it was a good thing, a relief, to divide up the responsibility of caring for a man.

With Len, for the first time in my life, I could honestly say, "I am content."

That all ended, of course. I trace the decline to one moment four months ago. I was eating lunch with my co-worker Julie, and she asked how I was feeling at the end of my first trimester. I had most definitely

not mentioned being pregnant or even wanting to be pregnant, which is something I want quietly, since it is impossible, and there's something shameful in yearning, concretely—not a whim, but a cold, hard desire—for an impossible thing. Uterine transplants are at least six years down the road. By then I'll be past childbearing age. I accept this, but there Julie was, acting as if I were carrying a baby, and there I was, to my great surprise, going along with it.

I should have said I wasn't pregnant, whatever she'd heard, but she smiled at me like we were sharing a new secret. She had been through two pregnancies, the second more difficult than the first. Everyone in the office knew the details. Her smile invited me to put my swollen feet up on conference tables, to send my ultrasounds to the "All" office email. Right down into my abdomen, that smile warmed me, and I said, "I feel better than ever," and that's how I'm in the mess I'm in now.

DESIRE HAS its own rhythms. It overwhelms and subsides. At the height of my contentment with Len, I'd nearly forgotten the feeling of wanting—the pull and the thrill of it. Two years into our relationship, Len said to me, "We're pregnant." For a single, startled moment I thought he meant the two of us, but he was talking of course about his wife, Melinda, about the baby we hadn't met yet, the baby who would be born to that happy couple five months later with toe-thumbs and a full head of hair. I called that baby the aphid. I cared for the aphid on Saturdays to give Melinda a break, and I enjoyed my relationship with them, which was something like that of an aunt. Melinda was a deliberate mother. She published articles on her blog about cloth diapers and raising children in nontraditional family structures. She didn't let just anyone watch the aphid, but she let me.

Maybe it was my time with the aphid that got my co-workers talking, some baby pheromone. Maybe the rumor started when I'd complained to another co-worker that I'd been nauseated in the mornings. I'd put the nausea down to starting a new plant-based progesterone or to a habit of breakfasting on Lemoncocco soda, but she'd said, "Are you pregnant?"

"What do you think?" I'd said. That was a real question. Did I seem pregnant? I wanted to know. She'd just pressed her lips together into a private smile and walked away.

After Julie asked about my first trimester, I started thinking about children. For three days, I thought about them. I texted Len, "Would you want to have a child with me?"

"Good morning to you"

I texted, "Not immediately, but one day."

"Two families is a lot"

"I'm just asking if you'd want to."

When we met up that evening, I asked him again.

"The logistics would be difficult," he said. "We'd have to adopt."

"We wouldn't have to adopt," I said, though I couldn't name an alternative to adoption.

"I don't think this is a conversation we need to have tonight," he said. "I think this is a conversation we should have in a year, a few years."

I said nothing, impressed into silence by his vision of longevity. I don't know anyone but Len who anticipates conversations they'll have in a few years.

PEOPLE THINK contentment is a gentle thing, like bathwater, that needs only occasional replenishing to keep from turning tepid. In my experience, contentment often requires more ruthless defending. After leaving Len that evening, I defended. I went through Facebook and unfriended the yoga instructor who had posted a photo of herself nursing her 2-year-old while in a forearm stand. I unfriended the mother of two whose account had descended into outraged article shares after her husband had left her for her doula. I wrote a long Facebook post about the insensitivity of self-congratulatory motherhood. I included references to half a dozen recent articles, like "The Peak of Selflessness: Motherhood."

It wasn't until Len called that I realized that the article about selflessness had been written by his wife.

"Melinda doesn't understand. She thought you were getting along," he said.

"We are getting along. It's a difference of opinion. It's not personal."

"Well, it feels personal to her."

"At any moment, Melinda could decide she doesn't want me spending time with the aphid, and I could do nothing. How do you think that feels for me?"

"Don't call him the aphid."

"Don't gender them."

"Melinda has asked you not to call our baby the aphid."

"At any moment, she could decide she doesn't want me around."

"She'd never decide that."

"But she could."

"She likes you," he said. Len often told me someone liked me. It was reflexive, a way to avoid an argument. "She thinks you're great," he said.

"I think she's great," I said, which seemed beside the point. "I just need distance." This wasn't something I'd planned to say, but it seemed necessary to save face.

He was quiet. I'd surprised him. "We thought you liked spending time with Aster."

We. A word I hated. A word that declared to the listener, *You Are Not One of Us.*

"Melinda's trying. She wants you to feel welcome, like part of the family."

"I'm not part of your family."

"Louie, you knew what this was when we started dating. If it's not what you want—"

"It is what I want," I said. It wasn't everything I wanted, but I'd long since stopped imagining that any single person could completely satisfy want in another.

"We can take some time away. Like you said. We can check in next week."

I could feel the whole thing getting away from me. "Aren't I watching Aster this Saturday?"

"Do something for yourself on Saturday."

"So I'm not allowed at your house now on Saturdays?"

"You just said you want distance."

"I want a family." I waited for him to respond.

"That's not on the table, Louie. For us, for now, that's not on the table."

So. There it was.

"Let's check in next week," he said.

I said, "Two weeks," and he raised me to three, and I raised him, and he raised me, and then we were saying goodnight, and I was wiping the moisture from the screen of my phone and going to get Nana ready for bed, unsure if I'd see him again.

IT'S NOT EASY, polishing yourself. It's not easy teaching yourself to code or making do with cornstarch as a setting powder or going into debt for a tracheal shave. But there's comfort in knowing you can do it, in relying only on yourself. I sat down on Saturday, when I should have been watching the aphid, and searched online for pregnancy bumps. The bumps come in a range of prices and sizes. Every one, according to the reviews, causes back pain that you need a professional to relieve. I went with the Pregnant Belly by Spirit, which shipped from South Korea and came complete with shoulder straps and

*It wasn't everything
I wanted, but
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imagining that any
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completely satisfy want
in another.*

an adjustable back belt. I ordered one for four to six months and one for seven to nine months. I chose express shipping. The Pregnant Belly by Spirit got good reviews for the price, though I've since wondered whether I should have spent more, invested in a more durable bump.

When my bumps came, I modeled them for Nana. They were cold and slick against my skin. I could feel the tug of the belt, a squeeze that would escalate over hours to a backache.

"That shape says you're having a girl," Nana said into her stew, and I was pleased in spite of myself, cupping the bump, rubbing circles into it, doting on it like people do.

"Are you going to be in a play?"

"People at work think I'm pregnant." I dabbed Nana's lips with a napkin, which came away pink with the lipstick she wears daily, even on days she doesn't leave her bed.

"And you haven't told them otherwise?"

"I'll correct them eventually."

"Pregnancy isn't like hepatitis. You can't clear it up so easy. It ends in a baby."

"I could borrow a baby if I needed one," I said, thinking about the aphid.

"People will find out, Louie. You'll embarrass yourself."

"Len and I have been talking about adoption," I said, which was technically true. We did talk about it, though at this point we weren't even talking that much. We sent sporadic texts—new restaurants worth trying, the dissolution of the Atlanta Silverbacks. Neither of us had suggested meeting up. Perhaps he was waiting for me. I was waiting for him. I felt a punch of sadness that Len wouldn't see me in the bump.

"Takes longer to adopt a kid than to grow one," Nana said. "If you need an excuse for medical leave, why not hemorrhoids, something nobody's going to ask you about?"

"This isn't about leave. It's a misunderstanding, that's all. It got out of hand."

She picked up her bowl and slurped the last of her broth. "Well, you better get it back in hand, Louie. Pregnancy is a temporary condition."

This is the way we spend our evenings, Nana and I.

I WAS SELF-CONSCIOUS my first day at work in the bump. I worried people would find the bulge at my abdomen too sudden, would sense it was a prosthetic and declare me a fraud. But no one mentioned the bump. In the developers' meeting, as we worked our way through a demo I'd helped debug, the head developer insisted I take the chair with extra back support. Julie nodded every time I passed her cube, little knowing nods that felt like friendship. She invited me to her Code Like a Mother support group. I declined. I was not a mother-to-be. The bump wasn't about motherhood. My pregnancy was an end in itself, the enactment of a ritual, and I approached it that way, as something real but apart, without the

purpose of a usual pregnancy. I had an urge to explain this to everyone, but I didn't. They wouldn't understand.

By the end of my first month with the bump, my backache was chronic, and the bump felt as familiar to me as my own breasts. It looked used, well loved, the silicone at the top-left edge repaired with a patch designed for inflatable pools. Weekly, I cleaned the bump with baby soap, patted it dry. Where the silicone rubbed, my skin blistered like feet in heels, blisters I soothed with Nana's ointment. This felt like a painful, necessary process, bringing me closer to the bump, opening my insides to it. I wore the bump even to bed, sleeping on my side, curled around it. I felt more at ease wearing it, more myself.

In month five, Julie wanted to throw me a shower. Julie's a great one for celebrations. She buys cheap soccer trophies, scrounges them from yard sales, and gives them away at staff meetings. Any excuse to fill a Thursday afternoon with cake and reusable bubble letters, and Julie seizes it.

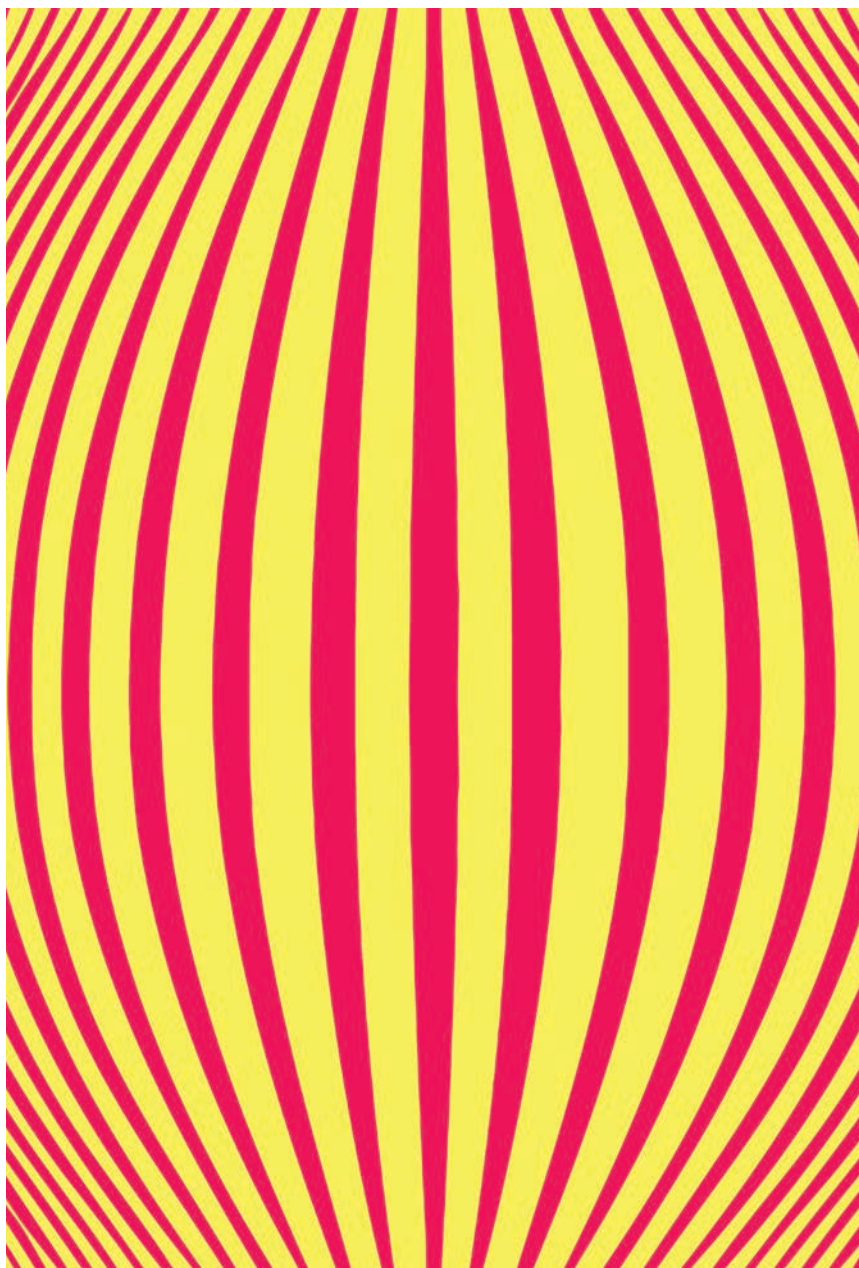
I told her I'd rather not have a shower. She said she understood, but later she emailed me a link to a website with various baby-shower themes. In the subject line, she'd written, "Which one?" I didn't respond. She sent me an email reminder for the week's Code Like a Mother gathering, which promised nonalcoholic schnapps and prenatal yoga.

That evening, as I bathed Nana, hunched over the bump, over the tub, I said, "It's almost like your great-grand-baby." The bump would have been her great-grandbaby. In the bathtub, Nana made a derisive sound. She dodged the cup of water I attempted to use to rinse her hair. I held the back of her neck to still her while I rinsed. When she climbed out of the tub, she put her hand on the bump. At first, I thought she just needed to steady herself, but it wasn't a steadying touch. It was a loving one.

I towed her head, trying to dissuade the thin strands of her hair from twisting into a cowlick. "I'd name it after you," I said. "If it was a baby."

She pulled her hand back from the bump. "Don't you start thinking that way."

"If," I said. I thought of the bump only as the bump. I understood the risk, the



delusion—and worse, the grief—inherent in thinking of it as anything else.

"I wanted another one," Nana said, wincing as I patted down her arms, though I was gentle. "After your father, I wanted a second one. We tried and tried." She touched the bump again.

"Nothing worked?"

"Back then, there weren't so many options. You could eat almonds. You could lie for hours after sex with your pelvis tilted back and a warm compress on your stomach. I did what I could, and that was that."

"I'm sorry."

"I'm glad. I'm glad we couldn't try and try like people these days, couldn't go broke trying, couldn't give whole years to it."

I felt a familiar skip of uncertainty, wondering if this was a criticism of me. "There's nothing wrong with options," I said.

"I wouldn't know. I'm just a country Cajun." This was a line Nana used when she wanted to duck an argument or some responsibility, like she'd been plucked against her will out of Louisiana, dropped into a city she couldn't possibly understand. She used it to avoid recycling and doctor appointments and public transportation of

any sort. “I’m just a country Cajun” seemed self-effacing but in fact worked as a defense, a statement of withdrawal and superiority, implying that we couldn’t understand each other, because I wasn’t a country Cajun. To Nana, I wasn’t Cajun at all.

“We could go back to Louisiana,” Nana said, her voice sly. “That would be one way to escape this pregnancy charade of yours.”

“It’s not a charade.”

“We could go to Louisiana. You could tell everyone you want to bring the baby up around family.”

She wanted to move back. She wanted to visit her husband’s grave. She wanted her funeral service held at the Rose Church, where she’d gone to Mass all her life. She wanted her remains interred in the mausoleum where her mother was interred. I wasn’t moving to Louisiana. If I moved, I was heading to the West Coast, where tech companies have enough trans employees to host their own support groups.

I said to Nana, “I don’t want to leave the city.” I rubbed ointment on her pressure sores. “I have a whole life here—a job, Len, friends at work, opportunities.”

“There’s no opportunity that will turn that bump into a baby.”

I paused, the ointment tube open in my hands. “What if it were true,” I said.

“You can’t get pregnant, Louie. You know that.”

I capped the ointment, took Nana’s nightgown from the hook, and slipped it over her head. “I’ve heard about a man born with a uterus,” I said. “A cis man. It’s not like it never happens.”

“You know you can’t get pregnant,” she said again.

“But if I could, what a thing.”

“You’re caught up,” Nana said. “Preoccupied with what you want.”

“I could be spending my evening in a thousand different ways,” I said, “and here I am taking care of you.” Nana didn’t reply. Nana was preoccupied with what she wanted too.

After Nana’s bath, I texted Len, asking if he’d like to meet up, then I logged on to my work email and accepted Julie’s invitation to Thursday’s Code Like a Mother meeting. I wanted it to be true, what I said to Nana. I wanted to feel I could spend my evening with Nana or on a date or holding

downward dog in a line of six women who were my friends.

Julie responded immediately with a GIF of a child jumping up and down, punching the air. Len took 12 hours, but then wrote back, “Saturday?”

JULIE’S CODE LIKE A MOTHER meetings took place at five in a windowless break room, the tables pushed against the walls to make space for yoga mats. The MotherCoders were six cis women in their late 30s and 40s, each recruited by Julie. The woman leading the yoga class had studied for 12 years at an ashram in California, paying for her teacher training by working remotely as a hacker for an American finance company.

I was the only one there with a bump. The hacker-yogi referred to me by saying, “Those who are expecting.” At first this annoyed me, but after a few minutes I started to think about my expectations: Being brought on full-time at work. Dating someone who wasn’t Len, someone who wasn’t married. Living with that person in a house without Nana, after Nana. When the hacker-yogi told us to visualize our intent for the practice, I closed my eyes and tried to really see those things, but the bump rose instead, came up before me like a snow moon on the horizon, huge and luminous, blocking everything else from view.

I opened my eyes to study the real bump in the narrow mirror that the hacker-yogi had brought so we could monitor our form. I watched myself move, and I experienced one of those precious moments in which I felt simply attractive—my clavicles delicate, my eyelashes long. Even my rosacea, which had flared as I sweat, gave me a glow. The bump moved with me, part of me. Not a false thing. A thing that served its own purpose, parallel to pregnancy, not a ghost of it, a different thing altogether.

At the hacker-yogi’s instruction, I bent into a forward fold, and it was then that something popped. At my shoulder, a pop. I expected pain, but there was no pain. Just the pop and a sudden looseness at my abdomen—and certainty, a mother’s certainty, that it was the bump. Sure enough, I felt the silicone peel away from my ribs, my body instinctively sucking in

a breath, which caused the silicone to peel away more quickly, sudden air sharp against skin that had been so long covered, and then the bump tipped forward, protruding oddly against my shirt. I clutched it, pressed it flat, and ran for the bathroom. I made it, just, and locked the door behind me. At the sink, one shoulder strap tore away completely, and the bump flapped forward, pocketing itself in my shirt—a sad, separate thing.

I took it off. The bump settled into the concavity of the sink. I envied the sink for so easily cupping it. How long did I stand there, considering the shape of my body, bumpless? Long enough that Julie was worried.

“Louie,” she called, knocking. “Louie, you okay?”

This is the moment I come back to, the moment I’d change. Writing it down like this, I am changing it. I’m walking over to that bathroom door and I’m swinging it open. Julie is looking between me and the bump—me, the bump. I look at Julie’s face.

Sometimes I see confusion there. Sometimes Julie watches me as I collapse in a jumble of pieces. Sometimes Julie takes up the bump without a word and helps me knot the broken shoulder strap to my bra, securing the bump, and when we’ve finished, she says, “Swiss bumps are sturdier.” Sometimes Julie laughs and laughs, and the other MotherCoders come and they laugh, and Julie takes the bump and tosses it up in the air, and the bump, miraculously light, arcs toward the ceiling and down, and then the hacker-yogi volleys it up again, and then the other women, and I run back and forth, trying to grab the bump, because every time they volley it upward, I feel the punch of their knuckles right in my abdomen. Sometimes, looking at my abdomen, Julie begins to scream, and I look down to see my shirt soaked with blood. I lift up my shirt to find a gaping wound, my abdomen skinless and bleeding, as if the bump has been sliced clean away, and I tell Julie to help me, bring me the bump, bring me a needle and thread, I will stitch the bump back to me, but Julie won’t come closer, so I’m left to stem the bleeding with the rough paper towels from the dispenser. I run through the whole roll.

Of course, this didn't happen. I didn't open the door. "I'm okay," I called to Julie.

"Are you sure? Should I phone someone for you?"

I tied the strap of the bump to my bra, the knot obvious beneath my tight shirt. It didn't need to hold forever, just long enough to thank Julie, get to my car. I exited the bathroom.

Julie immediately pressed me into a hug, which put her up against the bump. I felt it shift, slip a quarter inch against my skin, and I thought Julie would notice, but Julie just said, "You'll be fine, you know."

I repeated those words in the front seat of my car, having waved off Julie's offer to escort me to the parking lot. "You'll be fine," I told the bump, cranking up the air conditioner as high as it would go.

I drove home with one hand on the bump, cradling it against my body. The bump clung to me, but not like a child.

I WAS NO SEAMSTRESS, but I could patch. I could mend the bump. I took Friday off work, borrowed what I needed from Nana's sewing kit, and retreated to my room. The mending was a private thing—not shameful, but best handled alone, like applying cream to an abdominal rash. Besides, I wanted to spend the day with the bump, just the two of us. The bump wasn't what people thought, and that made it vulnerable. I wanted to keep the injured bump away from even Nana.

I threaded a size-11 needle and pieced the shoulder strap together with a mattress stitch, the stitch that surgeons use to minimize scarring when they piece together skin. I worked steadily, enjoying the task, and I discovered when I finished that I had done well. The bump was whole, the stitches barely visible.

I was to meet Len on Saturday at seven at a no-frills beer-and-wings joint, within walking distance of his house and a quick drive from mine. A significant choice, this restaurant. By suggesting it, Len had communicated his desire to make the reunion between us a nonevent. I parked on the street and sat, absently rubbing the bump, considering my options.

Impossible. It was impossible that Len didn't know about the bump. At 10 after, I got out of the car with the bump, walked to

the door of the restaurant. I saw Len, seated, waiting for me. I stood on the threshold, but I couldn't enter the restaurant with the bump. I couldn't explain the bump to him. He would think it was about Melinda and the aphid, about himself. He would think it was pathetic. I returned to the car.

Len texted, "Where are you?"

I crouched in the seat as if I were engaged in some secret, sneaky behavior, like changing my pants or fucking. I slipped out of the bump's harness.

Len texted, "You coming?"

I buckled the bump into the back seat. Not to protect it, but because I couldn't leave

*I didn't expect him
to notice the bump.
He never noticed
anything in the car
except the speed I was
driving and if the
cup holders were full,
which would inhibit
his drinking of an
after-work beer.*

it loose in the seat with all the other forgotten, unwanted items collected in transit.

Without the bump, my sweater hung almost to my knees. Agonizing flatness. Barrenness. I nearly climbed back in the car, plastered the bump back to my body, and drove away. But Len, too, needed me, was waiting inside for me like a boy and would feel a boy's embarrassment if I failed to show.

"I'll be right back," I said to the bump. I tapped the window twice in farewell.

Len looked up, relieved, when I paused at his table. "Thought you'd stood me up," he said.

Dinner was talk of his job and Melinda and the aphid. I tried to tell him about my

life, but every story I began led me back to the bump and so had to be left unfinished. After dinner, he suggested we walk along the Beltline. That would mean hours more away from the bump, hours more spent flat in public where anyone, someone from work even, could see me.

I suggested he come back to my place instead. If I was to be without the bump, I would rather be at home, unseen. I led him to my car, walking quickly to arrive before him. I checked on the bump, unclipped the seat belt fastened around it, which seemed, in his presence, to be indefensibly precious. I tossed a blanket over the bump, hiding it from him.

I didn't expect him to notice the bump. He never noticed anything in the car except the speed I was driving and if the cup holders were full, which would inhibit his drinking of an after-work beer. But on that drive, he decided he needed more legroom, and when he tried to put his seat back, the mechanism jammed, and he insisted over my protestations on taking his seat belt off, while we flew 75 down the highway, to figure out what had jammed it.

I put both hands on the wheel and said, "I slam on the brakes right now for any reason, and you go through the windshield. Is that what you want?"

"What's this?" He dug around behind his seat until it slid back all the way with a jolt that made him slip sideways onto the center console.

"What's this?" he said again, sitting back in the passenger seat with the bump, tired and worn as a child's doll, cradled in his hands. It felt like he had his hands on my belly, inside my belly, like he was mucking around with the organs in there.

"It's a pregnancy belly," I said. I didn't blush.

"Yours?"

"Whose else would it be?"

He laughed. "I've always wanted to wear one of these. Melinda told me to get one when she was in the thick of it."

"I don't want you to try it on," I said, attempting to head him off, because he was already slipping the patched shoulder strap over his arm.

"She didn't think I was sufficiently empathetic, Melinda."

"Don't try it on." He was working the old, beloved belt apart, looking at the fuzzy, mashed Velcro.

"You just strap it around your middle?"

"Please don't put it on."

"Why not?"

"It's not for you," I said. I took it from him, tried to shove it under the back seat, out of reach. The car swerved, and he braced himself against the dash and said, "Watch the road."

He recovered the belly from the back seat.

"It's broken," I said.

"That's okay. We're just having fun."

I sat silently, eyes on the road, while he strapped the belly over his button-down shirt. It looked absurd there, bare, cut off from the body.

He stretched and folded his arms behind his head, pleased with himself. When we pulled up to my apartment and stepped out of the car, he said, "Take a photo? For Melinda." He fished his cell-phone from his pocket, reaching awkwardly past the bump.

"It's dark," I said, but he posed—leaning against the car sideways, so the bump was visible, flashing a thumbs-up. A couple walking by grinned. Silly. They thought we were being silly the way people infatuated with each other are silly. I nearly reached over and tore the bump off him. Instead, I took his photo for Melinda—the bump, and his grin, and behind him the car and the night, a live photo in which the bump almost seemed to move.

Inside, Nana was playing double solitaire with a neighbor friend. Len, who was exasperated by Nana, who had told me multiple times that I should move her into assisted living, strutted past the women, hamming it up. They paused their game to grin and congratulate him. They wished they'd had a man who'd take turns. And who, they asked, was the father?

In my bedroom, he showed me Melinda's response to the photo of the bump—three laughing-with-tears emoji.

When the ache of the back belt got to be too much, Len took the bump off and handed it to me. I went to put it away in my closet, but he said, "Don't you want to wear it? Isn't the whole point of having it to wear it?"

"I don't want to wear it tonight."

"Come on. I want to see you in it."

Once I, too, had wanted him to see me in it. I remembered wanting that, a remembering so strong I could nearly convince myself that I wanted to wear it tonight, that this whole thing had been my idea.

I put it on in the bathroom, door closed, extra careful with the shoulder strap. When I came out, he whistled, and I almost took it off again, but he put his hands on the bump, and I could feel the vibration of his touch through the silicone, as if my nerves had extended into the bump, as if he were touching me.

I wore it as we watched two episodes of *Girls Get Arrested*. Downstairs, Nana's friend ran the disposal, saw Nana to her bedroom, let herself out the front door.

I felt different in the bump—because it was broken or because I was in front of him. It no longer felt a part of me. It was a prop, something to make him laugh, something for him to look at, and I wore it as we had sex, me telling him, "Be careful. It's fragile," but still by the time we'd finished, the shoulder strap had popped again and a tear had started in the back belt, and only the adhesive of sweat and silicone kept the bump suctioned against my body, and I got to thinking about the way this all would end.

I'd always known how it would end, but as I lay beside Len, the knowing became definite. I would take a week off in my seventh month. I would return with a flat abdomen and circles under my eyes. No one would ask what happened, ask me to confirm. Julie would circulate a card—something vague and reserved—*Our sympathies*. I tried to position this as a hopeful scenario.

Still, I felt not hopeful, but overwhelmingly lonely, a loneliness intensified by Len

having gone to sleep on his stomach beside me. I stood, holding the bump against me with one hand, and went downstairs, bent, clutching my abdomen in a sort of agony, as though holding on to a limb irreparably hewn from my body, unable yet to admit it was gone for good. I made my way through the quiet house to Nana's room.

There, I allowed the bump to peel away from my skin, hit the floor with a gentle bounce, inert, useless as a beetle on its back. I said, "Nana? You asleep?"

She *hmmmed*, groggy. "Who's that?"

"It's Louie. It's your grandbaby."

"My grandbaby. I must be getting old."

She was always disoriented at night. Her mind returned to her childhood. She scooted to the side and lifted the blanket for me, and I slid in beside her, on top of the crinkly absorbent pads. She said, "Where have you been, Gooch? You're pretty late getting home, aren't you? You better have a story or I'll tell Mama you've been with the boys."

I turned, and I cupped her, and I sobbed three sobs, which she felt in me, and she stroked my arm with her cold, corded hand, and she said, "One of them break your heart?" with the keen interest of a younger sibling.

I shook my head. It wasn't heartbreak. It was grief.

"Mama told me if you make too many tears at once, your eyeballs will float out of their sockets," Nana said.

IN MY SIXTH MONTH, Julie did throw me a surprise office shower with bubble letters strung together to spell CONGRATULATIONS. I wore the second, larger bump. My co-workers navigated around the bump to hug me. I was happy there, with them. It didn't feel like pretending. We might have been celebrating anything. *A*

Morgan Thomas is a writer from the Gulf Coast. Their debut short-story collection, Manywhere, will be published next year.



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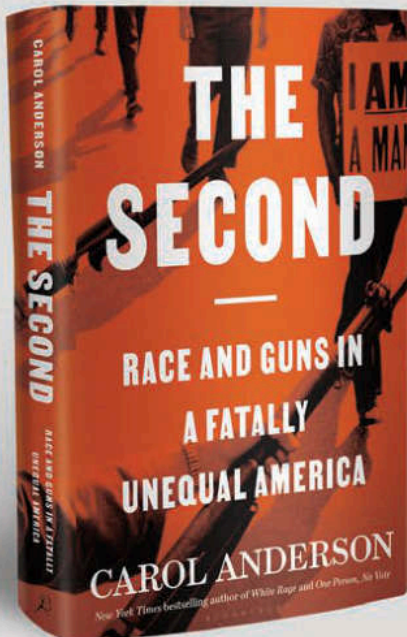
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*Lump in
my pocket;
buzz against
my thigh;*

beloved, clunky Kyocera flip phone, let me salute you.

I can't remember how long we've been together. Seven years? More? Even back then, you were retro. The salesman in the phone store spoke warmly of your indestructibility, as if that were your prime virtue: He said I could throw you against a wall if I wanted, and you'd just bounce off. But I would never do that.

Why can't I quit you? First, the obvious thing: You are not connected to the internet. So for me, you are a little ebony brick of privacy. And by *privacy* I don't mean cookies or my Social Security number or whatever—I mean the fragile sphere of imagination in which I exist when I'm not diddling about online. I mean what's left of my nondigital self. When I clack your two halves shut, you glorious technomollusk, that's it. Sauron cannot see me.

Second, you've become rather talismanic, socially. You stand for something. Perversity? Willed obsolescence? Sure, why not. It's like hanging around with a maladaptive friend: I enjoy watching people react to you. When I brandish you, flourish you, wield you in the world, I get exclamations of pity and confusion. Especially from the young. "Look at you, man," somebody said to me the other day when I took you out to exchange numbers. "*Look* at you."

We're out of the dream, you and me, out of the great swoon. When I have two spare minutes, I don't pull you out and stare at you, enchanted, moving my fingertips in tiny, silky swirls across your surface. I stand around like a spare part, hands in my pockets. I feel the stinky breeze on my face. I hear the caged hum of the city, the caged hum of my brain. I am present, however unsatisfactorily. Do I have the energy to send a text? I frown when I text. Sometimes I sweat. I smash your noisy little buttons; it sounds like I'm operating a telegraph. Three clicks to get to a *C*—*tack-tack-tack*—two more for an *E*. A decent sentence can take me 10 minutes. Anybody who gets a text from me knows I mean it.

What will I do when you go? Your name is Kyocera, king of kings. You are a black obelisk in the desert of Time. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

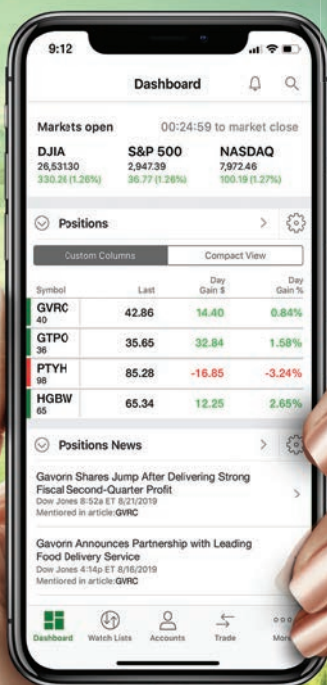
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By James Parker





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